The Royal Mage and the Golden Princess

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43554925.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M, Gen

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Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Perfuma (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

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The Royal Mage and the Golden Princess

by xSapphicPrincessesx (orphan_account)

Summary

"Glim, did you ever think about the day we met in the tower?" Adora asked, gazing into Glimmer's violet eyes.

"Yes," Glimmer replied, her thumbs rubbing small circles on Adora's hands.

Glimmadora Tangled AU, with some inspiration from Tangled: The Series.

Notes

This story is part of the LLF Comment Project, which was created to improve communication between readers and authors. This author invites and appreciates feedback, including:

- Short comments
- Long comments
- Questions
- Constructive criticism
- “<3” as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction

Prologue

Long ago, there were two vast kingdoms; Grayskull and Bright Moon. Both lands were rich in magic and wonder. Everyone lived in peace and harmony. For many years, the king and queen of Grayskull longed for a child. Their wish was granted, and they announced the news to their kingdom. A week before the child was born, the queen grew ill; she was running out of time. The king sent for every doctor, but no one had the cure. They needed a miracle. Or, in this case, a legendary golden flower. Its power was said to heal the sick and injured. King Randor ordered a search party to retrieve the magic flower. They were unaware of a woman hoarding its power.

The woman's name was Shadow Weaver. When she was younger, she unleashed a spell that backfired on her, granting her an irreversible curse. The curse made her age quicker and gave her a hideous appearance. It was the reason she traveled all the way to an isle to use the flower. That fateful night, the king's soldiers discovered a distant island, where a drop of sunlight had fallen. Shadow Weaver concealed the flower; her lantern bumped into the basket, knocking it over. The search party found the golden blossom and took it to Queen Marlena. Its magic healed her, and a week later, she gave birth to a baby girl. She named her Adora.

Adora was born with long, golden hair. Her eyes were the color of a bright summer day, filled with happiness and wonder. Everyone in the kingdom adored her. When evening came, King Randor and Queen Marlena released lanterns into the sky. For a moment, everything was perfect. But it wouldn't last long. Later at night, when everyone was sleeping, Shadow Weaver snuck into the castle and approached the crib. She sang a special song.

Flower, gleam and glow

Let your power shine

Make the clock reverse

Bring back what once was mine

What once was mine

As Shadow Weaver finished singing, her hair darkened from gray to ebony. Dark veins on her temples disappeared; her nose and chin reverted to their former shapes. Multiple scars vanished. Cutting the girl's hair, she took a small piece. The strand turned dark blonde in her hand. She knew what to do. By the time the king and queen awakened to Adora's cry, it was too late. Shadow Weaver had stolen the princess. The soldiers of Grayskull searched every inch of the land, but they couldn't find the lost princess. A year later, Queen Marlena gave birth to a prince. His name was Adam. Worried that something could happen to him, the king and queen ordered the guards to watch every entrance and exit.

In the same year, when winter had blanketed both kingdoms, Queen Angella and King Micah of Bright Moon welcomed a princess into their family. They named her Glimmer. The princess inherited her powers from her father. Everyone in the kingdom celebrated her birth. One day, when Glimmer was seven, her father charged into battle and died. Since then, Queen Angella had been ruling Bright Moon by herself.

Deep in the forest, in a hidden tower, Shadow Weaver had been raising Adora as her own. The child asked questions about the strict rules. Adora dreamed of seeing the floating lights in person, and of exploring the world. The paints and books weren't enough to entertain her, much to Shadow Weaver's irritation. Weaver was determined to keep her flower a secret, and she didn't want to let Adora go outside, ever.

"Mommy," Adora said one night as her mother brushed her hair.

"Yes, flower?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Why can't I go outside?"

"The outside world is a dangerous place, my dear. There are horrible and selfish people." Shadow Weaver was playing the part of an overprotective mother. "You must stay here, where you're safe. Do you understand?"

Adora frowned. "Yes, mommy." Her world was restricted to three small rooms, and they couldn't contain her imagination. Staying inside all the time was boring. No matter how dangerous her mother said the outside world was, she wanted to feel the grass beneath her feet and splash in the ponds. The orange and yellow lights in the sky only fueled her desire to venture into the outdoors.

The walls of the tower could not hide everything. Every year on Adora's birthday, King Randor and Queen Marlena launched thousands of lanterns into the sky in hope that one day, the lost princess would return.

An Annual Thing

The rays of dawn streamed into the windows. Adora began doing her chores; cleaning, sweeping, and mopping. She had spent eighteen years of her life inside the tower, forbidden from going outside. Her mother, Shadow Weaver, and her bird, Kowl, were the only ones keeping her company. To keep her mind off the outdoors, she would paint every wall and read countless books. She had read stories of princesses, knights, distant kingdoms, and dragons multiple times. Shadow Weaver had returned some books to the library. One of them told a story of a female warrior who protected the world from evil. It was her favorite. When she was twelve, she painted a picture of her favorite characters hugging each other. Both characters were female; a blonde and a pink-haired princess. She used to harbor a crush on the latter.

Adora brushed her hair, all seventy feet of it. It was a lot of work to maintain, but she never cut it. Neither did her mother. Staring into the mirror, she scrutinized her reflection; a red dress with white sleeves, the subtle dusting of freckles on her nose and cheeks, and rosy lips. According to Shadow Weaver, the dress was the only thing Adora could wear. She wanted to wear something different for once. The older woman's words replayed in her mind...

You're getting chubby.

Did I see a pimple on your chin?

How are you still sloppy?

Adora sighed. Why couldn't she look good? She placed the brush onto the dresser and patted her waist. Had she gained weight from eating every food she made? It was hard to tell. Perhaps she should stick with her dress for now. Pushing her thoughts aside, she glanced at Kowl.

"This is it. I'm going to ask her. Besides, tomorrow's my birthday," Adora said.

The castle courtyard was peaceful, save for a pair of women.

And they were sparring. Glimmer pressed her staff against Catra's, grunting as she struggled to "defeat" her opponent. Catra shoved her backward; Glimmer's spine met the ground. This was why she preferred magic; a foe could take her by surprise. Magic would give its user an advantage over their enemy. Forcing herself up, she glared at Catra. Sometimes the brunette could be quite infuriating. If it weren't for the chancellor's presence in the castle, she wouldn't have to see Catra as much. Releasing a feral yell, Glimmer swung her staff at Catra's leg. The magicat parried the blow.

Glimmer traced a rune in the air and blew on it.

A gust of air knocked Catra off her feet; she fell onto the ground. "Sparkles! You cheated!"

Glimmer placed her hands onto her hips. "If you can fight someone who's holding a staff or a sword, you can handle fighting a powerful mage."

Catra rose to her height. "I've seen enough magic for today."

"I didn't think I would hear that coming from a tough warrior."

Glimmer strode into the castle, navigated the hallways, and entered a library. A leather spellbook lingered on a mahogany desk; she moved closer and opened the book. Its spine was well-worn from years of use, and spellcasting instructions filled every page. There was still a lot more she hadn't learned or mastered. For example, teleportation. Sometimes, when she reappeared in a different area, she would collide against the ground. Flipping the pages, she pored over the text. She already knew the air spell and the teleportation one; it would be nice to learn something new. The door creaked open, garnering her attention.

"This used to be your father's spellbook," Castaspella said as she approached the desk.

"No wonder it looked worn," Glimmer said. "I have a question about spellcasting. Why is dark magic forbidden?"

"Because dark magic corrupts its user. A sorceress once practiced dark magic in secret. Shadow Weaver; a scar on Mystacor Academy's past. She was your father's teacher."

"Why would my father want to learn from her?"

"He didn't know what she was doing. No one knew, until Norwyn discovered the truth. Shadow Weaver argued with the council, and in a fit of rage, she attempted to hurt them with a dark spell. The spell failed, resulting in a curse that uglified her and made her age quicker. She left the academy and never returned. Some say she has searched for a golden flower."

"Adora! Let down your hair!" A voice shouted from the base of the tower.

"Coming, mother!" Adora replied as she raced to the window and looped her hair around a hook. Then, her hair cascaded down the tower.

Shadow Weaver grabbed the bottom section and slid her foot in. The younger woman pulled her upward. It was a lot of effort, but Adora had no desire to give her mother an attitude. Especially not when she wanted to ask about the floating lights. The sorceress reached the windowsill and made her way into the tower. Shadow Weaver removed the hood, revealing gray strands in her hair. Her appearance had changed; crooked nose, protruding chin, dark veins on temples, sunken cheeks, and pale skin. Weaver's face reminded Adora of the illustrations in books about wicked witches. Still, her mother wasn't wicked.

"You won't believe the dangers I have faced on the way home!" Shadow Weaver exclaimed. "This is why you shouldn't complain."

"My birthday is tomorrow, and-" Adora began.

"Oh, it can't be. I'm sure it was last year."

"Birthdays are an annual thing. The lights-"

"Flower, would you sing for me?" Shadow Weaver plopped into a chair. "I'm feeling worn down."

"Of course!" Adora rushed to grab the brush and a stool, then placed the stool in front of her mother. Before the older woman could begin brushing, she sang as quick as possible.

"Adora, why are you in a hurry?"

"So, as I was saying, the floating lights will show up tomorrow. I want to go see them in person."

Shadow Weaver pinched the bridge of her nose. "Oh, you mean the stars."

Adora shook her head. "They're not stars. Every year on my birthday, they appear. I think they're meant for me, and I have to know what they are."

"My flower, you know the rules."

"But-"

"I knew you'd want to leave the nest. Knew this day was coming. As long as you're safe inside the tower, no harm will come to you."

"We could go together-"

"No. You must listen to me. Mother knows best. It's a scary world out there, and I don't want to see you get hurt. Do you know what happens to delicate flowers if they're on their own? They perish." Shadow Weaver's voice took on an ominous tone.

"Something will go wrong. Ruffians, thugs, and people with pointy teeth. Monsters, quicksand, and snakes."

Adora sighed. "That's why I suggested-"

Shadow Weaver stood, then made her way to the kitchen. "I know it sounds disappointing, but I made those rules because I love you. After all, my dear, you're special. I have one request. Don't ever ask to leave this tower again."

"Yes, mother," Adora said.

"I love you very much," Shadow Weaver replied.

"I love you more."

"I love you most." Shadow Weaver grabbed a basket. "I'll see you in a bit."

"Okay."

Adora walked to the window, looped her hair around the hook, and lowered her mother. She rested her elbows on the windowsill, staring at the trees. A cool breeze rippled through her hair as she lingered. It wasn't fair, being told "no" in response to her question. Was the world truly that dangerous? Or could her mother be exaggerating? She could ask again later. Perhaps her mother could say yes. A small part of her doubted it.

After Castaspella left the castle to check on Mystacor Academy, Glimmer rode Swift Wind into the village. Queen Angella had told her to avoid straying into the woods. There was one problem with the warning; not every part of the forest was unsafe. There was a small section of the woods, Plumeria Forest, where fairies, elves, and hybrids lived. Perfuma was their princess. Speaking of Perfuma, the blonde hadn't left Plumeria Forest for a while. According to the fairy princess, a dark mage had attacked Plumeria Forest, and its residents had to recover. Glimmer made

her way to the village square and dismounted the horse. A familiar blonde man stood by the fountain, talking to Bow.

"My sister has been gone for eighteen years," Adam said. "Tomorrow, she turns eighteen. As usual, we'll launch the lanterns into the sky. She hasn't returned. I want to know if she's alive or not, and if she's safe."

"So, what do you want to do?" Bow asked.

"I'll search for her. My parents told me not to travel alone, so maybe you could come with me."

"Where do you plan to go?"

"The woods. Many Grayskull soldiers didn't find my sister. A few tried, but an enemy attacked them."

Glimmer approached them. "Hey, Bow. I heard what you guys were saying about the woods. Do you think we could stop by Plumeria Forest and say hi to Perfuma?"

Bow glanced at Glimmer. "Sure. I was going to see Perfuma anyways. Just be careful. Your mother doesn't want you to get hurt."

"I'll be fine." Glimmer walked over to Swift Wind and mounted him. "I know a few spells."

Adam and Bow mounted their respective horses. Adam said, "Let's go while there's still light."

They rode out of the village, moving along the dirt road. A distant line of trees came into view. For thirty minutes, the trio held a conversation. Glimmer gazed at the clouds. It was a clear day, with a few clouds gliding across the bright blue expanse. The sun moved toward the middle of the sky. Her thoughts drifted to the story of the lost princess. Was the princess locked away in a tower, unaware of her real family? How would Adam's sister feel about the truth?

The horses galloped into the woods. Twigs and leaves crunched beneath their hooves as they made their way into Plumeria Forest. Several scents wafted into Glimmer's nostrils; patchouli, sandalwood, and wildflowers. Vines dangled from low-hanging branches. Plumeria Forest was bustling with life. Sprites danced over a small pond, pixies tended to flowers, and elves sat by the water. A tanned woman with freckles and blonde hair waved at the group. Perfuma wore a smile.

"I'm so glad to see you! How are you these days?" Perfuma asked.

"I'm good. Is Plumeria doing alright?" Bow replied.

"Yes. Some fairies and elves are keeping watch." Perfuma turned her attention to Glimmer. "Hello, Glimmer! How are you?"

"Fine," Glimmer said. "We're exploring the woods. You know about plants, right?"

Perfuma nodded. "Of course. Why do you ask?"

"Is the golden flower real?"

"It is. A drop of sunlight fell onto an isle some hundred years ago, forming a flower. Eighteen years ago, it healed the Queen of Grayskull." Perfuma clasped her hands together. "Not every plant has magic, but they can have healing properties."

"Anyways..." Glimmer thought of the attack on Plumeria Forest. "Did you find out the name of the dark mage?"

"No. They didn't reveal their face, either."

Glimmer peeked at the forest ceiling. She could see patches of the sky. Was it noon right now? It was hard to tell. "We may have to get going. Our friend, Adam, wants to look for his missing sister."

"Okay. You guys be safe. Whoever the mage is, they're vicious."

The group made their way out of Plumeria Forest. Glimmer scrutinized her surroundings. Who invaded Plumeria Forest? Could it be Shadow Weaver or someone similar? The wind whistled around the trunks. Birds chirped as they flew to a branch. An earthy smell lingered in the air as butterflies hovered over a rosebush. Glimmer kept her eyes peeled for lurking enemies. So far, she didn't see anything out of the ordinary. From time to time, the bushes rustled, prompting the trio anticipate an ambush. Yet the only creatures they ran into were bunnies, deer, and squirrels.

"We could split up," Adam suggested. "Once we're done searching, we'll gather by Plumeria Forest."

"I'll go with Glimmer in case something happens," Bow replied.

The group parted ways; Adam moved toward the left path, while Glimmer and Bow continued down the middle path. The trail led them to a wall of stone. Glimmer's gaze flitted up and down the wall. Its cliff would probably lead them to the mountains or deeper into the woods. She glanced at a smaller wall. Was there a way around both walls? She dismounted Swift Wind and stepped closer. There had to be something. If the duo wasn't careful, they could get lost.

Glimmer approached the opposite side of the wall. A curtain of greenery swayed in the breeze; she plunged her hands through the curtain. All her hands found was air. Was it an opening? Stepping through the greenery, she entered a cave. Would she find anything in here? It wasn't as if the lost princess was hiding in a cave. Light streamed into the other side, drawing her to the exit. Footsteps thudded behind her, and she whirled around.

"Glimmer, I hope we're not getting lost," Bow said.

They stumbled into a field of waterfalls, ponds, and grass. Glimmer pointed to a tall structure. It was a tower, probably seventy feet tall. Had it been isolated from the rest of the world? Did someone live here? There was one way to find out.

"We're getting in there," Glimmer said.

Towers and Secrets

Chapter Notes

Catra's POV shows up in this chapter.

Once Glimmer and Bow approached the base of the tower, the archer shot an arrow at a hook above the window. The arrow transformed into a long rope and looped around the hook. Bow tugged on the rope, as if making sure it could hold his weight. He began scaling the tower. Glimmer debated climbing while he was still ascending. Would the rope give way if there were two people climbing at the same time? Maybe it would budge. Or it could stay put. She wasn't sure which one was a more likely outcome. As Bow entered the tower, Glimmer grabbed the rope and began her ascent. It didn't take long for her to reach the window and sneak into the tower. What she saw on the floor shocked her; Bow was unconscious. A figure hid behind a chair, accompanied by a trail of long blonde hair.

"Show yourself," Glimmer said.

There was no verbal response. The chair skidded forward, then stopped. Glimmer saw a woman's face peeking out from behind the chair. Steel blue eyes widened, and the blonde's face paled. Was the woman afraid? She wasn't here to scare this person. Still, the tower didn't have a front door, so she and Bow had to find another way in. Now they were in here, dealing with a frightened girl. The blonde stepped out of her hiding place, holding out a frying pan as though it was a sword. *Is she using it as a weapon?* If the situation wasn't tense, she would chuckle. She had never seen anyone use a pan to defend themselves.

The woman was taller than Glimmer, and her body was slightly toned. A red dress accentuated the blonde's waist; its skirt stopped at her ankles. She didn't wear any shoes. Did she have something against footwear?

"Who are you?" The blonde asked. "How... how did you find me?"

"What happened to Bow?" Glimmer replied.

"He'll be fine. I don't want to hurt you."

"Since when did you not want to hurt anyone?" Glimmer narrowed her eyes. Should she use the air rune again? "I'm a mage, so you better not mess with me."

"Can you answer my question?" The blonde lowered her brows. "My mother will be home soon, and-"

"You want an answer? Well, I'm Glimmer, and this is Bow. We were exploring the woods with a friend, and we found the tower."

"A likely story. Where's your friend now?"

"He's supposed to meet us by Plumeria Forest later. Blondie, if you-"

"It's Adora."

"Adora, if you try anything funny, I'll-"

A shout interrupted their conversation. Several minutes blurred by as Adora stuffed Bow into the wardrobe and led a reluctant Glimmer into a bedroom, telling her to hide. The blonde's reason for this? Adora's mother would be mad upon seeing a pair of visitors. Releasing an annoyed sigh, Glimmer watched Adora leave the room. The furniture in here was gorgeous; a red canopy bed, mahogany nightstands, and a small desk with various sketches. She tip-toed toward the door and caught snatches of voices. One of them belonged to a woman she had never met.

"I'm making hazelnut soup for dinner. Consider it a birthday gift," Shadow Weaver said as she unwrapped a basket of hazelnuts and parsnips. "I hate leaving after an argument. Even when I've done nothing wrong."

Adora chewed her bottom lip. It had been a close call; if her mother had seen the intruders, the older woman would think she was irresponsible. She could handle herself, though. Her mother didn't see her as a capable woman who could take out a thief with a frying pan. Hopefully, the two thugs would remain silent. If they made a sound, it would be a matter of time before Shadow Weaver discovered their presence. Her thoughts drifted to Glimmer. The short woman was beautiful; pink and purple hair, violet eyes, a lavender tunic, and purple leggings. She kept in mind that Glimmer had broken into her home.

"You think I can't handle myself out there-" Adora began.

"You're not strong enough to defend yourself," Shadow Weaver interrupted.

"But if you just-"

"Don't whine, my flower. If you're so desperate to see the stars, why don't you paint-"

"I have painted so many pictures of the lights. We could go-"

"Adora!" Shadow Weaver's voice took on a stern tone as she stepped toward Adora. "ENOUGH WITH THE LIGHTS! YOU SHALL NEVER LEAVE THE TOWER! So stop being ungrateful!"

Adora flinched, then backed away.

"Now I'm the bad guy." Shadow Weaver occupied an empty chair, massaging her temples. "I hate yelling, but I made those rules for your protection."

"Sorry, mother. I want something else now," Adora said. "Can you get the white shells? Their paints are the best."

"Oh, Adora..." Shadow Weaver made eye contact. "It's a long trip. Three days, to be exact. Are you sure you'll be okay by yourself?"

"Yes."

"I'll miss you. You're a special girl."

Adora gathered fruits, cheese, and other snacks and wrapped them in the basket. It might seem like a lot for three days, but it wouldn't hurt for her mother to be prepared. She handed the basket to Shadow Weaver. The older woman pulled her into an embrace, stroking her blonde locks.

"I love you very much," Shadow Weaver said.

"I love you more," Adora replied.

"I love you most."

"Bye."

Once Shadow Weaver left the tower, Adora raced to the wardrobe and pulled Bow out. Now he was on the floor. She said, "Glimmer, my mother left! You can leave my bedroom!"

Glimmer emerged from the room and descended the stairs. "Did I hear your mother yelling?"

Kowl landed next to Bow and emitted a loud chirp, awakening him.

"Yes," Adora said. "She got mad over the lights."

"What lights?" Bow asked as he stood, rubbing the back of his head and grimacing.

Another chirp drew Adora's attention. Kowl moved a wing to his bottom beak, as if telling her to check for sharp teeth. Or, at least, ask the intruders if they did. Adora glanced at the duo.

"Do you guys have sharp teeth?" Adora asked. "Another thing... are you here to steal my hair?"

Glimmer shook her head. "We don't have sharp teeth." She pointed to her teeth. "Also, we're not going to touch your hair."

Adora beckoned Kowl closer, and they whirled around. "I want someone to take me, since my mother won't. Bow and Glimmer do not have fangs."

Kowl let out a dozen chirps.

"I know, I know! But what choice do I have?" Adora said.

Adora turned to face Glimmer and Bow. "I'll tell you something." She walked to the left side of the tower, hopped onto a ledge, and pulled back a red curtain. "Look this way." She pointed at a painting of orange and yellow lights. "Do you know what these are?"

"The lanterns that Prince Adam of Grayskull talks about?" Glimmer answered. "Every year on his sister's birthday, Adam and his parents would launch tons of lanterns into the sky."

Lanterns. I knew they weren't stars.

"They're hoping the lost princess will return home one day," Bow added.

Adora cleared her throat. "Glimmer, Bow, I want you to guide me to see the lanterns tomorrow evening. After I see them in person, you will bring me home safely."

Glimmer furrowed her brows. "Are you sure? Bow and I will meet Adam by Plumeria Forest after we leave the tower."

"Yes. Tomorrow's my birthday, and I've never gone outside."

"How old will you be?"

"Eighteen." Adora jumped off the ledge. "Something brought you here. Call it what you will. Fate, destiny-"

"My curiosity. And Bow's arrow."

"I have made the decision to trust you."

Glimmer shrugged. "We don't get into Grayskull much. The woods can be confusing, so..."

Adora crossed her arms. "Are you saying no? My mother already told me no. I can't go outside by myself. Something could happen to me."

"Fine." Glimmer sighed. "We'll take you."

Catra made her way into the dungeon. Hordak had asked her to meet in his secret room. Usually, she wasn't allowed to go in there, but today, he wanted to talk to her. The dungeon reeked of feces and mildew. Of all the places in the castle, this area was the worst. No one ever kept it clean. She swore she had passed by a skeleton at one point. Rats skittered across the stone floor, squeaking as they moved. She navigated a dim passageway that led her to a large wooden door. This was where Hordak's secret room was, right?

Taking in a deep breath, Catra stepped into the room. Her gaze flitted around the room. Potion bottles cluttered the shelves. Had Hordak ever considered using a cabinet or some kind of storage? A familiar figure lingered by a mirror. Flicking her tail to one side, she stepped closer. Hordak wore a black outfit underneath a red cape. The dark colors made him appear paler. Hordak's expression was neutral instead of the usual menacing scowl.

"I have spoken to Queen Angella regarding the war," Hordak said.

"What did she say?" Catra asked.

"She will prepare for tonight." Hordak strode to the desk. "I have spoken with the Horde forces. They will send their assassins to kill the queen."

"And just like that?" Catra scoffed. "You'll attempt to take the throne? What will you do about the princess? She's a mage."

"A mage who isn't powerful."

"Are you sure she isn't?" Catra recalled Glimmer's spell. "Princess Glimmer used air magic on me."

The mirror emitted a green glow. Was it enchanted? Catra walked over to the mirror and scrutinized the reflection. "Has your mirror always done that? I saw a green glow."

"Leave the mirror alone." Hordak approached Catra from behind. "The green glow was a figment of your imagination."

Catra whirled around. "I know what I saw. I have a question. Will anyone know what happens to Queen Angella?"

"Not if we're subtle. Don't tell anyone. Our meeting is over."

Catra nodded, then proceeded into the passageway. She replayed the conversation in her mind. Wouldn't the queen figure out what Hordak could be planning? And why did he assume the mirror's light was a figment of her imagination? Did he not see what was going on with the mirror? Was he hiding something? Time dragged on as she wandered through the dungeon. A few guards walked past her. They were probably here to check on prisoners. She ascended the stairs to the first floor of the castle, ambled down several hallways, and reached the second floor, where the throne room was. But she wouldn't go there unless the queen requested her presence.

Speaking of the queen, Angella was chatting with a group of guards. The queen told them to check on Glimmer and keep her safe. Catra wished her adoptive mother would care about her as much as Angella cared about Glimmer. When she was a toddler, her former guardian abandoned her at an orphanage. According to Shakra, a woman who ran the orphanage, Catra's adoptive mother didn't want her anymore. A vague memory of the uncaring woman surfaced; gray strands in ebony hair, a hideous face, and a cruel personality.

Catra dug her claws into her palms in an effort to quell the shaking in her hands. It hurt to think about her childhood. She

would rather not remember any of it. Muttering under her breath, she strode into the training room, where the knights would practice their sword-fighting skills on dummies. Fortunately, no one was in here to witness a certain magicat's tears. She grabbed a staff and clobbered a dummy. Tears burned her eyes as she swung at this thing countless times, imagining herself fighting the woman who left her.

"Why did you leave me?!" Catra blurted out. "What did I ever do wrong? Do you not love me anymore?" Hot tears streamed down her cheeks.

"Hey, Wildcat," a feminine voice said.

Catra wiped her cheeks, then turned around and wore a stoic expression. Scorpia was smiling. It took all her energy to not lash out at the muscular woman and give in to a breakdown.

"Hello, Scorpia," Catra said in a shaky tone.

"Are you free to talk?"

"I'm a little busy at the moment."

"Oh." Scorpia's face fell. "I was hoping we could hang out. You know, going someplace and enjoying ourselves..."

"We're talking to each other, so it counts as hanging out. No need to take it personally."

"I've never seen you take a break from your duties. Even when the princess isn't home, you're still working nonstop."

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "Quit badgering me!"

Scorpia backed out of the room. "Sorry, Wildcat. Maybe later?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "We'll see."

Adora was outside at last. She hoped it wasn't a dream. The sensation of soft grass beneath her feet and the wind tickling her face felt real. Gathering a bouquet of bell-shaped flowers, she ran toward the pond and splashed in the water. Her life had finally begun. A thought snuck into her mind; what if she liked the outside world too much to go back? Her mother wouldn't be happy. Also, Shadow Weaver would grow old and ugly without the magic of Adora's hair.

"I can't believe you've never gone outside," Glimmer said.

"Mother kept me inside for my safety," Adora replied.

"Isn't that a little extreme?"

Adora followed Glimmer and Bow through a cave. "Let me guess. You've never been forbidden from going outside your entire life."

Glimmer shook her head. "No, but my mother was still protective of me. She didn't want to lose me the way she lost my father."

"Anyways, what is Prince Adam like?"

"He's nice. By the way, you kind of resemble him."

"Does he have long hair?"

Glimmer chortled. "No. You two have the same face shape and eye color."

Adora's heart skipped a beat. The shorter woman's laughter was cute; it was a sound she would never forget. Heat flooded her cheeks as she averted Glimmer's gaze. Twisting a blonde strand around her finger, she let out a soft chuckle. She had confronted a pair of strangers, gotten yelled at, and snuck out of the tower. Yet she couldn't come up with a response due to her brain short-circuiting. All she could do, however, was smile.

Danger Lurks in the Shadows

For the rest of the journey to meet Adam near Plumeria Forest, Glimmer and Adora rode Swift Wind together. Initially, Adora had been unsure about riding a horse, but Glimmer had helped her overcome her fear of riding Swift Wind. At times, the blonde would flinch at subtle sounds. Glimmer observed the area, watching for potential threats. Trees swayed in the wind, shaking the leaves off their branches. The bushes rustled, eliciting a gasp from Adora's lips as she tightened her hold on Glimmer.

"Is it ruffians? Thugs?" Adora asked.

Glimmer glowered at the bushes. "I'm not sure." She traced a rune in the air. "But I'm not letting anything bad happen to you."

A bunny emerged. Glimmer allowed the rune to vanish. There was no reason to cast a wind spell on a defenseless animal. "The bunny can smell fear. For real, though, it's not dangerous."

A pained scream penetrated the forest. What happened? Did someone get hurt? Bow rode his horse toward a path, then said, "I think it's Adam. I'll go check on him."

"We don't know what we're dealing with," Glimmer said.

"I know, which is why you can't get hurt."

The trio made their way to a clearing. What Glimmer saw shocked her; Adam lay on the ground, unconscious. A pool of blood darkened the lower part of his shirt. Who attacked him? The same person who invaded Plumeria Forest? Bow dismounted his horse and approached Adam's.

"Cringer, don't be afraid," Bow said as he placed a hand onto the horse's snout.

The horse lowered its head.

"Let's take Adam to Grayskull Castle." Bow walked over to Adam, then slipped his hands beneath the prince's armpits and dragged him toward Cringer. He turned his attention to Glimmer. "You take Adora to safety."

Swift Wind's ears flattened against his head as he nickered. Glimmer patted his neck and glanced over her shoulder. Adora was looking around in various directions. Whoever attacked Adam and Plumeria Forest was probably lurking in the shadows. Glimmer rode Swift Wind through Plumeria Forest, passing by ponds, sprites, and vines. Perfuma stood by the water, talking to elves and fairies.

"Do you think a ruffian or a thug hurt Adam?" Adora asked.

"I think it was a dark mage. They also attacked Plumeria Forest," Glimmer said.

"Are we going the right way?"

"We may have to find another way into Grayskull."

"Oh."

Glimmer swore she heard a tinge of disappointment in Adora's voice. Was the blonde losing trust in her? A half hour passed as they continued their journey in silence. Swift Wind trotted out of the woods and moved along the dirt road. Once again, she was in Bright Moon. Her stomach rumbled. Perhaps they could stop somewhere for lunch, or visit the castle to see how things were going. She would have to explain to Angella about Bow's absence.

"Mother would be so furious," Adora said.

Glimmer thought of the woman who shouted at Adora in the tower. "Maybe she would, but there's nothing wrong with a little rebellion. Sometimes rules are made to be broken."

"You think?"

"Yes. We're on an adventure. Kind of."

The village came into view. At this time of day, the town was busy; children played in the streets, adults rushed past buildings, and merchants advertised their wares. Swift Wind carried Glimmer and Adora into the village. Scents of baked goods and fresh food wafted into Glimmer's nose. When the women arrived in the town center, they dismounted Swift Wind. Adora gathered all seventy feet of hair into her arms. Wasn't there a better way to keep it off the ground? Or did Adora have to carry her hair?

"You want to eat something?" Glimmer asked.

"Yeah. I forgot to pack some food," Adora said.

"It's okay. We were going to leave the tower either way."

They approached a food stall and bought a basket of bread, cheese, fruit, and pastries. Several people in the crowd seemed to recognize Glimmer. A few of them gawked at Adora, as though they were wondering why the girl's hair was super long. Adora hid behind Glimmer. Did the stares make the blonde feel uncomfortable?

"Can you stop staring at Adora?" Glimmer asked the crowd. "It's making her nervous."

Dozens of people looked the other way, continuing with their activities. Glimmer led Adora to a quieter part of town, where there weren't too many people around. They occupied a table and began eating lunch. Adora dug into her food, as though she had been starving. On the other hand, Glimmer took a small bite out of an apple and munched on it. Did the girl not eat much? Adora tried to speak with a mouthful of food, but Glimmer told her to swallow first.

"Sorry," Adora said. "Anyways, thanks for telling people to stop staring at me."

"No problem. I guess they've never seen anyone with seventy feet of hair," Glimmer said.

"I'm sure they haven't."

Glimmer bit off a piece of a jelly-filled pastry, savoring the tart strawberry flavor. Footsteps hurried past the table. Laughter penetrated the air, and a bark garnered her attention. A little girl was chasing a dog. Adora mentioned the dog's cuteness. A ray of sunlight illuminated her hair, forming a halo.

"So, tell me about yourself," Glimmer said.

Adora sighed. "Where can I start?"

"What is it like to be stuck in the tower your whole life?"

"It was boring. I spent my free time reading, painting, brushing my hair, and cooking, so it's not that bad. Also..." Adora gestured at her bird. "I have Kowl."

Glimmer leaned forward. "You read books?"

"Yes. My favorite is a children's book called 'She-Ra.' The main character is a warrior princess who protects the world from evil. I was devastated when my mother returned that book to the library. Do you have a favorite story?"

Glimmer nodded. "I used to read about the adventures of a boy, his half-brother, and their elf friend. The story has dragons in it."

"Sounds cool."

"It is." Glimmer rose to her height. "I'm going to the castle. Are you coming?"

"Of course." Adora dropped the leftover food into the basket. "Do you live in the castle?"

"Yes. I'm the Princess of Bright Moon." Glimmer picked up the basket. "My mother, Angella, is the queen."

Shadow Weaver pulled her cloak tighter as she wandered along the trail. She could have gone a little farther if the blonde man hadn't attempted to hinder her. For years, she had put in all her energy into keeping the tower a secret. Besides, no one should steal her flower. And speaking of flowers... Her footsteps halted. Had someone found Adora? Was she safe? She whirled around and raced all the way to the tower, forgetting about her three-day journey. Had she overlooked something? Did someone discover a path to the tower? By the time she arrived at the tower, she looked up at the window.

"Adora! Let down your hair!" Shadow Weaver shouted.

This time, no waterfall of golden hair cascaded down the tower. Shadow Weaver hurried to the back of the structure. She pulled the vines and bricks apart, revealing a door. If Adora was gone, and if someone told her flower the truth, the girl wouldn't return. As a result, she would grow old and ugly in a matter of minutes. She ascended the stairs, shoved the floor tile out of the way, and pushed herself into the main room. Silence blanketed her home. No sign of Adora.

Shadow Weaver checked the kitchen and the bathroom. Then, she rushed into her bedroom. It was untouched; even her potions, bottled plants, and spellbook were left alone. Her room had always been off-limits to Adora, although the girl once snuck in and opened her journal. She made her way to Adora's room and yanked the covers off the bed. Instead of the familiar locks of golden hair, she found a pile of pillows. Cursing under her breath, she checked the tower again. And she couldn't find Adora. Her flower was gone.

An idea surfaced. Shadow Weaver returned to her room, gathered several ingredients, and tossed them into her small cauldron. The water bubbled and hissed, changing its color as she grabbed an

empty bottle and scooped the liquid with a wooden ladle. After pouring the liquid into the bottle, she took a sip. A vision of Adora surfaced; the blonde was walking down a hallway with a shorter girl. The girl had pink and purple hair, and her face reminded Shadow Weaver of Micah. *Sweet, talented Micah,* she mused to herself. The hallway seemed familiar. Last time she was in Bright Moon, she had mentored Micah at Mystacor Academy.

The hallway, however, was a part of Bright Moon Castle. Shadow Weaver had seen Queen Angella a few times when the woman was a princess. The vision faded. Shadow Weaver tightened her grip on the bottle, allowing anger to settle in her chest. Adora would know what she did. And who was the girl that accompanied her flower? If she ever ran into Adora, she would wipe away her memories and lock her up forever.

Adora's eyes took in every painting, tapestry, and statue. She had grown up with stories that took place in castles. This one was vast and majestic. Never in her whole life had she expected to see a castle in person, let alone enter one. Once she and Glimmer stepped into the throne room, her gaze landed on an elegant woman. The woman wore a long pink gown with mauve accents, and her hair flowed down her back. A diadem with a crystal rested upon the woman's head. This must be Queen Angella.

"Glimmer, who is your new friend?" Angella asked.

"I don't think you'd like to hear this, but I went to the forest with Bow and Adam. Bow and I found a tower, and as it turned out, Adora lives there," Glimmer said.

"I warned against going into the forest. It's a good thing you had someone with you, because something could have happened to you. Adora's face reminds me of the Queen of Grayskull."

"You know the Queen of Grayskull?"

"Yes. Queen Marlena and I were friends when we were your age."

"Anyways, Adora and I will go to Grayskull to see the floating lanterns tomorrow evening. Tomorrow, she turns eighteen."

Angella took in a deep breath, then exhaled. "You will not leave the castle. According to Chancellor Hordak, a threat is coming. Try not to get into a fight."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "I can defend myself."

"You only know the air spell. And you're not good at using a staff. Someday, you'll be queen, and you can't go off doing whatever you want. I do not want to argue anymore."

"Okay, fine." Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand and led her toward the grand doors. "We're going to the library."

The two women strode out of the throne room, navigated the hallways, and entered a room filled with bookshelves. Thousands of books lined the shelves. While Adora stood by the window, Glimmer sat at a desk and opened a thick tome. Adora's mind drifted to the lanterns. Would she ever have the chance to see them? Or would she be stuck here tomorrow? She trusted her guide; now she wasn't sure if the princess was reliable. Pressing a palm against the window, she peered over her shoulder. Glimmer widened her stance; she conjured a flame-shaped rune. The princess unleashed a spell upon the candles. Small embers materialized.

"I wanted to test out the fire spell on something else, but we're inside," Glimmer said.

"What would you use it on?" Adora asked.

"A dummy, for practice. The fire will burn it, however, and it'll have to be replaced." Glimmer's finger hovered over a page. "Lightning spell? Water, earth, light..." Her voice trailed off.

"Can we sneak out?"

"If my mother says a threat is coming..." Glimmer made eye contact. "I won't leave her here. She's not a fighter. Someone could kill her." A flash of sadness darkened her violet eyes. "I don't want to lose her."

"The guards will protect her, right?" Adora replied.

"Even a bunch of soldiers couldn't save my father." Glimmer closed the spellbook. "He's a powerful spellcaster. Despite his power, he lost his life on the battlefield."

"That's awful." Adora walked over to the desk. "What is your father like?"

"I... I don't remember him well. I was seven when he died."

Adora placed her hands onto Glimmer's arms. "I'm sorry for asking." She was at a loss for words. All she could do was silently comfort the shorter woman. A couple tears leaked from Glimmer's eyes.

Glimmer wiped her damp cheeks. "Adora, it's so sweet of you to comfort me. Thank you."

"So, um... while we're here, we could talk about our favorite stories."

"Yeah."

They proceeded to discuss their favorite books. From time to time, they would re-enact scenes, no matter how bad their acting was. Some of the funnier scenes had them breaking into fits of laughter. Glimmer never got bored, or asked Adora to stop when she was sharing the story of She-Ra. Likewise, Adora listened intently when Glimmer told her the tale of dragons and elves. The hours whizzed by as they chatted and exchanged jokes. Footsteps hurried past the door, and voices penetrated the silence, garnering their attention.

"Did we lose track of time?" Adora asked as she glanced at the window. It was now evening.

"Maybe," Glimmer said. She picked up the spellbook and pressed the side of her head against the door. "Something's wrong. I will check on my mother and see if she's in any danger."

"Let's go, then."

Adora followed Glimmer into the hallway. Snatches of shouts and commands pierced the air as they ducked the soldiers and peeked into every room. They dashed to a flight of stairs, panting as they ran. The stairs led them outside; they crossed a stone bridge to a tower. Another flight of stairs caused them to sweat. They stumbled into a corridor and froze. A tall man loomed over them, scowling.

"Chancellor Hordak, why are you blocking the door to my mother's suite?" Glimmer asked.

"She does not need to see you," Hordak spat. "Is that a spellbook in your hands? What are you going to do, cast every spell you see in there? I have more experience in magic."

"And what kind of magic have you been using? Dark magic?"

Hordak pressed his lips together. "Why does it matter?"

Glimmer clamped her fingers into white-knuckled vise-grips. "Are you hiding something?"

Hordak summoned his magic and chanted in an ancient language. A circular rune materialized on the floor beneath Glimmer, emitting a crimson aura. The shorter girl began wheezing. Adora glowered at the wicked man, baring her teeth. How dare he do this to her companion? All the princess did was ask a question!

"Stop it!" Adora demanded. "Leave her alone. She'll take me to the floating lanterns tomorrow evening!"

"Want an answer, brats? Horde Prime has been imprisoned for many years for using dark magic!" Hordak shouted.

"Let Glimmer go." Adora inched closer, her fists trembling as she maintained eye contact. "Now."

"You know what? I'll spare you two for now, but if you come back for me, you'll regret it."

The rune vanished. Glimmer panted, lifting a pair of hands to her neck. "Are you admitting to using dark magic? And are you planning to release Prime?"

"Get out!" Hordak retorted.

Can't Help Falling in Love

Before leaving the castle, Glimmer had teleported Adora into her room and grabbed a satchel for her spellbook. They had snuck out without alerting the guards, rode Swift Wind out of the village, and were now searching for a shortcut to Grayskull. It would take all night to explore the woods due to hidden dangers and a lack of light. The last thing she wanted to do was put Adora into more peril. Moonlight illuminated the field as Swift Wind galloped along the dirt road. Cold air enveloped Glimmer's body as her gaze flitted around the area. Yanking the reins, she halted Swift Wind and peeked at the castle. What if something happened to her mother? Did Hordak have a sinister reason for blocking the door?

"Glimmer, what is it?" Adora asked.

"I'm worried about my mother," Glimmer said. "Hordak could do something to her." She looked up at the stars. "Well, I think we could get closer to the border before we get tired."

Swift Wind began trotting. Glimmer patted her satchel to make sure she had taken her spellbook with her. Her palm met something solid. Expelling a sigh of relief, she turned her attention to the path in front of her. The moon glided toward the middle of the sky. Pinpricks of lights twinkled in the inky blackness. As the women and their steed made their way to the border, the horse slowed down. From time to time, Glimmer and Adora would yawn.

"Would you be okay with sleeping on the ground?" Glimmer asked as they reached the base of a hill.

"Yes," Adora said.

"We could set up a fire to keep us warm."

They dismounted Swift Wind. Glimmer led him to a pond, then gathered more firewood than needed. Adora helped her set up a fire. Since the base of the hill was secluded, a stranger wouldn't

bother them while they were sleeping. Most people weren't out and about during this time of night anyways. Glimmer traced a fire rune and unleashed the spell. Orange and yellow embers emerged from the firewood, radiating warmth and light into the air.

"Did you bring the blanket?" Adora asked as she sat on the ground.

Glimmer dug her mind for any memories of taking a blanket. *Oh, no.* She forgot to bring one. As for her cloak, she didn't know if it could function as a blanket or not. Shedding the cloak, she sat next to Adora.

"I forgot," Glimmer said. "We could use the cloak as a blanket, though."

"Are you sure?" Adora rubbed her arms. "It's cold. What if the fire dies out while we're sleeping?"

"Then we'll keep each other warm."

"Okay."

They reclined on the ground and pulled the cloak over their bodies. Glimmer rolled to her side, facing Adora. Their knees bumped against each other. In one whole day, they had gone from strangers to friends. Well, not exactly friends, but close. As Adora had said, Glimmer would escort her to the floating lanterns, and after that, they might part ways. She tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. The woman's hair was soft to the touch. Thoughts of the lost princess surfaced; Adora and the princess shared the same birthday, and would turn eighteen tomorrow. Angella had mentioned the resemblance between Adora and the Queen of Grayskull. Was Adora the missing princess?

Glimmer's eyelids grew heavy. A faint snore told her that Adora had fallen asleep. Today must have been an interesting day for the blonde. A distant caw, accompanied by the singing of a bird,

pierced the silence. Yawning, she closed her eyes. Unable to remain awake any longer, a heavy darkness overwhelmed her.

Blurry images and scenery flashed into Adora's dream as her fingers dug into the cloak. She rolled onto her back, taking in shallow breaths as she struggled to keep the nightmare at bay. Sweat drenched her hairline, and her pulse raced. Despite all her efforts to stop the nightmare, the images wouldn't fade...

...

Adora was running through the woods, trying to outrun whatever was chasing her. Creepy faces materialized on trees; red eyes and evil smiles. For hundreds of miles, she saw nothing but trees. The chilly air seeped into her dress, and her breaths turned into small clouds. Her foot met a log; she fell forward and rolled onto her back. A hooded figure approached her side and crouched to her level. She attempted to speak, but no sound came out. A bony hand emerged from the hooded figure and stroked her cheek. The hairs on the back of her neck stood. Why couldn't she move away from the threat? Was she frozen to the spot?

"Do you know what happens to delicate flowers if they're on their own? They perish."

Adora glanced around, hoping to see Glimmer in the vicinity. But the princess was nowhere to be found. Did the shorter woman leave her in danger? How would she go see the floating lanterns without someone to protect her? She blinked, and the next thing she knew, monsters and snakes surrounded her. If not for her inability to speak, she would scream for help.

"You have left the safety of the tower. You can't survive on your own. My flower, come home," a familiar voice said. "Taking a dangerous risk is not worth seeing those stars."

"You will face the consequences, since you defied the rules. For years, my dear, I thought you were special. But I was wrong."

A featureless silhouette lunged at Adora before she could react.

...

Adora's eyes flung open; she tossed and turned, her legs kicking the air as she attempted to fight an invisible attacker. Her brain screamed at her to flee to safety. A soft, yet strong hand gripped her wrist. It took a moment for her to remember where she was. Adora and Glimmer had been sleeping near the fire. There was no monster lurking in the vicinity. She glanced at Glimmer. The princess must have awakened to her having a nightmare. They needed energy for the rest of their trip, and right now, they weren't sleeping.

"Adora, what's the matter?" Glimmer whispered. "Did you have a nightmare?"

"Yes," Adora said.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"I... I don't know."

Glimmer wrapped her arms around Adora, pulling her closer. "It's okay if you don't want to talk about it."

Adora inhaled the comforting lavender scent, slowing down her heartbeat. The shorter woman rubbed small circles on her back. A distant hooting of an owl drew her attention to the starlit sky. She swore she heard a wolf howling. Maybe it was just a lingering effect of her nightmare; senses on high alert. A soft humming drifted into her ears, and she realized it was coming from Glimmer. Adora had never snuggled with anyone in her life, other than her mother. But it was only when she obeyed Shadow Weaver. Soon, the humming faded. Sleepiness weighed upon her limbs as she resisted the pull of slumber. She had no desire to return to the nightmare. If she did, she could see the hooded figure again. Monsters and snakes could be waiting for her, too.

"Are you still awake?" Glimmer whispered.

"Kind of," Adora replied.

"You better sleep..."

"Can't..."

"Why not?"

"I could... see them... again..."

"I'm here... Nothing will hurt you... You're safe..."

Adora's eyes fluttered shut. As soon as they closed, she snapped them open. The moonlight illuminated Glimmer's face. As time passed, it became harder to remain awake. Darkness crept into her vision, and within seconds, she fell asleep. This time, no dreams haunted her slumber.

Morning came. Glimmer awakened to the sight of a sleeping Adora. The blonde's chest rose and fell. Adora's rosy lips must have parted at one point during the night. A flush, probably from cold weather, highlighted Adora's freckles. Glimmer felt herself slipping back into unconsciousness. Shaking her head, she reminded herself that they had to continue their journey. She gently removed her arms from Adora and stood. The blonde's eyes opened.

"Time to get up and go," Glimmer said.

Adora sat up. "Can we have breakfast first?"

Glimmer picked up the basket. To her shock, the food had somehow disappeared, leaving behind crumbs. Did some animal eat it? She scrutinized the trail for any evidence of an animal tampering with the basket. Hoofprints confirmed her suspicions. So much for assuming that she secured the basket. She looked over to Swift Wind and arched a single brow. The horse's ears flattened against his head.

"Swift Wind, did you eat our food?" Glimmer asked.

Swift Wind lowered his head.

"I guess Adora and I will have to grab breakfast somewhere." Glimmer helped Adora up. "We'll look for a restaurant."

Adora furrowed her brows. "What's a restaurant?"

"A place to eat food."

Both women mounted Swift Wind and began riding. As they proceeded over the hill, a sign came into view. According to the sign, they should be in Grayskull soon. Glimmer took in her surroundings; jagged mountain peaks rose above the clouds. On the right edge of the trail, she glimpsed a slope. Twigs snapped beneath Swift Wind's hooves. Wasn't this path supposed to be the shortcut? Was she missing something?

Catra ascended a staircase, panting. There was never a dull moment last night; the Horde assassins murdered Queen Angella, resulting in a midnight funeral. The guards had looked everywhere for Princess Glimmer, yet she was nowhere to be found. Glimmer's companion was absent, too. They said that her companion was a young blonde woman with super long hair. She had never heard of anyone who refused to cut their hair. Did the woman have a reason for refusing to bring scissors or a dagger to her strands?

Catra reached the top, stepped outside, and began crossing a stone bridge. Hordak stood in the middle of the bridge, gazing into the distance. After the queen's death, he had crowned himself king. A few individuals objected to the idea of him ruling Bright Moon. In response to their arguments, he told them to hold their peace.

"Catra, you will gain a promotion this morning," Hordak said as he turned around.

"A promotion?" Catra repeated.

"Yes. Since I'm the king, I will make you a commander. You will give orders to our soldiers and guards. There are times when you must lead a group of soldiers on a mission."

"Am I going on a mission?"

"No."

"Will they discover the truth?"

"No. I'll tell the kingdom that the princess betrayed her mother, and that she won't return to Bright Moon."

Catra scoffed. "And people will believe the lie?"

Hordak stepped forward. "Of course. The throne is mine, and I won't surrender it anytime." He summoned a magical sphere to emphasize his point.

"What will you do if the princess comes back?"

"Kingdoms do not respond well to traitors." Hordak strode past Catra. "I will come up with a task for you later."

Catra nodded. What would the task be? It better be something she would enjoy. Scorpia would insist on coming with her. Emitting a sigh, she stormed into the tower and descended the steps. Why would Hordak give her a promotion and not a mission? Was he blind to her potential? She didn't work hard for nothing. Once she reached the bottom of the staircase, she proceeded into a hallway. Had she made the mistake of joining the royal guard after escaping the orphanage at eighteen years old?

Catra made her way to the courtyard and plopped onto a bench. She couldn't shake off the feeling that something was wrong with her. No wonder her adoptive mother abandoned her. Biting the insides of her cheeks, she suppressed the pain in her heart. There was no reason to scream and cry. Not when the soldiers and guards needed her to be a tough commander. Footsteps

approached, and she looked up. Why couldn't Scorpia leave her alone?

"Can we sit together?" Scorpia asked.

"You're talking to the commander," Catra said.

"You got a promotion?"

"Of course I did. It means I get to boss soldiers around."

"Oh. Congrats. So, Commander-"

"Don't be formal. We're not on a mission, and we don't have a task yet."

Scorpia sat next to Catra. "Okay, Wildcat. Can we hang out?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "I'll ask Hordak for an assignment once he takes a break from his royal duties. Also, we're not friends. If you want a friend, go talk to Kyle. Or Entrapta." She shot up to her height. "As commander, I order you to stop bothering me."

Glimmer and Adora arrived at a restaurant by a lake. The building was in desperate need of a renovation; parts of the roof had fallen off, small cracks had zigzagged along the foundation, and there was a fence that needed repair. A few horses waited outside, their riders already inside the restaurant. Adora followed Glimmer to the entrance. The shorter woman opened the door and stepped in first.

Adora held out her frying pan, trembling as her gaze flitted around. Two tables to the right, a pair of women chatted. The dark-skinned woman with white hair held a steaming mug, while the larger one cut a biscuit in half. A few tables down, a man with a pirate outfit sat next to a woman with teal hair. Accompanying them was a young woman with a dark blue bob. Glimmer led Adora to an empty table. Silverware, cloth napkins, and menus

idled on the surface. Adora held the frying pan closer to her chest, as though it was a shield.

"Adora, are you okay? You seem nervous," Glimmer said.

"I don't know anyone in here," Adora said. "What if they're ruffians and thugs?"

"Relax. The people in here aren't dangerous."

"People could stare at me."

"If it happens, I'll tell them to stop."

As they chatted, a waiter approached their table and spoke to them. They said that they wanted pancakes. The waiter left, and their conversation continued. Glimmer held Adora's hands. For a moment, every sound in the restaurant faded; she became aware of her fluttering heart. Heat flooded her face; she saw Glimmer blushing. She couldn't believe she was falling for someone who was a complete stranger just a day ago. Then again, she had read fairy tales about maidens who fell in love at first sight. Did she harbor a crush on Glimmer because the shorter woman comforted her last night? Or was it because of how sweet and protective her friend was?

"You're adorable," Glimmer said.

"You too," Adora replied.

"So... how come you never left the tower before?"

"I... um..." Adora was at a loss for words. "I did want to, for years. But..."

"Can I ask about your mother, then?"

"No. And I don't feel like answering questions about my hair, either."

"Am I allowed to mention the bird?"

"I thought I told you!" Adora placed a hand onto her chest in a gesture of fake offense. "His name is Kowl."

"Whoops. I forgot!" Glimmer replied in a silly tone.

They laughed. Adora felt her cheeks flush again, and in the midst of the laughter, she heard Glimmer chortling. There was something captivating about the way her friend laughed. Eventually, the giggles halted. She rested her elbows on the table and propped her chin against her palms. After tonight, the fun would end. And Shadow Weaver would ground her forever. She didn't want any of this to end.

"Adora, what is it?" Glimmer asked.

"I... I'm thinking," Adora said.

"Thinking about what?"

"Are we..." Adora took in a deep breath. "Parting ways after tonight?"

"I hope not."

"Maybe if I talk to my mother... hopefully she won't mind us being friends." Adora buried her face in her hands. "I doubt it, though. She would freak out."

"Adora... are you scared of your own mother?"

Adora shook her head. "No way." However, her answer didn't sound convincing.

"It sounds like it to me," Glimmer said.

Adora frowned. Silence lingered in the air, unspoken words anticipating release. But she had no desire to keep talking. Only time would tell if she could continue seeing her friend or not.

I Do Adore

Chapter Notes

More Glimmadora fluff in this chapter.

After the waiter carried two plates of pancakes to the table, the man with the pirate outfit strode to the stage and played the piano. The woman with teal hair told him to avoid singing shanties. He continued as if the woman hadn't said anything. Glimmer listened as the man sang about his dreams. A large woman with lavender hair pulled a dark-skinned woman to the dance floor and began dancing.

"Sea Hawk, I'll play music my way. I'm not a fan of shanties," the teal-haired woman said as she grabbed a guitar. "Hey everyone, I'll tell you what my dreams are." She faced the crowd and proceeded to sing while playing the guitar.

At the beginning of the song, everyone clapped their hands to the music. The woman said that her name was Mermista, and she was a mermaid. Her dream was to see the underwater kingdom of Salineas recover from a curse. She sang about the day she inherited the kingdom from her parents. Other than her dream, she wanted Sea Hawk to stop burning ships. Also, she mentioned her annoyance at his shanties.

The two women, Netossa and Spinnerella, sang about their dreams. They wanted to settle down and start a family after traveling the world. Frosta, a young woman who turned out to be fifteen, talked about moving to a colder climate and living in an ice castle. Glimmer didn't understand the logic behind living in a permanently cold climate, but she kept listening. The rest of the crowd joined in, singing about their hopes and desires. By the time they asked Glimmer and Adora what their goals were, the blonde hid her face behind a curtain of hair.

"I'll speak first," Glimmer said. "I want to be a powerful sorcerer like my father. I intend to learn as many spells as possible, and most importantly, I want to save Bright Moon from Chancellor Hordak. Adora, your turn. Don't be afraid."

Adora looked up, then tucked her hair behind her ears. "I'll tell you this... ever since I was young, I dreamed of seeing the floating lanterns in person. My mother never allowed me to leave the tower. Today's my eighteenth birthday, and nothing's going to stop me from watching the lights tonight. I believe they're carrying an important message for me. I don't know what it is, but I need to know why I'm drawn to them."

Mermista nodded. "I've heard of the lanterns. Adora, your face reminds me of Queen Marlena and Prince Adam."

"People have told me that before."

Glimmer sipped her drink. "Maybe they're related."

Adora stuffed her mouth with pancakes, and within minutes, the plate was empty. Everyone else in the restaurant proceeded to finish their breakfast. Glimmer hadn't heard another word from Adora. Had she said the wrong thing? Was family a sensitive topic? Should she have remained quiet regarding her thoughts? She pushed her food around the plate, replaying those words in her mind. *This is what happens when you're impulsive,* she told herself. Adora would not want to talk to her after the mention of possible familial relations. By the time Glimmer was full, she rose to her height and pushed the chair in.

"Adora, I'm sorry," Glimmer said.

"It's fine. You didn't hurt my feelings," Adora replied. "It's just that I never had any relatives other than my mother. If I did, they might have been forbidden from visiting my home."

They walked out of the restaurant and mounted Swift Wind. As the horse trotted down the path, Adora rested her chin on Glimmer's shoulder. Warmth bloomed in Glimmer's chest at the

touch. Thirty minutes whizzed by as they rode Swift Wind to a huge stone bridge that crossed a river. On the other side, countless buildings and a gorgeous castle occupied the vast island. The ocean was calm and serene. Its surface glittered in the golden sunlight.

"Wow," Adora said. "I've never seen the ocean in my entire life."

"It's beautiful," Glimmer replied.

"Yeah."

Swift Wind carried the duo to the island. A sign by the entrance came into view. It said: "Welcome to Gray Haven, Capital of Grayskull." Glimmer and Adora dismounted the horse, then strode into the town. The colors of the buildings and greenery were vibrant. Dozens of people hurried back and forth; some stepped on Adora's hair. Glimmer scooped up the blonde hair to prevent more people from stepping on it. She led Adora to the town square; a group of girls garnered her attention. They were braiding each other's hair.

"Hello," Glimmer said to the girls. "Would you like to braid Adora's hair?"

"Of course!" The girls replied in unison.

For the next ten minutes, Glimmer watched as the girls styled Adora's hair. A few individuals stopped to observe the scene before moving on. The girls added finishing touches to Adora's braid; pins and colorful flowers. Glimmer's jaw dropped as she gawked at Adora's braid. A tiara would make her friend look even more regal. Adora returned to her side, smiling.

"Do you like it?" Adora asked.

"Yes," Glimmer replied. "You're stunning."

"Thanks." Adora's cheeks reddened. "We have a few hours until evening." She grabbed Glimmer's hand. "In the meantime, let's do

something fun."

The town library contained more books than the one at Glimmer's castle. It was located in a quieter district, but Adora didn't mind. At one point, when searching for a book to read, they stumbled into the children's section, where they discovered their favorite stories. One was about She-Ra, and the other book focused on dragons and elves. They made their way to another section. The genre? Legends and myths. Adora pulled out a thick book, scrutinized its summary, and chose a blue sofa by the window. Glimmer settled in right next to her, leaning against the blonde.

Adora opened the book. "I've never read this before." She pointed to an illustration of a female warrior. "The cover calls her 'Mara.' According to the summary, she is a legendary hero who saved everyone from Horde Prime."

"Let's read it," Glimmer said.

Adora began reading the story of Mara to Glimmer. The tale started off with an impending threat to the world. A woman, Light Hope, spoke to Mara, telling her that she was the chosen heroine who would stop Horde Prime. So, the heroine set off on an adventure, braving perilous mountains, stormy oceans, and enchanted forests. Mara never knew what danger she would face; despite fearing the unknown, she was determined to defeat Prime. One day, Mara was gravely injured in battle. Her friends joined her, fighting hundreds of wicked foes.

"In the end, she sacrificed herself. The most powerful sorcerers in the land sealed Prime's spirit away in a magical prison. Everyone celebrated the victory, yet those closest to Mara mourned her," Adora said.

"I'm guessing it's a real story," Glimmer replied. "It mentioned Horde Prime."

"So did Hordak, when we confronted him."

"Mara is a hero, isn't she?"

"Yes. But she's so young. Nineteen, has a whole life ahead of her, and... yet, she lost her life while trying to protect everyone." Adora closed the book. "I'll find a different story. Maybe something about a princess. Or a collection of fairy tales in one book."

"A collection of fairy tales," Glimmer repeated.

Adora returned the book to its shelf and searched for another one. Sure enough, it was indeed a collection of stories. She hurried to the sofa and sat. For the rest of the afternoon, she narrated the stories and stopped a few times to discuss her favorite tropes. Glimmer rested her head on Adora's shoulder, smiling as she listened. At times, the shorter woman made jokes and comments. Adora wrapped an arm around Glimmer's waist as she continued speaking.

An hour later, they finished reading books and made their way past shops. Children and dogs played in the streets, chasing each other from sidewalk to sidewalk. Merchants shouted at passing crowds, only for a vast majority of people to ignore them. As the two women walked to the dock, Adora halted. She stared at a mural; it depicted a king and queen standing next to each other. The latter held a baby. Some people weren't kidding when they said that Adora resembled the Queen of Grayskull.

"You really do look like her," Glimmer pointed out.

"Yeah," Adora said.

They strode to the town center. A small band played music for the passerby. At first, a few people clapped their hands and tapped their feet to the music. The tune began picking up; a circle of dancers had formed. People looped arms together and spun. Adora made her way to the center, beckoning bystanders to join the dance. She held out a hand to Glimmer, and the shorter woman shook her head.

"I'm not dancing," Glimmer said.

"Yes, you are!" Adora replied as she pulled Glimmer into the circle.

As soon as Glimmer entered the circle, the two women got separated. They fell into a pattern of spinning around, switching partners, and repeating the cycle. Adora's heartbeat sped up; so did the rhythm. She frantically scanned the crowd for any sign of her friend. Panic gripped her heart, and as she squeezed her eyes shut, she struggled to maintain her composure. She felt a hand on her waist, and another holding her left hand. Her eyes fluttered open. Relief flooded her soul as she found herself gazing into Glimmer's violet eyes. If she could choose who to dance with, it would be Glimmer. The princess smiled; all Adora could do was mirror the smile. And she did.

If the dance wasn't coming to an end, Adora would lead the way, spinning and twirling her partner. And like in the stories of princesses and knights, she would lower Glimmer into a dip and kiss the back of her hand. Her cheeks burned as she tried to find the right words to say. Yet she couldn't speak. Would it be okay to do a quick dance for a few seconds?

"So, um... did you have fun?" Adora asked.

You sure have a way with words, don't you?

"Yes," Glimmer said. "Maybe after the lanterns, we could check on Prince Adam. Bow probably went home after taking him to the castle."

"Still, I'll be home before my mother figures it out, right?" Adora replied.

A voice told everyone to find the boats, interrupting the conversation. Adora and Glimmer hurried to the dock, then chose a small boat. They rode the boat out to sea, floating on the water. The sun dipped into the horizon, turning from bright yellow to a deeper gold. Streaks of pink, purple, and orange painted the

darkening sky. Adora took in the beauty of the sunset, committing it to memory. If she went home, she would paint this scene.

"It's so pretty," Adora said.

"I agree," Glimmer replied. "Although I prefer the nighttime, due to its moon and stars."

"I can't wait to see the floating lanterns."

"Adora, I want to tell you something..." Glimmer held Adora's hands. "I... I like you as more than just a friend. We've only known each other for a short time, but I want us to have a chance when it comes to romance."

Adora stared at her lap. "I like you, too. I'll share a secret. My hair glows. It has healing powers. This is why my gift must be protected. When I was a baby, people tried to cut my hair. They wanted to steal its power."

"I've never heard of magical hair. But there is a story of a golden flower that heals people. A drop of sunlight grew this flower on an isle. Eighteen years ago, before the lost princess was born, the magical blossom healed Queen Marlena."

"Speaking of its power, my mother must have gone a while without the healing magic. She'll become old and ugly as a result."

Glimmer gazed at the sunset. "My aunt once told me of a wicked sorceress who suffered from a curse that uglified and aged her. She gained the curse from a failed spell."

Adora furrowed her brows. "What's the name of the sorceress?"

"Shadow Weaver."

An image of Shadow Weaver's face flashed into Adora's mind. Then, a memory of the old woman's journal surfaced. She had seen an illustration of a sun-shaped flower. All she could hear was

silence as she dwelled on the memory. Shadow Weaver had yelled at her before snatching the journal out of her hands. The shouting resulted in Adora crying as her "mother" locked her in her bedroom for the rest of the night. Tears blurred her vision as she hugged herself. She wished she could go back to being the naive girl who dreamed of leaving the tower. Yet she couldn't. If her "mother" and the sorceress were the same person, then-

Adora thought of the mural and those who said she resembled Queen Marlena and Prince Adam. Was she the lost princess? She swore she heard Glimmer speaking to her, but the words were muffled. Had she believed a lie her entire life? Had Shadow Weaver used her for her hair? Why else would the old woman tell her not to leave the tower?

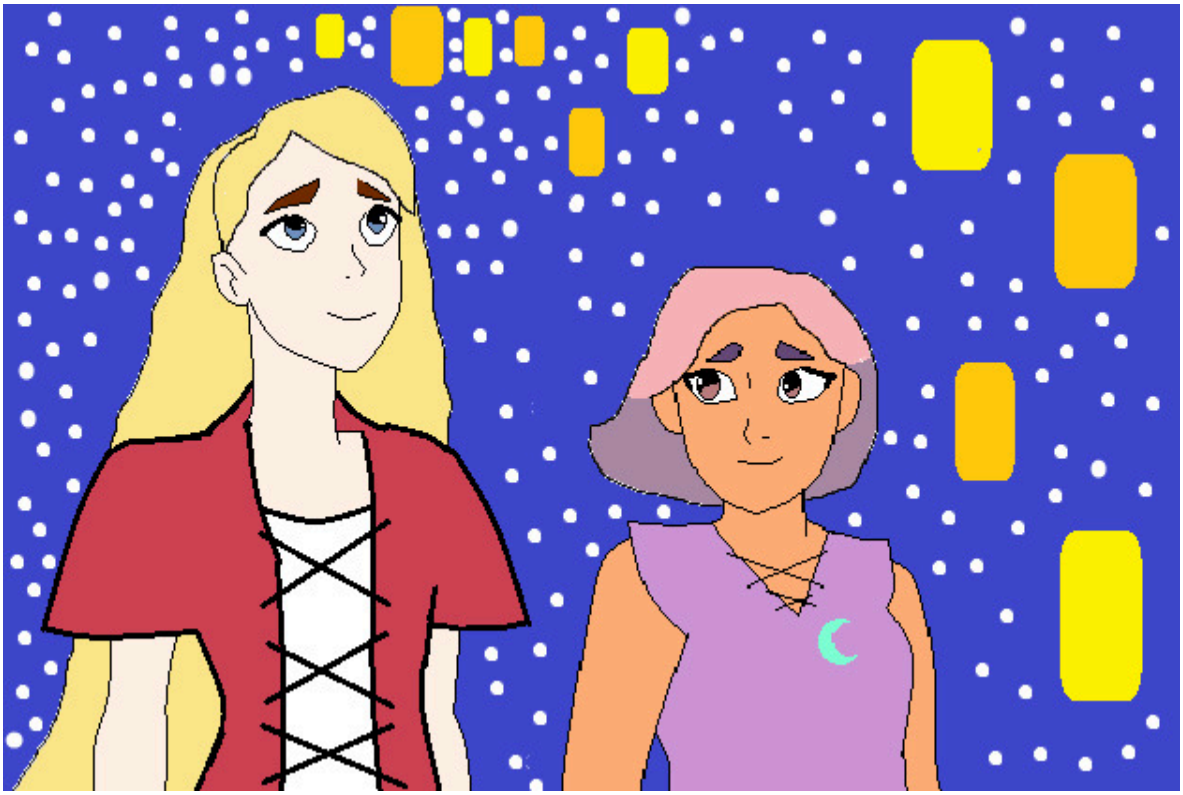
"Adora!"

Adora jumped at the sound of Glimmer's voice. "Were you talking to me?"

"Yes," Glimmer replied.

"The woman who raised me, she's not my real mother. Shadow Weaver lied to me for eighteen years. I might be the lost princess."

"We'll go to the castle after this."



Pinpricks of light dotted the night sky, accompanied by small glows of orange and yellow. Adora gazed at them, speechless. A ball of dread settled in her stomach. Images of her nightmare surfaced She reminded herself to focus on the lanterns. It did little to help. *Adora, relax. You're safe with Glimmer,* she told herself. Hundreds of lanterns glided into the sky, drawing her attention. Adora and Glimmer gasped at the beautiful sight. She didn't regret any of this; escaping the tower, adventuring with Glimmer, and watching the lanterns. Would she call this the best night of her life, though? After all, it was her birthday.

Glimmer leaned forward; so did Adora. Their faces were inches apart, breaths mingling as they closed their eyes. Adora had been warned about strangers her entire life, but as she had learned, not all of them were scary. Sure, there were people who didn't mind hurting others. Yet she met kind people more often than hostile individuals. Her lips brushed Glimmer's; the kiss was perfect, although brief. This moment was better than all the romantic scenes in her favorite books. Glimmer meant so much to her, that she feared parting ways with the princess. She hoped they didn't have to.

She Means Something to Her

Upon returning to the town, Glimmer led Adora to the castle. They strode to a throne room, where Queen Marlena and King Randor were sitting. Prince Adam stood by the king, watching as the women approached the steps. Adora had no idea what to say to the royal family. Should she simply tell them that she was the missing princess? Or tell them the story of her life leading up to her eighteenth birthday? Her hands trembled; she clasped them together and straightened her spine. Shadow Weaver would be angry. The woman who raised her could be capable of great harm. There had been times in her life when the sorceress used magic to punish her. She felt a palm covering both of her hands.

"Adora, breathe," Glimmer said.

Adora looked up at the couple. "I am the lost princess, gone for eighteen years. A woman, Shadow Weaver, kidnapped me when I was a baby. She used me for my hair."

Marlena gasped. "Adora?" She descended the steps and placed a hand onto Adora's cheek. "I can't believe it. You returned."

The touch was warm and comforting, in contrast to Shadow Weaver's. Marlena drew Adora into an embrace, crying tears of joy. Randor and Adam joined in. Adora was home. She would never go back to the tower. But Shadow Weaver might have other plans, considering that the sorceress was still out there somewhere. Adora held out a hand to Glimmer, gesturing at her. The shorter woman hugged her.

When everyone stopped hugging, Marlena turned her attention to Glimmer. "Thank you for bringing her home. Say, you remind me of Queen Angella and King Micah."

"It's because I'm the Princess of Bright Moon. My name's Glimmer," Glimmer said.

"Oh. How are your parents?"

Glimmer frowned. "My father's gone. And I don't know what happened to my mother."

"I'm sorry for your loss," Marlena said.

"Anyways, we need to keep Adora safe. Shadow Weaver could be out there, searching for Adora."

Randor nodded as he listened. "I'll ask the soldiers to guard every entrance and exit."

"Shadow Weaver has magic powers," Glimmer said. "She could cast a sleeping spell or worse. I'll make sure she doesn't hurt Adora."

For Shadow Weaver, the journey to Grayskull was smooth. All she could do was find Adora and bring her home. As she navigated the town of Gray Haven, she tightened her grip on the cloak and snuck into alleys. A small part of her expected to run into children. Instead, the streets were calm. If there had been children around, and they saw how ugly she looked, they would scream. As a result, the guards would have been alerted to her presence. She didn't want to deal with that situation. Muttering under her breath, she raced past a cluster of shops and bakeries. From time to time, she would peek at the passerby, hoping to see Adora.

As Shadow Weaver made her way toward the castle, a pair of guards hindered her. What was their deal? Did her flower go into the castle? Who knew what the royal family could be putting into Adora's mind? She clenched her teeth. If those stubborn guards refused to move out of the way, she would curse them. And she might have to.

"Sorry, you cannot visit the castle at this time," the short guard said.

Shadow Weaver knew what to do. "Sir, have you seen my sweet daughter? I have no idea where she is!" The worry in her voice was all for show. "She's blonde, has blue eyes, and wears a red dress! Please help me find her!"

"We can't help you. We are to avoid leaving our posts," the tall guard said.

Magic tingled in Shadow Weaver's fingertips. Those two didn't fall for her "worried mother" facade. Now was the time to resort to unpleasant methods. She rose her hands, channeling her power through her veins. The guards pointed their weapons at her, as if anticipating an attack. Too bad. They couldn't defend themselves against her magic! She unleashed a spell at them, knocking them off their feet. The duo fell to the ground, unconscious.

Hoofsteps thundered forward; Shadow Weaver cursed more soldiers, watching them fall off their steeds. She rushed closer and closer to the grand entrance. A fireball descended toward her; she evaded the flames. Where did it come from? Looking up, she glimpsed a figure in one of the windows. Did someone attempt to attack her from a distance?

Glimmer had been observing the window the whole time as she and Adora waited in the blonde's room. She had watched a sorcerer curse the guards. Just now, this person jumped out of the way before the spell could touch them. If the intruder was Shadow Weaver, she couldn't let her harm Adora. She grabbed Adora's hand and raced into the hallway. There had to be a safe place for her friend to hide.

"Is she here?" Adora asked in a shaky voice.

"Yes," Glimmer said. "I'll protect you from her."

A gust of wind extinguished the torches, darkening the hallway as they entered an adjacent corridor. Glimmer wasn't experienced in magic yet; she wasn't sure if she could succeed in keeping Adora

safe. Summoning an orb of light, she escorted Adora to a flight of stairs and ascended the steps. Despite knowing that they couldn't continue running from danger forever, she didn't want to risk letting Adora suffer. They stumbled into a master suite and slammed the doors shut. Queen Marlena and King Randor must have stayed in the throne room to fight the threat. As for Adam, neither woman had any idea where he went.

Outside the door, Glimmer could hear shouts and footsteps. Did Shadow Weaver track down the girls? Such a possibility wouldn't be far-fetched. Fixating her eyes on the doors, she anticipated a sudden break-in. She snatched a dagger from the nightstand in case she needed to outsmart the wicked woman.

"Are you going to stop her with a dagger?" Adora asked.

"I'll figure out a way," Glimmer said.

"You don't know what she's capable of. I've seen what Hordak did to you with a dangerous rune. You could have lost your life." Adora stepped forward, holding out a pan. "I... I'll ask her to spare you and the others. I will go back. We may not see each other again."

"No. Don't say that. You will stay in the castle with your real family."

The doors swung open, revealing a hooded figure. "Hello, my flower." A pair of pale hands pushed back the hood.

Glimmer widened her stance. "Shadow Weaver, stay away from Adora!" She sounded braver than she felt.

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. "You stole my flower."

"You shall pay for kidnapping Adora, and for deceiving Mystacor Academy's council!" Glimmer unleashed a wind spell at Shadow Weaver. "You can't own anyone. Not even Adora."

"You are bold and reckless. It will be a shame if you get hurt."

A chill ran up and down Glimmer's spine. "What are you going to do?"

Without a word, Shadow Weaver unleashed a dark spell at Glimmer before the latter could teleport. Glimmer descended to her knees, groaning in pain as an electrical sensation overwhelmed her body. The dagger slipped out of her hand. Just as she attempted to rise, another electrical jolt flooded her limbs. What did Shadow Weaver do to her? How would she stop this woman if she couldn't do anything to defend Adora?

"Shadow Weaver! What have you done to her?" Adora blurted out.

"You must not defy me any longer. Come home," Shadow Weaver said.

"No. I know what you did. You manipulated me my whole life. Made me fear the world. Forbade me from going outside."

"Stop the complaining. We will go where no one will find you. And you won't remember any of this. You will be my flower forever."

"Please stop torturing her."

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "If you comply, she won't die."

"I won't disobey you ever again. Let me heal her first. If you let me heal her, I will go with you."

"Adora... no..." Glimmer said.

"I'll never run. I'll never try to escape. You and I will be together forever. Everything will be the way it was. I promise."

"Fine." Shadow Weaver surged her magic into Glimmer. "Just in case you get any ideas about following us."

Glimmer screamed in agony. A moment later, Adora was at her side, while Shadow Weaver lingered in the doorway. The blonde

undid her braid, tears leaking as she looped her hair around Glimmer's waist. Flowers and pins fell out of Adora's hair.

"Adora, you shouldn't do this. She could be tricking us," Glimmer said.

"You don't deserve to suffer," Adora replied.

Despite the pain threatening to paralyze Glimmer's body, she picked up the dagger while maintaining eye contact. She ignored the horrid sensation of many needles piercing her body as she grabbed Adora's hair with her free hand. In one clean motion, she sliced off the golden hair. Shadow Weaver would no longer get away with using Adora. The blonde was free.

"Glim?" Adora asked, reaching for her hair. Her fingers stopped at the middle of her neck and brushed the choppy ends of her now dirty blonde hair.

"NO!" Shadow Weaver screeched as she gathered the bundle of hair. She seemed to age seventy years and gain a hideous appearance within seconds.

The agony paralyzed every inch of Glimmer's body as she whimpered. She felt Adora's arms wrap around her body.

"Glimmer... I couldn't save you... this is all my fault..." Adora said.

"WHAT HAVE YOU DONE?" Shadow Weaver bellowed as she glowered at Glimmer.

Glimmer wished she had the strength to retort, to say something in response to Shadow Weaver's question. All she could do was sit there and let Adora hug her. Both women watched as Shadow Weaver tripped and fell through the window. Glimmer could no longer sit up. She reclined to her side; in a swift motion, Adora caught her. She made eye contact, resisting the urge to slip into unconsciousness.

"Stay with me, Glim..." Adora whispered as she stroked Glimmer's cheek.

"Adora... I love you..." Glimmer murmured.

Adora sniffled. "I... I love you, too..." She began singing.

Flower, gleam and glow

Let your power shine

Make the clock reverse

Bring back what once was mine

"Adora..." Glimmer whispered.

"What?" Adora replied, tears staining her cheeks.

"You were my dream..."

"And you were mine..."

With a final breath, Glimmer's life faded away.

Adora buried her face in Glimmer's shoulder, sobbing. If she kept her hair, she could have healed the comatose woman. She could sit here forever, crying her heart out. No amount of tears could bring back the woman who died protecting her. Or could they? It sounded like a foolish hope, something that only happened in fairy tales; the idea of tears reviving someone's true love. Her heart ached at her loss.

Glimmer wouldn't live to become a powerful spellcaster, wouldn't save Bright Moon, and she would be leaving her kingdom without a ruler. All because she saved Adora. Of all the people and kingdoms in the world, she sacrificed herself. Why did she choose to be a hero? Why did she have to be one?

Adora recalled the story of Mara and her sacrifice. As far as she knew, heroes never had the chance to achieve their dreams and fulfill their deepest longings. Stroking Glimmer's soft hair, she whispered, "I'm so sorry." Due to losing herself in her grief, she failed to notice a golden glow enveloping Glimmer's body. Thinking her mind was playing tricks, she pulled away. The glow illuminated the entire room, touching the furniture, walls, and windows. She had no idea what to think. What was it doing?

Adora placed an index finger and middle finger onto Glimmer's neck to check for a pulse. For a brief second, she swore she felt something. But it could be a figment of her imagination. The shorter woman remained still and dead. They didn't go on an adventure and share their first kiss just to wind up in here, devoid of hope. Glimmer was the reason she left the tower, found out the truth regarding her family, and came home to her real parents. Anger heated her veins. It was cruel of Shadow Weaver to end Glimmer's life. The golden light receded into Glimmer's body.

Could the magic bring Glimmer back? Adora didn't know if it was possible. She waited for several minutes, every second dragging on. As her hope began to dwindle, a voice spoke.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked, her eyes fluttering open.

Was Adora imagining things? Or was it real? She had to be delusional to not accept her loss. And yet, somehow, her true love came back to life. It was the stuff dreams were made of. If it was real, she would feel relieved. Glimmer held her hands, smiling.

"Glim..." Adora said. "You're back." She pulled Glimmer into a tight embrace. "I thought I lost you forever!"

"I'm still here," Glimmer replied. She glanced at Adora's lips.

Adora closed the distance, their mouths colliding in a passionate kiss. This was more meaningful than their first kiss. A lot more. She couldn't imagine her life without Glimmer. A life without the princess was no life at all. By the time they broke apart, she

released Glimmer. Both women stood. They would have to explain everything to the King and Queen of Grayskull. Adora peeked at the doorway.

"I'm going to talk to my parents and my brother," Adora said. "So, are you going back to Bright Moon?"

"No. I have to gain more magical power and learn a lot of spells if I plan to defeat Hordak," Glimmer replied.

"Are you going on more adventures?"

"I might. If Hordak releases Horde Prime, the world will be in danger." Glimmer lowered her brows. "I will defeat them if they threaten everyone."

Adora didn't want to see Glimmer risking her life again. If it wasn't for the healing magic, she could have lost Glimmer for good. However, she couldn't ignore the fire of determination in her love's violet eyes. She reached for her missing hair. Although Glimmer cut her hair to save her life, she missed it.

"Sorry about your hair," Glimmer said.

"It's fine. You did it to save me," Adora replied. "Thank you for taking me to the floating lanterns."

"Thanks for healing me."

The duo strode into the corridor, holding hands as they made their way to the throne room. Once they entered the regal hall, Adora glanced at the royal couple and the prince. Her family's smiles were filled with more love than Shadow Weaver could ever possess.

"Shadow Weaver's gone for good," Adora said.

"This calls for a celebration," Randor said. "We're so glad you're home after all those years, safe and sound."

"Before any of you ask about my hair, Glimmer cut it to free me from Shadow Weaver."

Marlena nodded. "It's okay. We were more concerned about your safety."

Later in the night, Adora and Glimmer snuggled in her new bed, tired from today's trip. Their legs were tangled underneath the covers, and their foreheads met. Adora's mind drifted to memories of the tower. Not all of them were bad; she had painted the most beautiful portraits, baked her favorite treats, and read the best books. Would she still do those things in the castle? A small part of her wondered, despite her anger at Shadow Weaver, if the old woman ever loved her. After all, Weaver had raised her for eighteen years. Considering what had happened earlier, she could answer the question with a simple 'no.'

"I'd like to go on another adventure," Adora whispered.

"Maybe we will," Glimmer replied.

"I'm glad I found my real family..."

They drifted into a blissful slumber, snoring as they dreamed of romance and daring quests.

Sheltered Again?

Chapter Summary

> Adora tries to adjust to royal life and to get to know her family.

For Adora, the morning was a blur. Everyone in the castle prepared the ballroom for the celebration, and multiple servants insisted on making her wear something different. All she wanted to wear was something comfortable. At one point, one of the servants told her to try on a pair of shoes. It felt strange to wear shoes, but since her attendants wouldn't leave her alone, she chose a pair of simple flats. Fortunately, a floor-length gown would hide them. The gown's design was similar to her other dress, despite white lace lining the neckline and sleeves. She caught her reflection in the bedroom mirror, transfixed by her appearance. A golden tiara with a ruby in the center and tiny wings on its sides rested upon her head.

"Glimmer... what do you think?" Adora asked as she turned to face her love.

Glimmer still wore a lavender tunic and purple leggings. An aquamarine brooch on her tunic glittered in the sunlight. Earlier this morning, she had brushed her hair to one side, forming an asymmetrical bob. Teardrop earrings dangled from her ears.

She's so cute.

"Adora, you look amazing," Glimmer said.

"Thanks," Adora replied.

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "Ready for the ball?"

"Yes."

They walked out of the bedroom, into the hallways, and entered the ballroom. People in their finest clothes streamed into the hall, talking to one another. On one side of the ballroom, there was a seating area and a buffet. Music echoed off the walls, the tune slowing down as Adora and Glimmer descended the stairs. Hundreds of strangers stopped to observe the duo. Her pulse sped up as she sensed countless individuals watching her. She had a feeling that she would have to get used to being the center of attention.

"So, are we going to dance the whole time?" Adora asked.

"No. We may chat with your family, and we'll have some food," Glimmer said.

They strode to the buffet and filled their plates with food. Adora glanced at the tables, searching for a spot that wasn't occupied. Out of the corner of her eye, she detected Queen Marlena waving at her. Adora led Glimmer to her family's table, and they both sat down.

"Adora, since you're a year older than your brother, you are now an heir to the throne. Someday, you will be queen," Marlena said. "Your duties as a princess will prepare you for the day you inherit the throne. By the way, a princess does not stuff her face."

Adora lifted a brow before swallowing her meal. Was there anything else she wasn't supposed to do as a princess? She listened to the rest of Marlena's lecture about royal life; obligations, etiquette, greeting nobles the proper way, and of course, the importance of wearing shoes. According to her mother, there was a list of rules; it was a lot to take in. Posing for portraits? The correct way to write letters? Ladylike posture, whether sitting or standing? She couldn't imagine herself being stiff and boring all the time. But at least she was reunited with her family, right? She proceeded to take smaller bites of her lunch, making sure to avoid annoying her mother.

"The guards will be more vigilant. We don't want to lose you again," Randor said.

"Are you saying they'll watch my every move?" Adora asked. "You don't need to worry about me. I'm eighteen now."

"Eighteen years ago, Shadow Weaver kidnapped you."

"I know. But now I'm home, and-"

"I am your father. Therefore, I must keep you safe."

Adora sighed. "Just don't resort to locking me up. So, Adam..."

Adam sipped his drink. "What is it?"

"I didn't know I have a sibling."

"Well, for eighteen years, I had no idea if you're still alive or not."

"How is your injury?"

"It's getting better. My girlfriend, Teela, has been extra protective of me these days."

"What is she like?"

"She's strong-willed and fearless."

Adora placed her fork onto the plate. "Anyways, Glimmer and I will dance."

"Okay. Have fun dancing," Adam said.

Adora and Glimmer made their way to the center of the ballroom. Couples linked their hands together, holding their free hands behind their backs. As the guests swayed to the tune, Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand; they began dancing. At first, they worked together, neither guiding the other. Soon, Adora took the lead, twirling her around and adding a few moves; spinning, pulling either away or as close as possible, and dips. The guests ended

up watching in awe. For a moment, she lost herself in Glimmer's gaze.

"I've been wanting to do this ever since the dance in Gray Haven," Glimmer said.

"Me too," Adora replied. "You're the Princess of Bright Moon, right?"

"Yes."

"How did you feel about dealing with a lot of rules and duties?"

"I'm used to it. There were times when it feels like my mother is holding me back. She would get upset whenever I go into the forest or far enough from the castle without anyone to accompany me."

"I think my situation is different. As my father said, the guards will watch my every move." Adora wrapped her arms around Glimmer's waist. "It sounds like I won't have much freedom."

Glimmer rested her palms on Adora's shoulders. "You were gone for eighteen years, so it makes sense for him to fear losing you again."

Catra had searched the entire castle this morning for Hordak. He still hadn't given her a mission, and people could start wondering where he went. A thought came to her as she navigated the dungeon; he could be in his secret room right now. The king hadn't granted her permission to enter, though. She approached a large wooden door; snatches of a conversation wafted into her ears. Who was he talking to? Was someone in the room with Hordak? She moved toward a crate and hid behind it, listening to the conversation.

"We meet again, Hordak. How did your conquest go?" An unfamiliar voice said.

"It has been successful. Grayskull is next," Hordak said. "The problem is, someone will try to foil my plans."

"And who are they?"

"Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon and her blonde companion."

"Little brother, before my enemies imprisoned me, there was a young girl who thwarted me. Her name's Mara."

"Horde Prime, I'm not here for stories. I'm here for advice."

"You want advice? Do not make the same mistake as I've made. Never underestimate your foes. If any of your assets aids an enemy, discard them."

Catra had heard tales of Horde Prime trying to take over the world in the distant past. According to the legend, if someone used a spell to free Horde Prime, he would avenge himself. Many people viewed it as a cautionary tale, to warn spellcasters against learning dark magic. A memory of the green glow flashed into her mind. Did Hordak contact Horde Prime by casting a spell on the mirror? Was this the reason he told her to leave the mirror alone? She began walking toward the dim passageway when the door swung open.

"Catra, are you going to ask me about missions again?" Hordak asked.

Catra whirled around. "What are you waiting for? Horde Prime to tell you *when* to give me a task?"

"You were eavesdropping?" Anger darkened Hordak's eyes. "There are consequences for overhearing a private conversation." He murmured an incantation; a rune materialized beneath Catra's feet.

Catra felt the air being extracted from her lungs as she fell to her knees. Wheezing, she looked up at the king. Sweat trickled down her face as she struggled to inhale. It was horrifying, being

asphyxiated. She wanted this to end, yet she brought it upon herself by eavesdropping on Hordak. The asphyxiation spell could easily kill someone. Would she die in here? Her vision blurred as she continued glowering at Hordak. Did she just see a sinister smirk on his face?

"You disturbed me for no reason," Hordak said. "You should know this. When an asset fails to serve its purpose, it becomes worthless to me." With a single wave of his hand, the rune vanished. "Want a task so bad? I suggest you track down the Princess of Bright Moon and her companion."

"How can I do it?" Catra asked.

"Use both your magicat senses and a potion."

"Is there information I need to get from them?" Catra rose to her height. "Sparkles may not tell me anything."

"Of course. She may have plans to stop me." Hordak took a potion out of his robe. "The potion will reveal her location to you. Once you discover where she is, take a group of soldiers with you and go."

By five in the afternoon, the ball ended. Adora sat in the courtyard, watching Glimmer cast new spells on targets. All she wanted to do was go somewhere without the guards following her. And speaking of guards, some of them were present in the courtyard. She was not a helpless child who needed constant supervision. It was annoying. Whenever a person other than Glimmer and the royal family tried to interact with Adora, the guards would tell them to stay away. Although she wasn't in the tower anymore, her world still felt small. She wouldn't be surprised if the royal couple forbade her from leaving the castle.

Glimmer sat next to Adora. "I enjoyed our dance during the ball."

"Same," Adora said. "Other than the ball and reuniting with my family, I'm not so sure about the princess life. Apparently to them,

a princess is supposed to be sheltered and delicate." She crossed her arms. "They should know I'm not weak. I stood up to Hordak and Shadow Weaver. And one time, I used the frying pan as a weapon."

"A frying pan wouldn't be effective against an evil sorcerer."

"They backed down when I stood up to them."

"Words don't always work on bad guys. I have a feeling Hordak will do anything to get what he wants. He could have hurt you when you spoke to him. Remember his warning about meeting him again? It was a threat."

"I'm not scared of him. I was more scared of losing you."

"I don't want anything bad to happen to you, either." Glimmer's hand enveloped Adora's. "We'll always have each other's backs."

"That aside, I want to learn how to fight." Adora turned her attention to the targets. "I doubt the guards will let me train. Do you have any experience with non-magical weapons?"

"I have trained with a staff. As for other weapons such as swords, I've never touched them."

"How about Adam? Does he wield any weapons?"

"He does. Teela's more of a fighter, though."

"Where can I find her?"

"At the moment, I don't know. Sometimes, she may accompany Adam."

Adora rose to her height. "I'll ask Teela to train me." She led Glimmer into the castle.

Once again, the guards followed them. What would they do next, stand in front of Adora's bedroom door while she slept?

Navigating the hallway, both women moved past multiple doors. Within ten minutes, they entered a training room. A few knights had just finished sword-fighting practice. One of them was a redheaded woman. Like the rest of Grayskull's soldiers, she wore golden armor and carried a sword.

"What brings you here, Princess?" The woman asked.

"I'm looking for Teela," Adora said. "I'm here to learn how to use a sword."

"I'm Teela, Adam's bodyguard. Why are you interested in sword-fighting?"

"Because I want to defend myself."

"It'll take a while to master the skill. Also, when it comes to protection, the guards will defend you when you're in danger. Glimmer will keep you safe, too."

Adora approached the weapon rack. "Are you saying no?" She reached for a wooden sword. "I won't leave until-"

Teela pushed Adora's arm in the opposite direction. "You will not put your life in danger. If you'll excuse me, I'll attend to my duties."

Adora pressed her lips together as she stepped into the hallway. Was this to be her life? She never asked to be supervised every minute of the day. Clenching her hands, she stared at the floor as she continued walking. The guards wouldn't leave her alone, she couldn't do anything without being corrected, and worst of all, Teela refused to teach her how to wield a sword. Today was not her day. A servant approached the women. Why couldn't she have some time to herself?

"Princess Adora, the king and queen has requested your presence in the dining hall," the servant said.

"Is it dinner already?" Adora asked.

"Yes."

Adora and Glimmer followed the servant to the dining room. Sunlight illuminated the large windows, brightening the hall. They occupied a pair of empty seats, sitting across the table from the king and queen. Adam wasn't here. Was there a reason behind his absence? Adora frowned at King Randor. She wanted her father and everyone else in the castle to understand that she wasn't a helpless child.

"Can I have more time to myself without having half the Royal Guard over my shoulder?" Adora asked. "Can I be allowed to use a weapon to defend myself?"

"Sweetheart, I don't want you to get hurt," Randor said.

"Is that it? No answer to my questions?"

"Well, you came home to us last night. I waited for eighteen long years, hoping you would return. And you did. It would shatter my heart if I lose you again."

"Is this why you're restricting my freedom?"

"I'm not restricting your freedom." Randor heaved a sigh. "Your safety is important."

Adora rested her elbows on the table. "And what about Adam? Does he have a lot of freedom?"

"He's allowed to travel, but someone has to be with him so he won't get kidnapped."

"Can I travel sometimes? Glimmer could come with me."

"No."

"What you're saying is that Adam *can* go somewhere, yet I *can't* leave the castle?"

"Adora, will you please understand what I'm trying to say? I've had many sleepless nights when you were gone. Your absence haunted me every minute of every day."

Before Adora could reply, a group of servants carried plates of food into the dining hall. She dwelled on her father's words for a moment. Sure, he missed her. But was it right to limit someone's freedom? Shadow Weaver had limited her freedom in the past, and she didn't enjoy it one bit. Why couldn't he understand her point of view?

A Hairy Situation

Chapter Summary

> Adora sneaks out to clear her head, and she comes upon the exact location of the magic flower. She returns home with seventy feet of hair.

After one long week of princess duties, etiquette lessons, and being told to stay behind whenever Glimmer went on a trip outside Grayskull, Adora grew tired of this new life. One night, she paced back and forth in her room, ranting to Glimmer about how the princess life made her feel. All she wanted to do was clear her head and go somewhere by herself. It wasn't that she was ungrateful; it was one thing to be reunited with her family, and another thing to be controlled. She never asked to be babysat by all those guards. Why wouldn't anyone give her some space? Was it somehow too unsafe to be alone? At this point, she was frustrated.

"Is there something you want to do?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said as she plopped onto the sofa.

"You told me you wanted to go on another adventure. Well, we could do it tonight."

"And how will we do that? Won't the guards notice?"

Glimmer made her way to the window. "We'll sneak out. No, we'll teleport. First, I'll create an illusion of you sleeping in bed, sound effects included."

Adora shrugged. "Won't they see through the illusion?"

"No. They'll fall for it."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes." Glimmer beckoned Adora closer. "My teleportation has improved, so I don't think there will be as much of a chance of messing it up. First, illusion..." She summoned her magic, whispering an incantation.

Adora peeked over her shoulder and detected a silhouette on her bed. "This is the illusion? Also, how will you explain your absence without making my family suspicious?"

"An illusion of me leaving the castle." With a single wave of her hand, Glimmer conjured a doppleganger. "It'll last until she's out of the castle."

"Oh, okay." Adora couldn't help but feel a little freaked out. There were two of her, and two Glimmers. "It's kind of spooky."

"To us, maybe. But to them, they won't think something's up." Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand. "Ready?"

"Yes."

Catra had reserved multiple rooms in a Gray Haven inn for her companions prior to their arrival. She had also sent a letter to Hordak regarding a potential delay; he responded with a letter expressing his annoyance. Of course he wouldn't be happy about it. Was he anxious to take over Grayskull? The door swung open, revealing her soldiers. Scorpia was one of them, but the others wouldn't count on her to be useful. She herself didn't. So far, the tall woman had gotten distracted by ducklings, didn't follow some orders, and almost blew everyone's cover. Catra was done with Scorpia's mistakes. If Scorpia decided to be stupid again, the plan would fail.

"Here's the plan. Kyle, close the door behind you, so they won't hear us talking," Catra said.

"Okay," Kyle said as he shut the door.

"Tomorrow, we'll disguise ourselves as nobles and guards. If we see Sparkles, we'll ask her if she's planning to stop Hordak. We need to be subtle, so that she won't figure us out."

"Oh, we're gonna dress up?" Scorpia asked.

"It doesn't mean we'll have fun," Catra spat. "We're on a mission here, and fun is not part of the task."

"Alright, then. Who will be a noble, and who will be a guard?"

"Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio will be the guards. Scorpia and I will be nobles. Since Double Trouble's a shapeshifter, he can create a distraction. Entrapta can look up the castle layout on her tablet. Let's make up code names. Scorpia, you are Duchess Lynda D'Ream. I'm Lady C'yra of D'riluth. Before you ask, I'll wear a suit."

"Ooh, fun!"

Catra massaged her temples. "Did you forget what I told you? If you screw things up, like you always do, I'll tell King Hordak what you did! He will be mad."

Scorpia lowered her head. "Fine. I'll do my best to obey your orders."

"Good. And I don't want you singing, either."

Glimmer and Adora reappeared by the entrance to the woods. The clouds concealed the moon and stars, dimming the night. She conjured a magical orb and let it guide the duo. It reminded her of the time she and Adora left the tower. However, this was for a different reason. There were no lights to watch in the sky, and no Shadow Weaver drama. She escorted Adora along the path, stepping over moss-covered logs and shoving low-hanging branches aside. Damp leaves brushed her sleeves, and despite the warmth of her tunic, the cold air enveloped her. Puffs of white clouds escaped the women's mouths.

"If you start to feel tired, just say so," Glimmer said.

"I'm fine," Adora replied, pacing ahead.

"Don't go too far."

"Sorry. I'll slow down."

Glimmer caught up to Adora. "I know you're excited to leave the castle, but if something happens to you, your family will be upset."

"Can we talk about something other than my safety?" Adora's voice rose in volume as she spoke. "I'm not a helpless damsel!"

A growl interrupted their conversation. Glimmer stepped in front of Adora and traced a rune in the air. Their voices must have garnered the attention of a hostile creature. A pack of wolves emerged from the shadows. Crows and bats flew past the duo; Glimmer unleashed an air spell at the wolves, pushing them back. She led Adora past dozens of pine trees, keeping her eyes peeled for more dangers. As they reached the exit, a bridge came into view.

Cracks ran along the stone bridge. It must have fallen apart from age. Was it around for hundreds of years? Glimmer and Adora ambled across the bridge, slowing their pace each time they heard a crack. Once they made it to the other side, they began speeding up. Fifteen minutes transitioned into an hour as they navigated the trail. The path led them to a small dock and a boat.

"It doesn't have paddles. However, it has a sail," Glimmer said.

"Can we explore the ocean?" Adora asked.

"I don't want us to get lost, so..."

"There's always teleportation." Adora raced across the dock and stepped onto the boat. "Come on."

Glimmer joined Adora. "I'm only coming with you because this could be perilous. A storm could hit us in the middle of the water."

After untying the rope holding the boat, they floated toward the middle of the sea. There was something dangerous about sailing at night; sudden storms, powerful ocean waves, and getting lost in the middle of nowhere. Glimmer scrutinized the area, biting her bottom lip. If something happened to Adora, she would blame herself. Seagulls cawed as they hovered in the sky. A salty breeze propelled the boat forward.

"We're going faster," Adora said.

"I hope we don't wind up stuck on an island," Glimmer replied.

As they continued their journey across the water, an island came into view. Riding a boat was a harebrained idea. Glimmer should have said no, but she didn't want to upset Adora. Next time the blonde suggested something crazy, she would put her foot down. It might hurt for a minute, yet in the long run, it would be worth keeping Adora safe. Within a half hour, they arrived at an isolated beach. Even in the dark, she could see a mountain pointing upward. They dismounted the boat and proceeded to explore the island. She didn't have a good feeling about this.

"Let's stick together," Glimmer said. "There's something about the island I don't like."

"What are you so worried about?" Adora asked.

"More hostile animals. Poisonous insects. You don't know what's out here. And it's dark."

"I'm not scared."

Glimmer held up an orb of light and gripped Adora's hand. They wandered along the trail; from time to time, they would pass by a skeleton. Disembodied hoots penetrated the silence. Not once did she stop checking her surroundings. They ascended the hill and crept to a clearing. Moonlight broke through the clouds,

illuminating a stone pedestal and dozens of sharp rocks. Of all the rocks she had seen in her life so far, she had never seen those. This island had to be magic.

"What is this?" Adora asked, approaching the black rocks.

"No idea. This must be where the drop of sunlight landed," Glimmer said. "Don't touch anything." She unleashed a fire spell at the rocks. The flames had no effect on them.

The rocks emitted a bright blue light as Adora placed a finger onto a stone. A ball of light exploded, shoving both women backward. They landed onto their backs. The moment Glimmer looked up, she heard Adora gasp. More rocks emerged from the ground; Glimmer and Adora backed away. She took Adora's hand and ran down the hill, panting as she glanced over her shoulder. Why were the glowing stones following them? Was some invisible force controlling them? It would make sense for an island touched by magic to have strange things happen. Perhaps an unseen entity haunted the island. Glimmer halted, while Adora hurried a couple feet ahead.

"Why did you stop?" Adora shouted.

"I'll make sure they don't impale us!" Glimmer replied as she kicked one side of the mountain, triggering an avalanche. The avalanche formed a barrier, hindering the rocks.

Adora ran off into the darkness; Glimmer pursued her into the wooded area, ignoring the burning sensation in her lungs as she chased the blonde. She wasn't about to let Adora stumble into danger anytime. A scream drilled into her ears. Was the princess hurt? Adrenaline racing, she descended the hill as fast as possible. She really should have said "no" to island exploration in the first place! Adora shouted her name, prompting her to run faster. Her legs would ache tomorrow.

"What's the matter?" Glimmer asked upon finding Adora. A trail of hair drew her attention. "How in the world?"

"I don't know how it happened," Adora said. "All it took was my fingertip merely brushing the stone, and..." Her voice trailed off.

"Adora, do you think the sundrop's magic was still flowing through you?"

Adora folded her arms. "Perhaps. My family will be upset if they see all that hair. The moment we get home, we're cutting it off."

"Let's go home," Glimmer replied. "This time, we're teleporting to the castle instead of taking the boat."

"You can teleport long distances now?"

"Yeah. It takes practice." Glimmer grabbed Adora's hands. "In three, two, one..."

The duo reappeared in Adora's room. She plopped onto the bed; her double vanished into thin air. Glimmer sat next to her, holding a pair of scissors. The shorter woman took a section of blonde hair and attempted to cut it. To Adora's disappointment, it didn't work; the scissor blades shattered into pieces. Was her hair indestructible?

"We're not falling asleep until we figure this out," Adora said.

"Can it wait until-" Glimmer began.

"No!"

Glimmer placed a finger onto Adora's lips. "If you freak out, it'll get the guards' attention. You could tell your parents about your hair. But they cannot know that I snuck you out. They could forbid me from seeing you if they knew the truth."

"I need my hair to be cut already."

"Okay, fine." Glimmer put away the scissors and drew a rune in the air. "Close your eyes."

Adora squeezed her eyes shut. For a brief moment, she sensed her hair being levitated. Glimmer chanted in an unfamiliar language, repeating herself a few times. After ten minutes, the shorter woman emitted a noisy exhale. Adora's eyes fluttered open as she ran her fingers through her blonde locks. As it turned out, her hair was immune to spells. How did it happen? If she hadn't touched the rocks, they wouldn't be in this situation right now.

"That's why I told you not to touch those rocks!" Glimmer blurted out.

"You knew it would happen?" Adora replied.

"No, although I remember thinking that the island has magic in it."

"If I didn't put my finger on the rocks, you wouldn't be trying to cut my hair. I'm sorry for not listening."

Glimmer's face softened. "I'm sorry for yelling. We didn't expect this, yet here we are."

Adora yawned. "For the time being, I may try to hide my hair. Let's call it a night."

The two women slipped into bed, and as usual, they cuddled beneath the covers. Adora closed her eyes, replaying tonight's events in her mind. The images transitioned into a single dream. Somehow, the dream was more ominous. At first, she attempted to regulate her breathing and ignore her rapid heartbeat. Despite Glimmer's proximity, Adora's body temperature sank...

...

The castle hallway was dark. All Adora could see were faceless shadows. Her gaze flitted around the area for a light source; only the area around her body was lit. Why was it so dark and creepy in here? She began walking, but her movements were slow. Something or someone could be lurking in the blackness, waiting

to ambush her. A faint image of Glimmer flashed before her. As she reached the end of the hallway, the door creaked open, revealing a familiar room. She had been here before, but when? Entering the room, she detected a hooded figure standing in front of the window.

"Welcome home, my flower," Shadow Weaver said.

"I thought you were gone," Adora replied.

"What's the matter, dear? Aren't you happy to see your mommy?"

"You're not my mother."

Shadow Weaver approached Adora and stroked her cheek. "Come back to the tower. You will be safe and sound."

Dozens of rocks sprung from the floor, surrounding Adora. Sinister laughter rang through the air. She attempted to flee, only to be hindered by more rocks. Thunder boomed. What was happening? Had Shadow Weaver pretended to be dead the whole time?

...

Adora's eyes flung open; she began tossing and turning, suppressing an urge to scream. She let out a faint whimper. Shadows lingered in the darkness. All she could think about was escaping an unseen threat. A soft, gentle voice spoke to her. She glanced at Glimmer, and her heartbeat slowed down.

"Breathe," Glimmer said.

Adora took in a deep breath.

"Did you have a nightmare?"

"Yes," Adora whispered.

"What was it about?"

"Shadow Weaver. Those rocks. My hair."

"You're safe here. Shadow Weaver's gone." Glimmer pulled Adora into an embrace. "And nothing's going to hurt you as long as I'm here."

Adora's heart fluttered. Although she was too tired to speak at this point, she didn't want to return to dreamland. For the rest of the night, she remained in bed, listening to Glimmer's snoring. Early in the morning, her exhaustion won over, and she drifted off to sleep.

Two Princesses and a Cat

Chapter Summary

> Catra and her soldiers infiltrate the castle. Adora reveals her hair to her family.

Morning came. Adora hid her hair under a wig before leaving the room. Due to the wig's height, a few individuals gave her strange looks. There had to be a reason behind her hair being indestructible. Her lack of sleep weighed down on her as she strode to the courtyard to have breakfast with her family. As usual, Glimmer accompanied her. If the wig fell off, her family would freak out over the sudden return of magic hair.

"You seem tired," Marlena said. "Are you okay?"

"Of course," Adora said. "It's just that I'm getting used to all this after eighteen years."

Randor clasped his hands together. "After some consideration, I came to the conclusion that my methods seemed too strict and unfair."

"Does it mean the guards will stop tailing me? Will I get more freedom?" Adora asked.

Perhaps their last conversation got through to Randor. But Adora couldn't read his mind. She would be glad to gain some freedom. To her, it meant going on trips with Glimmer, making new friends, and exploring the world. Holding her breath, she waited for an answer - the one she wanted to hear so bad.

"It means I'm willing to reconsider those methods," Randor said. "But I make no promises."

Marlena smiled. "Adora, you will greet the nobles today."

"Where are they?" Adora asked.

"They will be here soon. I expect you to display ladylike behavior and to exercise restraint."

Adora's wig began sliding; she caught it before it could expose her hair. How much longer before it fell off? Would she be forced to come clean at one point? She flashed a watery smile.

"I should go," Adora said. "I have a lot of princess-ing up to do!"

Adora grabbed Glimmer's hand, led her into the castle, and made her way to her room. For a second, she wondered if she could try cutting her hair again, only to remember the failed attempts. The shorter woman opened a door leading to a walk-in closet, causing Adora to recall the floor-length gown. She could wear it again to conceal her bare feet. The nobles wouldn't notice. But if she stepped on grass outside, the dirt could stick to her soles. Same thing with puddles. No wonder the maids asked her to wear shoes. What was wrong with feeling the ground beneath her feet? The tickle of grass against exposed skin, the splash of water, and even the smoothness of polished floors-

"Found a dress," Glimmer announced, holding up a gown. It was more pinkish in color compared to what Adora usually wore.

"I'm not sure about it," Adora said. "Are there other options?"

"There is. Its color is cream, with gold accents."

"Floor-length?"

"Ankle-length. Is that okay with you?"

"It's fine, I guess."

Glimmer rushed back into the closet. "Wait here!"

Adora walked toward her mirror, then stared at her reflection. Not too long ago, she had a bob, and because the magic hair grew back last night, she had to wear this wig. It made her feel

ridiculous. However, what was a girl to do? Footsteps approached; she turned around.

"Do you need help putting it on?" Glimmer asked.

"No," Adora said. "I suggest turning around and not taking a single peek."

"Tell me when you're done."

Adora switched out of her gown and slipped into the cream and gold dress. The wig wobbled a few times, yet it didn't fall off. At least, not yet. If she left the magical rocks alone, she wouldn't have to worry about wearing a wig. A small part of her hoped it would be temporal. What if it was permanent?

"I'm finished," Adora said.

Glimmer whirled around. "The color looks nice on you."

"I can't wear my tiara, though. So... why did my hair resist your magic?"

"I don't know. To be fair, I'm still not as powerful as my father. My aunt Castaspella might have insight on indestructible hair. I'll send her-"

"You can't tell her. No one needs to know!"

Glimmer stroked her chin. "What should we do?"

Adora tucked a golden strand into her wig. "Live with it, I guess? Let me tell you something. There has to be a way to know why the rocks would trigger hair growth."

"How do we seek out the answer? Visit the island again and ask some ancient spirit?"

"Glim, I..." Words lodged themselves in Adora's throat as she rubbed her temples. "I don't want to keep lying to my family. The

magical hair was what got me kidnapped eighteen years ago. Do you know a spell that reverses time?"

"No, I haven't learned such a spell."

"Great." Adora dug her nails into her palms. "Guess the problem will be permanent."

When it was time for Adora to greet the nobles, Glimmer escorted the blonde outside, where the carriages would arrive. The king and queen were here, too. Adora stood next to them, smiling; the grin seemed forced. A carriage halted in front of them. Its design wasn't fancy; no decorations, lace, or family symbols. Maybe this noble preferred to keep it simple. A tanned woman with cat ears and a suit emerged. Wait a minute. As far as she knew, Catra wasn't a noble. Did Hordak send Catra here?

"Lady C'yra of D'riluth," Catra called herself.

"Oh, nice to meet you!" Adora exclaimed as she rushed to hug Catra. "My name's Adora!"

"Get off of me!"

Glimmer expected Catra to attack; instead, the magicat simply pushed Adora off. She could see the anger in Catra's mismatched eyes. In Adora's eyes, hurt. Why did Catra disguise herself as a noble? It took all of Glimmer's willpower to not lash out at Catra.

"Sorry," Adora said.

"We don't know each other well," Catra replied.

"Still, it's been nice talking to you."

"I better go."

The next carriage came. A tall, muscular woman with white hair stepped out, wearing a black gown with red accents. Glimmer

swore she had seen her before. Wasn't she one of those Bright Moon guards? This could be Scorpia.

"Duchess Lynda D'Ream," Scorpia said.

"You look more like a warrior than a noble," Adora said.

"Funny you should mention that. I, ah, used to be a soldier."

"How much can you lift?"

Glimmer pressed her lips into a thin line. There was nothing impressive about Scorpia. Also, Scorpia and Catra could be working together. Was anyone else with them? Only time would tell.

"I used to have super long hair, and I would use it to pull someone up," Adora said.

"Isn't this your hair?" Scorpia asked .

"It's a wig."

"I have to go."

Once Adora was done greeting nobles, Glimmer took her aside. Something wasn't right, as Catra's presence could bring trouble. No way Glimmer would ignore a possible threat.

"They're lying. Their real names are Catra and Scorpia," Glimmer whispered.

Adora tilted her head. "Do you know them?"

"They were guards from the castle in Bright Moon. I have to know if Hordak sent them here, and if anyone's with them."

"Oh, so now I can't choose who I can befriend?"

"No. That's not what-"

Adora backed away. "I'm going to my room to clear my head."

Glimmer reached for Adora's wrist; the blonde distanced herself. "Adora, I'm not trying to control you. Can you let- wait!"

Adora raced into the castle before Glimmer could continue speaking. Glimmer hung her head; Proceeding through the door, she ambled to a corridor and navigated the wide halls. Her mind drifted to the way Angella would speak to her. Did she sound like her mother? All she wanted to do was make sure Adora wasn't in any danger. She wandered into an adjacent hallway and detected Catra talking to the guards. Why was the magicat bothering them? Despite not remembering every guard's face and name, the trio seemed suspicious.

"Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, I suggest finding the girl who hugged me earlier," Catra said. "Bring her to me."

"We will," the woman with dreadlocks replied.

The trio left the hallway. Glimmer jumped in front of Catra, hindering her. She grabbed the magicat's shirt and drew her closer, despite their height difference. It was obvious; the intruders were up to no good! And she had to do something.

"Catra, why are you here?" Glimmer demanded.

"Do you have any plans to stop Hordak?" Catra replied.

"Answer my question, scum."

Catra dug her nails into Glimmer's wrists. "I don't have time for this."

Glimmer ignored the pain in her wrists. "Hordak made you come here, didn't he? Did anything happen to my mother, by the way?"

"Hordak's the king now. Your mother's gone. Guess your companion is more important than an entire kingdom, after all."

"Fuck off!"

Fiery magic heated Glimmer's palms as she rammed her foot into Catra's abdomen. Tears streaming down her cheeks, she unleashed a spell at Catra. The magicat evaded the fireball. All she could think about was killing the enemy. It was callous of Catra to speak so casually about the queen's death. And she hated it. She glowered at Catra, watching as the brunette escaped the hallway. Blinking back her tears, she stormed through the door and began searching for Catra.

Adora paced back and forth in her bedroom, muttering under her breath. Why did people keep insisting on babysitting her? First, it was her parents. Then, the guards. Even Glimmer tried to decide who she could befriend. Did Glimmer act like that in response to seeing C'yra push Adora? The door slammed open, interrupting her thoughts. A trio of guards stood in the doorway, glaring at her. Of all the guards in the castle, she hadn't seen the trio before. Were they new recruits?

"Catra, I mean, C'yra, wants to see you," the skinny blonde man said.

"Seriously, Kyle?" The dark-skinned woman spat.

"Kyle, you blew her cover!" The broad-shouldered guard exclaimed.

Adora lifted a single brow. "Who are you guys? You're not guards, are you?"

"Lonnie? Rogelio? What should-" Kyle began.

"Can't you shut up?" Lonnie shouted. "We're getting the job done either way."

Adora yanked her wig off. "That does it! I want you out of here!"

The trio stared in shock as Adora swung her hair at them. A rope of blonde hair looped around the trio, restricting their movements. She stormed past them and pulled the intruders down the hall. It didn't matter whether anyone saw the hair or not. They had to go! Grunting, she moved past many doors and descended a flight of stairs. Behind her, they struggled, but failed, to break free. If the situation wasn't so serious, she would find it funny. Footsteps approached; she looked up, anticipating her family's reactions. Instead, she saw Glimmer chasing Catra.

"I caught the intruders!" Adora said.

Glimmer traced a rune and cast another spell at Catra. "How did you?"

"Hair."

"The real guards are here. Catra-"

Catra leapt out the window before anyone could catch her. The royal couple, along with the prince, entered the hallway. Adora flashed a nervous grin. Now they saw the truth; would her parents punish her for lying to them? She released the intruders, allowing the guards to arrest them.

"Adora... how did your hair grow back?" Randor asked.

"I can explain," Adora replied.

"Guards, take those intruders to the dungeon. Everyone else, give us a moment."

Within seconds, everyone else left. Randor wore a disappointed frown. Adora swore she saw another emotion in his eyes. She could lie to him, but then the truth might come out. Well, he already saw her hair. If she told him that she snuck out with Glimmer, she might not see Glimmer again.

"Last night, I snuck out, sailed to an island, and touched a magical rock. No one accompanied me," Adora explained.

"So... you went beyond the Kingdom of Grayskull and found a rock, causing your hair to return?" Randor asked.

"Yes."

"And you acted alone?"

"I know you're angry. Can't you see I'm okay? I'm more than okay, I-"

"Adora, there's something I need to tell you. The night you were taken, a part of me died. The best part of me. For eighteen years, I swore that if the fates showed mercy and returned you to me, I would never let anything bad happen to you again. Since this has returned, I am left with no choice. As of tonight, I am forced to exercise my martial right as king to forbid you from leaving the Kingdom of Grayskull without my consent."

"Yet Adam is allowed to leave whenever he wants," Adora said. "I am not a defenseless child. I took down the intruders. Father, if you would just-"

"Go to your room," Randor interrupted.

A few days passed as Catra and Scorpia returned to Bright Moon without the rest of their group. She made her way to Hordak's secret room to speak with him. Despite the disappointment in the king's eyes, she didn't tell him anything. This wouldn't go well. He could demote her or worse, fire her. Entrapta was stuck in Grayskull somewhere, Rogelio and the others could be in the dungeon, and she didn't gain any information from Glimmer regarding what the princess might do to Hordak.

"It was a test," Hordak said. "And you failed."

"How do you know?" Catra asked.

"I used a spell to gain insight on your mission. The code names and disguises were decent. However, the plan flopped."

"I could go back for Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Entrapta."

"You will not gather them without backup. Anyways, I will discuss a strategy with our soldiers in the war room. Do not tamper with anything. Understand?"

"I understand."

Once Hordak left the room, Catra turned to face the mirror, shoulders slumping as she hugged herself. For a commander, she sure was worthless. If she couldn't serve a purpose, what was the point of existing? Out of the corner of her eye, she detected a green glow in the mirror. Light flooded the glass, prompting her to squint.

"We meet again-" a voice began.

"Horde Prime, I'm not Hordak," Catra said.

A silhouette materialized in the mirror. "You're one of his soldiers, then."

"A commander. I think he regrets giving me the promotion." Catra peeked into a pair of bright green eyes. "To him, I'm just a discardable asset."

"He's not the first person in your life to see something wrong with you."

"How do you know?"

"I possess an ability to see into someone's past."

"You do?"

"Of course, little sister. When you were a child, did a woman abandon you?"

Catra gritted her teeth. "She did. Can you guess her name?"

Horde Prime smirked. "Sure. The woman is..." He paused, as if for dramatic effect. "Shadow Weaver."

"Look into her past. Tell me why she left me."

"Eighteen years ago, after Shadow Weaver left you at an orphanage, she took the Princess of Grayskull from the girl's family and hid her in a tower."

"Shadow Weaver left me for Princess Adora?"

Horde Prime placed a hand onto his chest. "I apologize if the story causes you pain. Shadow Weaver never loved you, did she? You've been cast aside your entire life. Don't count on Hordak to let you keep your current position as commander. He'll replace you with someone he thinks is better."

Catra scowled. "I'm not letting people cast me aside anymore. No longer will I overwork myself to prove my worth to others who refuse to see it."

An Angry Cat

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Glimmer visit Entrapta in Gray Haven, seeking answers about the hair. Catra visits the kingdom again.

One day, before the end of the month, Adora and Glimmer decided to explore the town of Gray Haven. Prior to this, Glimmer had invited Bow and Perfuma to Gray Haven. The weather had warmed up a little, although not as pleasant as the spring temperatures. Glimmer wore a lavender handmaiden gown this time, instead of the usual tunic and leggings combination. Adora's hair had been pulled back into a braid to minimize chances of people stepping on her blonde locks. Both women made their way to the local pub to grab some lunch. Once they entered the building, they saw Bow and Perfuma sitting by the window.

"Hi!" Glimmer exclaimed as she pulled Adora to the table.

"Hey," Bow said. "How's your romance with Adora so far?"

"It's been great. How about you and Perfuma?"

"Good. Perfuma and I will go on a date tonight. We'll ride a boat." Bow turned his attention to Perfuma. "I have a surprise."

Glimmer occupied an empty seat. "Are you going to propose to her?"

"If the relationship changes, I'll tell you. For now, Perfuma and I are enjoying ourselves."

Adora sat next to Glimmer. "So, romance aside, my hair grew back after I touched magical rocks. Now I'm forbidden from leaving the Kingdom of Grayskull. This hair, due to its healing power, is the reason I got stolen when I was a baby. I want to seek out answers regarding my hair."

Glimmer made eye contact. "Did you forget what your father said?"

"I'm not leaving Grayskull."

"Maybe there's a way to find answers." Glimmer leaned in, then moved her face closer to Adora's ear. "I've heard rumors of a wizard moving into Dryl Cottage. She calls herself Entrapta."

Adora's eyes widened. "A wizard?"

Bow and Perfuma gave the duo odd looks.

Glimmer held up a finger. "Bow, if you'll excuse us, we'll go somewhere else to talk." She snatched Adora's wrist and yanked her outside. They made their way to an alley.

"So, visiting a wizard is more important than getting lunch?" Adora asked.

"We'll get some sandwiches and visit Dryl Cottage."

"How about sitting down to eat?"

"We'll eat while we walk." Glimmer scrutinized the alley. "By the way, not every rumor of Entrapta is positive. Some say she blows things up."

"If we want answers, she's our best bet, right?" Adora said.

"Yes."

"Sounds like we have a wizard to visit."

They returned to the pub and sat down. Ten minutes passed as they chatted with Bow and Perfuma. When Bow mentioned Queen Angella, Glimmer's mind drifted to the last time she spoke with the older woman. Why did their last conversation end in an argument? A memory of the night she left Bright Moon surfaced. How was her mother feeling in those last moments of life?

Scared? Worried? Were the queen's last thoughts filled with memories of Glimmer and Micah? Also, how did Castaspella respond to Hordak taking over after Angella's death? Did Castaspella suspect his motives?

"I should have gone back and apologized to her," Glimmer said. "She's gone now, which means I can't make it up to her." Tears leaked from her eyes.

Adora placed a hand onto Glimmer's shoulder. "I'm sorry for your loss." She pulled the shorter woman into a side hug.

Once Adora and Glimmer received their sandwiches, they began navigating the town, searching for Dryl Cottage. A few people acknowledged the blonde's presence with curtsies, bows, and waves. Smiling, Adora waved at the strangers. A group of children stopped to give her flowers. One boy showed off an adorable puppy, asking her to pet it. She stroked the puppy's soft body and fed the dog a piece of her sandwich. It didn't take long for the children to run off. The duo ambled past multiple buildings and reached the outskirts of town. A cottage, surrounded by greenery, beckoned them closer. The sign by the stone path said: "Dryl Cottage."

"So, this is Entrapta's place," Adora said.

"Yeah," Glimmer replied.

They strode to the door; Adora knocked multiple times. No one answered. The door creaked open, spilling fog onto the steps. Was the cottage filled with fog? Leading Glimmer into the residence, she glanced around. It was dark in here. Purple light illuminated the area; she looked at Glimmer. The shorter woman was carrying an orb of light.

"Watch your step," Glimmer said as they walked into a room.

"It's just fog. I'm sure it's okay," Adora replied. "I hope Entrapta doesn't mind us coming in here without asking."

Footsteps approached them from behind, prompting them to whirl around. A pair of glowing eyes gave them a menacing stare. Adora didn't have a good feeling about this. Perhaps she and her love should leave before anything bad happened.

The silhouette removed their mask, revealing a woman's face as she stepped forward. "Princesses, I didn't know anyone would be interested in science or my inventions."

"I want to ask you about my hair-" Adora began.

"I've heard stories of your hair returning. Some say you have the magic of the golden flower inside you." Entrapta grabbed a strand of golden hair. "I wonder how it grew back."

"I touched the magic rocks. They were on a distant island. Now my hair's indestructible."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Entrapta, I have a question here. How did you know I was a princess?"

Entrapta grabbed a magnifying glass and peeked at Adora's hair. "I came from Bright Moon."

Glimmer fixated her gaze on Entrapta. "Do you know Catra, Scorpia, and their friends?"

"I do. But they left me here without explanation."

"Did you help them in any way?" Glimmer crossed her arms. "What do you think of Hordak ruling Bright Moon?"

Entrapta picked up a dagger and attempted to cut off a strand; the blade shattered. "So, it really is indestructible. It must be made of tough material."

"Entrapta, aren't you a wizard?" Adora asked.

"No. I don't know where you got the idea. I'm a scientist!"

"A scientist?"

Entrapta led Adora to a machine and proceeded to bind her to it. "I'm going to run some tests here. By the way, this is a recent invention."

The machine spun Adora around, tugged at her hair, and reverted to its original position. "Are you done running tests?"

"It's the first test. I'll do eighty-six more."

Glimmer grabbed the broken blade. "Entrapta, she's a person, not a thing to be experimented on."

Entrapta glanced at Glimmer. "I haven't figured out what her hair was made of." She pulled a lever.

"Uh, what does the lever - wait, what are you doing?"

A whirring blade hovered above Adora. The edges were sharp and could easily cut someone if it was pressed into a person's body. But Entrapta was going for her hair, right? As she waited for the scientist to continue the tests, she heard Glimmer shouting at Entrapta and telling her to safely conclude that all experiments were failures.

"I am not letting you take her apart!" Glimmer hollered.

"I'm going to test the blade on the hair, not-" Entrapta began.

"Well, it looks dangerous!" Glimmer summoned a pair of magical spheres. "Did Catra tell you to do this?"

"No. I haven't talked to her ever since she left."

Glimmer gripped Entrapta's shirt. "You better not deceive us. I don't trust you, and this thing, whatever it is, could hurt Adora. She means a lot to me!"

Entrapta lowered the blade to Adora's hair; the blade flew off and glided toward a wall. Glimmer balled her hands into angry cannonballs. Adora had a feeling the shorter woman would continue yelling at the scientist. She knew how protective Glimmer could be sometimes, and this was no exception. Glimmer shot Entrapta a death glare. It wouldn't be surprising if the pink-haired princess resorted to violence. Hopefully she didn't, although she might do it. As Glimmer continued her rant, the ground shook.

"What's going on?" Adora asked.

"Entrapta, are you hiding something that could harm people?" Glimmer added.

Entrapta shrugged. "I have another invention in the basement. It's probably unstable."

"Then turn it off!"

Another tremor rattled the cottage.

"You better have an explanation for this!" Glimmer said, shaking the broken blade in front of Entrapta's face. "Release Adora right now, and turn off your devices. I swear, if she gets hurt, I may report you to the king and queen."

The entire building began crumbling. Adora expected Glimmer to go after Entrapta; instead, the shorter woman glowered at the scientist as the latter escaped. Glimmer pulled at the restraints, struggling to free Adora.

"I didn't think this would happen," Glimmer said. "Entrapta did blow something up. I'm sorry for bringing you here."

"It's okay," Adora replied. "Don't you have the magic to teleport me out?"

"I don't want to teleport this contraption with us."

Large piles of rubble fell around them, trapping the duo. Adora squeezed her eyes shut. Eventually, she sensed her hair moving. A bright, golden light flooded her eyelids. What was going on? Was her hair doing something? Could it feel her emotions? She became aware of Glimmer hugging her. Within minutes, her eyes fluttered open. Somehow the restraints had fallen off.

"Did your hair form a shield?" Glimmer asked as she released Adora.

Adora twisted a strand around her finger. "I don't know. But the most important thing is that we're alive."

"I agree. Let's find Entrapta."

"What are you going to say to her?"

"I'll tell her not to do anything dangerous again."

Glimmer and Adora strode to the town square, discussing failed inventions and lack of answers. Her gaze flitted from alleys to shops. Where did Entrapta go? Did the scientist leave the town? Or did Catra find her? The latter seemed unlikely, though. Someone could have gotten killed in Dryl Cottage. Glimmer led Adora to the fountain and sat down. The blonde ran her fingers along the water, forming small ripples in the reflection. Adora must have felt disappointed, because the princess hadn't found any answers regarding magical hair. Glimmer could send a letter to Castaspella and ask her for insight on indestructible hair. However, her aunt might not have answers, either.

"Are we ever going to know the reason behind my hair's regrowth?" Adora asked.

"I could write a letter to Castaspella. She knows magic, and she doesn't blow stuff up," Glimmer said.

"The problem is, I've never met her in person."

"She has never harmed anyone, so there's not gonna be a problem when she visits us."

"Earlier, Entrapta tried to help. I think you were a little harsh on her."

The image of the whirring blade surfaced in Glimmer's mind. "I was trying to protect you. All that stuff in Dryl Cottage, it could kill anyone."

Adora folded her hands on her lap. "Entrapta didn't attack me. She performed the experiments, and it didn't go well because her home collapsed."

"Still, you're a person. Your safety comes first."

"So do yours. My hair protected both of us." Adora stared at the clouds in the bright blue expanse. "I believe I have some sort of power. It must be why the rocks glowed, and why they made my hair grow."

"Can you still heal people?"

"It requires an incantation. I'll try it and see if the power's still in my hair."

Flower, gleam and glow

Let your power shine

Make the clock reverse

Bring back what once was mine

Adora finished singing. Glimmer didn't see a golden glow. The ability to heal must have disappeared when she cut off all that hair.

"You no longer have the ability to heal," Glimmer said.

"It did glow when forming a shield," Adora replied.

Footsteps approached the duo. "Hey, Sparkles."

Glimmer looked up. Anger heated her veins at the sight of Catra. Why was the magicat here? Was Catra about to cause more trouble? Rising to her height, she grabbed the brunette's shirt. If Catra asked the royal family to release the three intruders, they would hear none of it. Rogelio, Kyle, and Lonnie didn't deserve to regain freedom.

"I'm here to tell blondie something," Catra said.

Glimmer's fingers dug into the fabric. "Her name's Adora, in case you've forgotten. And if you hurt her, I will make you pay!"

Catra hissed as she pried Glimmer's hands off her shirt. "I discovered information about Shadow Weaver. She was my adoptive mother, and one day, she abandoned me at an orphanage." She turned her attention to Adora. "Weaver cast me aside for you!"

Adora rose her brows. "I didn't know she did that to you."

"She never returned for me. What did she see in you?"

"Shadow Weaver used me for my hair. It had healing powers."

"So that's what made you special?" Catra swung a hand at Adora's face; her claws dug into the blonde's skin, drawing blood. "No wonder Shadow Weaver chose you over me!"

Glimmer shoved Catra backward, then stepped in front of Adora. "Catra, leave her alone! Even if Shadow Weaver abandoned you, it's not an excuse to attack my girlfriend. You need to stop."

Catra's ears flattened against her head. "And what will you do if I don't stop? Give me more empty threats? You fought me in the castle. What's stopping you right now?"

Several bystanders froze, observing the confrontation. A few guards advanced, pointing their weapons in Catra's direction.

Glimmer traced a rune in the air, then unleashed a wind spell at the magicat. The spell knocked Catra off her feet, sending her flying toward a food stall. Catra forced herself up and raced down the street.

Glimmer pursued Catra past dozens of buildings and trees. Despite the exhaustion seeping into her legs, she refused to take a break from running. Sweat poured down her forehead as she panted. Her enemy was fast. By the time they reached the bridge, Catra was already on the way out. It was surprising that the magicat didn't take Entrapta with her.

Black Rocks?

Chapter Summary

> More black rocks appear. Glimmer sends a letter to her aunt, Castaspella.

Glimmer and Adora went to the castle and entered the blonde's room. For the next several minutes, she tended to Adora's wound while they sat on the bed. Who gave Catra the information regarding Shadow Weaver? She didn't know much about the old sorceress, other than the story of Mystacor Academy and the fact that for eighteen years, Shadow Weaver raised Adora. Maybe the truth came from someone who possessed an ability to see into the past. Adora's fingertips brushed the bandage. Catra's scratch would leave behind a scar.

"Did you say something?" Glimmer asked.

"I did nothing to provoke Catra, yet she attacked me," Adora said. "Somehow my hair was a reason for Catra to scratch my face."

"She's an awful person. You don't deserve that."

"Anyways, are you going to search for Entrapta?"

"Yes. Are you okay with me being gone for a while?"

"Of course."

"If I ever see Catra again-"

"I know, I know. You don't have to repeat yourself. Glim, it's cute when you protect me." Adora rested her hands on Glimmer's. "But I can defend myself. I used my hair to tie up the intruders, remember? And I once hit someone with a frying pan."

"Catra hurt you. Listen, I know you can defend yourself, but sometimes you have to let others take care of you." Glimmer

tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. "I'm going right now."

Adora kissed Glimmer's cheek. "See you later."

Despite being accustomed to the layout of Grayskull's capital, Glimmer had yet to find Entrapta. Where could the scientist be? She thought of Adora's comment regarding being harsh on Entrapta. Was it true, or did Adora expect her to be super nice to Entrapta? Adora's safety would always be a priority to her. Glimmer wouldn't apologize for protecting the blonde. As she made her way to the outskirts of Gray Haven, she peeked at the rubble that was once Dryl Cottage. The scientist had to be on the island somewhere. If not in Gray Haven, probably somewhere else. She wandered along the dirt path, scrutinizing the area.

Glimmer stumbled into a small village with decent spacing between houses. Snatches of conversations drifted into her ears; one old woman mentioned unbreakable rocks emerging from the ground. If there were magical rocks on this island, how did they get here? She reached the end of the road, then detected a sign by a small home. It read: "Dryl Cottage 2.0." Would Entrapta give all her houses the same name after this?

Glimmer closed the distance between herself and the door, then knocked. There was no answer; it reminded her of the other place Entrapta had lived in. Stepping inside, she shut the door behind her. Entrapta was experimenting on black rocks. How did those things get in here? Didn't the scientist realize how dangerous they were?

"What are they from?" Entrapta asked.

"Those rocks were originally on a distant island, where the magical flower used to be," Glimmer said.

"They're from another island?"

"Yeah. They were following Adora, and-"

"Are they connected? Can she-"

"No more crazy experiments on her, okay? Also, she's not here."

Entrapta pulled down her metal mask, concealing her face. "Are you still mad at me?"

"No. Don't make any more dangerous stuff." Glimmer crossed her arms. "And don't run tests on people."

"It sounds like you're mad at me."

"I'll tell you what. Whenever I'm serious, I use this tone. My mother used a firm tone of voice, too, when telling me not to do something."

"Oh."

A sickly green concoction sunk into the black rocks. Entrapta snatched a magnifying glass from the desk and peered at the concoction. "Ooh, fascinating! Also, it emits the yellow spikes."

Glimmer furrowed her brows. "Yellow spikes?"

Entrapta nodded. "Mm-hmm."

Glimmer watched as multiple yellow spikes emerged from the rocks. "Whatever you put on there is going to make it worse."

"Well, I can see that, but-"

Larger spikes stretched toward Entrapta; Glimmer unleashed an air spell at her, shoving her out of the way. She didn't know which was worse - the spikes or the rocks. Both could impale someone, though. The scientist gathered many tools and vials, then hurried to the door. Glimmer led her outside, and to her shock, more black rocks had appeared in the village. A few families lost their homes and farms. The royal family of Grayskull had to know about this.

"Looks like it got worse," Glimmer said. "Entrapta, promise me you'll stop inventing dangerous stuff."

"I won't stop being a scientist," Entrapta replied.

"Someone could get hurt." Glimmer pointed at the affected buildings and crops. "The black rocks are displacing families and destroying farms."

"I'm not controlling the rocks."

Glimmer sighed. "I'm going to investigate this. Even if you're not responsible for what happened, you still shouldn't mess with something you know nothing about."

Glimmer made her way back to Gray Haven, replaying the conversation in her mind. It wouldn't be surprising if Entrapta moved into a third house and named it "Dryl Cottage 3.0." Maybe it was Entrapta's favorite name for a residence. The outside temperature began to sink. Of course the weather would do this a few weeks before spring. She ambled through town and reached the bridge. Strangely enough, she didn't see as many black rocks on the bridge or in the middle of the water. Should she teleport to the other side, or just travel on foot? If she teleported, there might be a chance of colliding into a cluster of black rocks. However, if she made the latter choice, it could take some time to cross the bridge. Footsteps approached, prompting her to whirl around.

Bow and Perfuma were holding hands. He said, "I heard rumors about the confrontation in the town square. How's Adora doing?"

"She's fine. The only thing Catra did was scratch Adora's face," Glimmer replied.

"Why did she do it?"

"Catra blamed Adora for what Shadow Weaver did. If anyone is at fault, it is Weaver. She abandoned Catra at an orphanage when Adora was a baby. I'm sure it broke Catra's heart, but she chose

to be bitter and angry. That aside, large magical rocks have been showing up on the island ever since Adora's hair grew back. They're indestructible."

"So, are you going to do anything about the rocks?"

"I don't know. I'll tell the King and Queen of Grayskull. They need to know what was going on." Glimmer turned her attention to the bridge. "Perfuma, can you check on Plumeria and see if there's any magical rocks over there, too?"

Perfuma snaked an arm around Bow's. "I guess the date will have to wait."

"Make sure Plumeria is okay. If you find anything unusual, you can tell me. Oh, and check on Bright Moon, too."

After an hour or two of dealing with monotonous etiquette lessons and princess duties, Adora joined her family in the dining hall. Would the bandage on her face give the king a reason to restrict her freedom even more? Her family and the guards still treated her like a fragile piece of china, and honestly, she was done. Even her girlfriend insisted on fighting her battles. There was always something whenever she left the castle. If she told her family what happened at Dryl Cottage, King Randor would demand that she be locked up and watched every single second. She glanced at Glimmer; the shorter woman seemed ready to say something.

"King Randor, Queen Marlena, there are magical rocks popping up around Grayskull," Glimmer said. "They're unbreakable, and something has to be done about them."

"My soldiers can take care of the problem," Randor said.

"What have they done, other than following Adora around?"

"Well, it's their job to protect my daughter. She'll be queen someday. When Marlena and I are gone, you must take care of Adora."

"She's the strongest person I know. You might not see it, but I can."

Adora held Glimmer's hand, fingers intertwining. "Glimmer, do you really think that I'm a strong person, or are you just saying those words?"

Glimmer wore a soft smile. "I'm not just saying those words. You *are* strong and brave."

"You, too. So, are you going to send a letter to Castaspella tonight?"

"Yep."

"Won't it take her a day or two to come to Grayskull?"

"She could always teleport across long distances. But that can take up quite a bit of magical energy. And she doesn't even know what any part of the kingdom looks like."

Adora released Glimmer's hand. "So, when do you plan on saving Bright Moon?"

Glimmer shrugged. "It's a good question. My magic has gotten a little better, for sure. However, according to Castaspella, it can take a few years to master my magic."

"So, why can't she defeat Hordak?"

"When it comes to fighting, she couldn't stand a chance against powerful sorcerers. My father's more experienced than she is."

Randor cleared his throat. "Now's not the time to worry about other kingdoms. Tomorrow, Marlena and I will go on an anniversary trip. Adora, you will be queen until we come back."

"Queen?" Adora repeated.

"That's right," Marlena answered. "It'll be temporary, though. Someday, you will inherit the throne, and you may have to make important decisions. You can choose what kind of queen you will be."

"In the meantime, can't I have the freedom to go on adventures with Glimmer? She can protect me."

Randor shook his head. "I want to know how you're doing at all times. We've talked about this before."

White-hot anger boiled in Adora's veins as she struggled to maintain a neutral expression. Where had she heard a similar phrase? Why was her father acting like Shadow Weaver? While Adam was enjoying his trips out of the castle, she was staying behind. She wanted to lash out at her father for deciding where she could go and couldn't go.

Adora, you asked me many times, and I said no. You're not ready for the real world.

"You know, you are not the first person to restrict my freedom and make excuses for why I shouldn't go anywhere," Adora said. "Where's Adam right now, out to dinner with Teela and enjoying yet another adventure?"

"Adora, that's enough," Randor said.

For the rest of the dinner, everyone ate in silence. Unspoken words lingered on Adora's tongue, anticipating their release. Why wouldn't the king and queen listen to her? It wasn't fair to deal with strict rules while Adam got to do whatever he wanted to do. The moment she finished her meal, she led Glimmer into the hallway. This time, there wasn't a fleet of guards in the hallway waiting to follow her around.

"You're not staying for dessert?" Glimmer asked. "Usually, you would. Is something the matter?"

"Sort of," Adora said. "I feel like they expect me to be the kind of queen who doesn't do anything but sit on the throne all day. The way my father spoke to me, it reminded me of Shadow Weaver. Both of them told me I wasn't ready for the real world. Also, they forbade me from going somewhere, yet it's somehow okay for someone else to leave. In Shadow Weaver's case, she left whenever she wanted to. And in the royal family's case, Adam-"

"I get it. Speaking of parents..." Glimmer's voice took on a somber tone. "Don't make the same mistake I made. You never know when something will happen to your parents. I couldn't apologize to my mom because she's gone."

"All you said was that we were going to a library."

"I was giving my mother an attitude. No wonder she didn't want to argue."

"I probably didn't notice. Back then, I was more focused on the journey to see the lanterns."

Glimmer began escorting Adora through the hallway. "Sure you were. Anyways, all I'm saying is that if your last interaction with your parents is an argument, you may regret the way you acted and spoke."

Adora paced ahead of Glimmer. "This is different. I grew up in the tower for eighteen years, isolated from the entire world and never allowed to go outside. My father is the one making a mistake! I have every right to be pissed."

"Not every parental figure is like Shadow Weaver."

"I'll go to my room and clear my head."

They strode to Adora's room. While she grabbed a journal and plopped onto the bed, Glimmer sat by the desk and began writing a letter. Adora scribbled an entire paragraph onto a page, pouring out her heart. In the entry, she mentioned her feelings regarding the princess life. She knew Glimmer had a point, but the shorter

woman had never been locked up in a tower for almost two decades. Their childhoods were different, after all. Once she finished writing her entry, she peeked at Glimmer.

"How's the letter going?" Adora asked.

"I'm almost done," Glimmer said. "Your parents told you that you'll be queen for a day, right? When it comes to ruling a kingdom, I have more training. If you need help-"

"I'll be fine. Mom says it'll be temporary. So, enough about me. Did you mention the black rocks in the letter?"

"I did. And I also asked if there were some in Bright Moon. I have a bad feeling about them." Glimmer dipped the quill into a small bottle of ink. "I mean, it seems as if something is controlling the rocks."

"Yeah. I want to solve the mystery, but my parents won't let me." Adora closed her journal and placed it onto the nightstand. "I hope Castaspella has some knowledge."

Glimmer conjured a rune and unleashed the spell. Within seconds, the letter vanished. After several minutes whizzed by, a scroll materialized. Unfurling the scroll, she walked over to Adora's bed and sat. "She sent me a reply. I'll read it to you." She began reading the letter...

...

> Dear Glimmer,
>
> I can't come to Grayskull, but in this letter, I can tell you what I know according to a legend. The black rocks are destructive creations of the Moonstone Opal. The Opal longs to be reunited with the Sundrop after they were divided. If the Opal and the Sundrop were to remain separated, the rocks will destroy everything in their path. I think the rocks have transferred their power into Adora's hair, which is the reason behind her hair becoming indestructible.

I hope you're doing alright, wherever you are. Hordak, the man who doesn't deserve the throne, is a tyrannical ruler. If anyone disagrees with his reign, they will be punished. Also, if people attempt to form a revolt, he will order his soldiers to execute anyone who defies him. They say you have betrayed your mother and won't return to Bright Moon. But I have a feeling it isn't true. Your parents and I know you better than many people do. My dear niece, you are loyal to your family and to those you care about. And I believe that someday, you will come back to Bright Moon and end Hordak's tyranny.

Love,
your Aunt Casta

...

"I hope everyone else in Bright Moon is okay," Glimmer said.

"Me, too," Adora replied. "The way Casta described Hordak's reign, it made me shudder."

"So, about the Moonstone Opal..." Glimmer rolled the letter. "We don't know where it is. Maybe if the Opal and the Sundrop reunite, they'll stop the rocks from growing."

The Blizzard

Chapter Summary

> Adora is queen for a day. A powerful blizzard comes to Grayskull.

Morning came. King Randor and Queen Marlena left the castle to go on their anniversary trip, leaving Adora to rule the kingdom for a day. According to her parents, the first thing she should do was listen to the concerns of their subjects. There were also important decisions to make, requests to pose for royal portraits, and dozens of other things on the list. Hundreds of people arrived at the castle to speak of their concerns. She couldn't deny how anxious it made her feel. After all, people were counting on her. How did her parents handle ruling a kingdom? This morning, Glimmer had offered to help her; for the second time, Adora said no. Maybe she should have said yes? As she occupied the throne, dozens of strangers entered the throne room.

A pair of men carried their sheep forward. The taller one said, "He won't let his sheep graze next to mine without a fight."

Another man with a slicked-back hairstyle said, "How can I cut hair with this guy fiddling day and night?" He snatched a violin from a musician.

Everyone else scrambled for Adora's attention.

"There are too many cats on the loose in Gray Haven. They eat everything in sight, they attack chickens, and they tempt dogs to chase them!" One woman shouted, holding up a box of cats.

"Well, everyone, listen to me," Adora announced. "To the men with the sheep, I have a suggestion. You'll have to share the land. There's no need to be selfish. To the one who cuts hair, you can have earplugs. You will receive a royal pair." She grabbed the box of cats and handed them to Glimmer. "We'll feed every cat and

kitten here within the palace square. They can play with each other instead of dogs and chickens."

"Are you sure this is the right solution?" Glimmer asked. "May I suggest-"

"I'm trying my best. Glim, take them to the palace square. You see, I'm busy right now."

"What if something goes wrong?"

"It'll be fine." Adora stroked a kitten's chin. "By the way, I'll continue listening to my subjects."

"Okay. Guess you've got this."

Adora turned her attention to the crowd. "Folks, the line starts there. You have to wait your turn."

Glimmer passed by a portrait of the royal family on the way to the palace square. The family seemed complete, unlike what she had seen at the mural in Gray Haven. While Adam stood next to Randor, Adora stood next to Marlena. She found herself staring at the princess. Even in portrait form, Adora's inner beauty shone through. The blonde's name was fitting, as everyone in the kingdom adored her. As Glimmer proceeded to the palace square, she watched more people entering the castle. Others had left the throne room, complaining. They sounded unpleased with the way Adora was running things. She could go back and give Adora some advice, but then the blonde would say some variation of "I'm fine" and "Don't worry about me." There wasn't anything wrong with being independent, yet she had a feeling her girlfriend wasn't doing well.

Sighing, Glimmer left the cats in the palace square and made her way to the courtyard. Today was cloudy, with no sunshine in sight. The cool air enveloped her as she strode to a bench. A male voice and a female voice garnered her attention. As it turned out, she wasn't the only one in the courtyard. Teela was swinging the

sword through the air, as if battling invisible enemies. Adam leaned against the stone wall, arms crossed.

"Is there anything you want to do today?" Adam asked.

"No. Besides, your parents ordered us to stay here in case something happens," Teela said.

"They worry too much. What's the worst that could happen?"

"It could be anything."

Glimmer stepped forward. "I doubt we'll have to deal with something crazy. The king and queen won't be away for too long, and Adora hasn't messed anything up so far."

Adam sighed. "She doesn't know a lot about politics and the possible burden that comes with ruling a kingdom."

"She won't let me help. So, let's see how it goes."

By the time it was afternoon, Adora was exhausted from her royal duties, and disappointed in herself. The sheep owners couldn't tell whose sheep belonged to either individual, the hair stylist couldn't hear customers, and the rats were everywhere in Gray Haven. It was a huge disaster, and everyone knew it. She had one job to master, and she blew it. So much for assuming that she would be fine. Her parents would do a much better job. Even Glimmer would, because the pink-haired princess had more training in politics. Compared to every royal she knew, she was inexperienced. Who knew how far she was from performing a great job as queen?

Adora made her way to the balcony outside her room, then leaned against the tall stone fence. She rested her elbows on the handrail, gazing at the land below. It was a mistake to refuse help. Glimmer would probably lecture her about how asking for help wasn't a sign of weakness. The door creaked open; she turned around. Glimmer must have been looking for her.

"How's your first day as queen?" Glimmer asked.

Adora rushed toward Glimmer and hugged her.

"Is everything okay?"

"I'm just..." Adora clasped her hands together. "I should have asked for advice. How am I ever going to do this?"

"You could let me guide you."

Adora returned to the fence. "I don't know if I'll be a decent queen someday. I, ah... I'll start with the sheep. The two men who owned them, they shared the pasture. And they couldn't tell whose sheep was theirs. There's the issue with the hair stylist and the violinist. The cats I gave you? They were quiet, but apparently it wasn't enough. The rats, as one lady said, are running everywhere."

Glimmer joined Adora, her elbow brushing against the blonde's. "Hey, relax. You hang in there one more day. It won't be a long time, as your parents will be home after their anniversary trip."

"I know. This isn't what I'm worried about. Someday, being queen will be my job every day, and I'm..." Adora glanced at the distant ocean. "I-I'm not sure if I can handle it all."

"Adora, come on. I'll rule by your side if we marry in the future. You won't have to do it on your own." Glimmer held Adora's hands. "Since leaving that tower, you've handled difficult things like the strong person you are. Do you think you would have been able to overcome hard stuff if you let fear take over? I know you didn't choose to be a princess, but, as I've said, someday, when we're both queens..." Her fingers intertwined with Adora's. "Well, I'm not sure what else to say, other than the fact that we're stronger together."

A snowflake landed onto Adora's nose. "Glim, I appreciate the comfort. I couldn't imagine life without you."

More snowflakes clung to Glimmer's hair, resembling stars in her pink and purple strands. "It's snowing."

"Oh, my gosh!" Adora exclaimed. "I've never been outside when it snows." She stuck out her tongue to catch the snowflakes.

"I thought spring was coming soon. Maybe the weather decided to delay the pleasant temperatures."

"Snow's not too bad. I'll tell the citizens to enjoy the snow."

"I'll get something warm to wear." Glimmer rubbed her arms. "Maybe you should wear boots, because they'll keep your feet warm. You don't want to get sick, do you?"

"You know, I'm still not a fan of shoes."

"Adora..." Glimmer arched a single brow.

"Okay, fine."

"Just looking out for you."

Adora giggled as she raced into her room and slipped into a warmer outfit. Thick fur lined the sleeves, neckline, and her boots. Perhaps the afternoon would turn out to be better than the morning, after all. She strode to the castle entrance and stepped outside, then waved at the citizens. Small children tossed snowballs at one another, older people chatted, and several inches of snow blanketed the ground. An afternoon of snow; the perfect ending to this day.

"Loyal subjects of Grayskull," Adora began, her voice garnering everyone's attention. "As your temporary queen, I officially declare today a snow day!"

The crowd cheered. Adora proceeded to descend a makeshift ice slide, chortling as she reached the bottom. Glimmer appeared in front of her; the shorter woman wore a long, lavender dress with

fur-lined sleeves and mittens. A gust of wind rippled through Glimmer's hair, giving it a messy appearance.

"Enjoying yourself?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said.

"I wonder if it's snowing in Bright Moon and everywhere else." Glimmer gathered a handful of snow. "When I was a kid, Bow and I did a lot of fun stuff whenever there's snow."

"Sounds fun. What would you do?"

"Snowball fights, igloos, and snow-people."

The two women gathered the snow and packed a pile into a large round shape. Several children copied their actions, albeit their creations were smaller than the duo's snow-person. Adora's hand brushed Glimmer's as they added final touches to their creation. She detected a flush on the pink-haired woman's face. It was hard to tell if the blush came from the physical contact or the cold. Either way, it was cute.

By nightfall, the wind began picking up speed. Glimmer followed Adora to a firepit; both women basked in the warmth of the fire. A small group joined them. Everyone's breaths emitted white clouds as they rubbed their hands. A sudden burst of wind rammed into Adora, knocking the blonde off her feet. Glimmer caught her before the princess could fall onto her back. Would there be a blizzard tonight? The snow showed no signs of stopping, and the temperature could sink below zero. She helped Adora up, but didn't release her until she was sure the blonde wouldn't fall.

"Thanks, Glim," Adora said. "I'm trying to get used to the weather." She faced the others. "Does it always snow this much?"

"Only once," a man replied. "At least, according to legend."

"Legend?"

"The legend of Horde Prime. Eons ago, a warlock, Horde Prime, had a deep hatred for the world and unleashed a curse which caused a blizzard to sweep across every kingdom. The storm destroyed everything in its path. If not for Mara, all would have been lost. Using both science and magic, Mara built a massive machine, deep in the Grayskull Mountains. Her powerful device possessed the ability to change the direction of the wind, and it pushed the flurries out to sea. Prime had been defeated. Some say the curse of the storm lives on and is waiting to strike again."

"Didn't Mara sacrifice herself?" Glimmer asked.

"She did, a few years after the blizzard," the man said.

Adora rubbed her hands together. "What was the storm waiting for?"

"For the world to be at its weakest."

"It's only a legend, right?" Adora replied.

"Every legend is based on truth."

Glimmer wrapped her arms around her torso. "Are there any other stories surrounding cold weather?"

The wind whistled before the man could answer Glimmer's question, extinguishing the fire. Okay, they were definitely dealing with a blizzard tonight. And it might not calm down anytime. If it was Prime's curse, then someone had to do something. But she and Adora couldn't just run off to the mountains, hoping to find a device. The citizens needed Adora. Also, if the princess lost her life, the king and queen would be heartbroken.

"For everyone's safety, we should all head indoors!" Adora said.

Everyone in the vicinity began walking. The duo prepared to make their way into the castle when they heard a horse nickering. Swift Wind stepped forward, his head lowered. Adora closed the distance between herself and the horse, then patted his snout. All

Glimmer could do was observe them. Were there terrible news? Did Adora's parents die, or were they stuck in the storm somewhere?

"What happened? Are you okay?" Adora asked. "And where - Swift Wind, where are my parents?"

A guard inspected the saddle. "It looks like there was an accident up on the mountain."

"Accident?"

"Adora, your parents are in grave danger."

Adora shook her head. "Is anyone else with them?"

The guard frowned. "No. I hope they find a shelter to hide from the storm. Your Highness, you must go inside the castle. It's too dangerous out here."

Glimmer took Adora's hand and began escorting her toward the castle. During their walk, neither woman spoke a single word. Silence blanketed the area. She swore she heard the blonde sniffling. Was Adora feeling overwhelmed right now? If Adora's parents died, she would be devastated. Glimmer knew how it felt to lose her own mother.

"Do you think I made the same mistake with my parents as you did with your mother?" Adora asked.

"I don't think you have," Glimmer said. "Why do you ask?"

"I resented them. Also, I was a little jealous of Adam for having more freedom." Adora squeezed Glimmer's hand. "My parents care about my safety. And they love me. However, when it comes to me and Adam, they're more strict with me than with him. Last night when I mentioned this to my parents, I had a bit of an attitude. No wonder my father had enough. I haven't apologized to them, not even this morning."

"I'm sure they'll forgive you."

Within fifteen minutes, the duo entered the castle. Glimmer peeked over her shoulder, staring at the door. If the story of Prime's curse was true, everyone would be in danger of dying in the blizzard, especially the king and queen of Grayskull.

To Halt a Storm

Chapter Summary

> Adora seeks out an ancient device, while Glimmer, Adam, Bow, Teela, and the royal guards rescue the king and queen. Catra poisons Hordak and takes control of Bright Moon.

The blizzard continued all night, speeding up and strengthening with the passage of time. Adora was unable to sleep through the night due to worrying about her parents' safety and guilt over making disastrous decisions as queen. In the morning, she followed Glimmer into the living room, where the servants sat. A fireplace heated the room as the maids served tea to the ones sitting. Despite the windows being closed, she could hear the wind howling.

"Sounds like it's gotten worse," Glimmer said.

"I'm sure it has," Adora replied.

Glimmer traced a rune in the air, forming a circle. "The spell should reveal your parents' location to us. Next, it'll show us where Bow is. Since the blizzard is everywhere, I want to know if the others are okay."

Various shades of purple mingled in the center of the circle, then faded, revealing a scene of Marlena and Randor trying not to fall off a cliff. Adora gasped. She wanted to find them, yet Glimmer might object to her leaving the castle. The image faded; a different scene surfaced. Bow was escorting Perfuma, a group of fairies, and a cluster of elves to a shelter. Other elves stayed outside, guarding the entrance. How was everyone else? Adora approached a window, watching the flakes blur the glass. In the distance, all she could see was white. Even though she didn't touch the window, she could sense the chilly temperature. Would closing the curtains keep out the cold? Or would it cause the people inside to be unaware of the current conditions?

"I want to find my parents," Adora announced. "Everyone, take care of each other."

"Adora, don't even think about leaving. Everyone needs you here," Glimmer said. "I'll get Bow and Adam. We'll look for your parents."

"What about you? Won't something happen? I can't imagine losing you, Glim."

"I could always teleport."

"A long distance? Won't it tire you out?"

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "No. I'll be fine, and so will the others. I won't be alone; Teela will lead the guards."

Adora drew Glimmer into a tight embrace. "Stay safe out there."

"You stay safe, too. We'll figure something out, starlight. I love you."

"Love you too, Glitter-bug."

After Glimmer teleported herself and Adam to Plumeria Forest, they hurried to the shelter's entrance. The elven guards wore serious looks as they gripped their staffs. She could see them shivering, despite their warm outfits. Wouldn't it be more sensible to go into the shelter? No one would want to be outside during a blizzard. Something could happen. Shuddering, she hugged herself as she stepped forward.

"Bow! Are you in there?" Glimmer shouted. "Adora's parents are trapped somewhere on a cliff. We need to save them. The guards are also looking for them."

Bow emerged from the shelter. "Can't I stay in there, where it's warm and safe? It's so cold."

"King Randor and Queen Marlena are in grave danger!" Glimmer beckoned Bow closer. "They could lose their lives. Bring your trick arrows. We're going to help the king and queen."

"I already have my arrows. I'll come with you guys."

"Good." Glimmer grabbed Adam's hand and Bow's wrist. "Let's teleport."

Glimmer conjured her magical energy; her skin tingled as she sensed the spell preparing to transport the trio. Squeezing her eyes shut, she allowed the spell to envelop the group. It didn't matter how tiring the long-distance teleports could be; lives were at stake. They zipped out of this reality and moved through another dimension. Within seconds, her eyes fluttered open. They were on a mountain; a gasp escaped her mouth as she detected a carriage below the cliff. Releasing both men, she inched toward the edge.

The king and queen left the carriage. Glimmer said, "Bow and Adam, you pull them up. If the ropes don't work, I'll teleport them to safety."

Bow shot a trick arrow at a rock wall behind him, then tossed the rope over the cliff. Adam unfurled his own rope and let it descend. Randor and Marlena strode toward the ropes; hoofsteps approached Glimmer from behind. She wondered whether to teleport to the castle to check on Adora, or stay here in case something went wrong. For some reason, the latter made more sense than the first option. This rescue mission was risky, due to the strong wind and a chance of the ropes breaking. Teela and the guards accompanied Bow and Adam.

"We may have to combine the ropes," Teela said.

"Why?" Glimmer asked as she glanced at the royal couple.

"A single rope couldn't hold up a person such as Randor. As for Marlena-"

One of the guards sneezed, triggering an avalanche. The ground rumbled; Glimmer looked up. A large wave of snow descended before anyone could jump out of the way. *You've got to be kidding!* She shut her eyes and braced for the impact. Sure enough, the snow forced her off her feet, and she slid down an icy rock wall. The sensation of pins and needles overwhelmed her face. Was she getting frostbite? Nearby, several individuals shuffled beneath the snow. A pair of hands swept the white powder off her face; her eyes fluttered open. Marlena wore a concerned expression.

"Glimmer, are you alright?" Marlena asked as she held out a hand.

"I don't know." Glimmer took Marlena's hand and rose. "My face is numb."

"I appreciate you and the others coming to rescue us. Regardless of that, the weather is perilous. How's Adora?"

"She's good, but she's worried about you."

After Adora ordered the citizens to evacuate the island, she visited Gray Haven and strode past multiple families. If she could find the ancient device in time, she could stop the blizzard for good. How were Glimmer and the others holding up? What if something happened to them? Despite the harsh wind, she walked faster. A child slipped on the ice; she helped him up. She arrived at one of the buildings, where the man who told the story resided.

"Hello?" Adora called out.

A man came forward. "Hey. What brings you here?"

"I want to find Mara's device. It's in the Grayskull Mountains, right?"

"I don't remember saying the legend was true."

"You did say legends were based on truth." Adora furrowed her brows. "What if the curse is real, and the blizzard won't let up until the world is destroyed? Even an evacuation won't help, then! That machine might be our only hope."

"Hmm."

"Please. If the legend is true, where would the device be?"

The man grabbed a torch. "I have an idea."

Catra stormed past the guards, swearing under her breath. Today, Hordak had demoted her and hired a different commander. Being cast aside was the worst thing to happen to her, and she hated it. A group of servants stepped out of the way as she glared at them. They should be scared to piss her off. After all, she would take control of her own destiny. Never again would she let someone else tell her what to do. She didn't want anyone to see her as a disposable asset. Hordak perceived her as someone to get rid of when he found someone "better." Stomping into the kitchen, she pointed her staff at the cooks. They backed away, trembling.

"Want me to kill you?" Catra spat.

The others shook their heads.

"Don't say anything to anyone," Catra continued as she emptied a vial into a pot of stew. The concoction would kill Hordak, and she would take over as Queen of Bright Moon.

Once Catra finished mixing the concoction into the stew, she poured it into a bowl. "Give it to Hordak. And don't explain anything. If you tell the truth, I'll slice your heads off." She shoved the bowl into a woman's jittery hands.

Catra followed the woman to the dining hall, where Hordak sat. She maintained a neutral expression, despite an urge to flash a sadistic smile. It would be hilarious to watch him die. The servant gave the bowl to Hordak. By the time she and Hordak were the

only ones in the dining hall, she occupied an empty seat and watched him eat the stew. The king began coughing as he clutched his chest. It was working.

"Why do I feel funny?" Hordak asked as he rose to his height.

"Because it's funny," Catra said.

"Now the room's spinning. My heart..." Hordak wheezed. "Stopped... working..." He collapsed to the floor.

Catra didn't have to put on the act of mourning the king, as she knew that most people considered him a tyrant. After his funeral, an event no one might attend, she would pretend to be a benevolent ruler at first. She called the guards; they rushed into the room to gather the king.

"How did he die?" A female asked.

"Heart attack," Catra lied.

"Who will rule Bright Moon now?"

"I will. Let's start my coronation."

"What about the evacuations? We're in the middle of a fatal blizzard!"

"I don't care!" Catra shot up, muscles tensing as she glowered at the woman. "The people must know!"

"You're as cruel as Hordak."

"Want to be imprisoned?"

The woman's eyes widened. "No. My apologies, Catra-"

"It's Queen Catra!" Catra retorted. "I will not tolerate your disrespect! And what's your name?"

"Juliet, the new commander."

"Well, Commander Juliet, I order you to take Hordak to the burial grounds! There will be a funeral."

Juliet tilted her head. "In this weather?"

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. "Ugh. At least put him in a coffin!"

The guards carried Hordak out of the dining hall. Catra strode into the long hallways, past every entrance and exit, and down a flight of stairs. From time to time, she peeked over her shoulder, making sure no one followed her. It wouldn't be good if anyone discovered her secret. She stepped into Hordak's secret room and approached the mirror. Expecting Horde Prime to materialize, she remained still. Several minutes dragged on; he didn't appear.

"Someone's not feeling like it, huh?" Catra whispered.

Catra made her way to the desk. A potion recipe book had been left open. According to Hordak, every potion had different results. Some were beneficial, and others were harmful. If someone added too much or too little of something, potion-making would backfire. She wasn't here to make one today, as she was hoping to inform Horde Prime of Hordak's demise.

"We meet again, little sister," a familiar voice said.

Catra whirled around. "Oh! Hey, Horde Prime. I poisoned Hordak, and I'm crowning myself the Queen of Bright Moon."

Horde Prime smiled. "You are meant to carry that title. There is a stone, the Moonstone Opal, that will give you great power. If someone opposes you, you can silence them. They'll learn to respect you."

"Where is it?" Catra's ears perked up. "I want its power. No, I need it."

"It is in the Fright Zone, also known as the Dark Kingdom."

The moment Adora found Mara's device, she began pushing the lever with all her strength. A crackling of electricity echoed off the stone walls as she continued pressing her weight against the lever. Within seconds, she stepped back and watched as the levers and bars moved in a clockwise motion. Other parts of it moved in the opposite direction. It was working; this would stop the blizzard. A bright blue light flooded the chamber; the ground vibrated. Another minute dragged on as she held her breath. Then, the machine stalled.

"What gives?" Adora asked as she inched toward the edge and stared into the chasm. "Kowl, go down there."

Kowl chirped as he took to the air and descended into the chasm.

"Careful!" Adora shouted.

Adora observed the bird as Kowl searched for the source of the machine ceasing to work. Eventually, Kowl found the source; a stuck boulder. He bumped against the boulder multiple times, forcing it off. Once again, the machine whirred. Kowl evaded its metallic parts, and for a moment, something blocked Adora from seeing where Kowl went. What happened?

"Kowl, are you okay down there?" Adora yelled.

There was no response. Sobbing, Adora covered her mouth with both hands. Losing her bird was not worth chasing a fairy tale. At least the device was working. Her thoughts drifted to the cliff scene. Was her girlfriend still alive? How about Adam and the royal couple? Teela, even? She could lose the ones she loved.

A chirp garnered Adora's attention; she whirled around, and what she saw made her gasp. Kowl was alive, although injured. She beckoned him closer, letting the bird land onto her palms. Now it was time to tell the citizens that they didn't have to evacuate. The blizzard was over.

It had taken a lot of effort - and in Glimmer's case, teleports - to rescue the king and queen. Now everyone was on solid ground, safe from falling off a cliff. Exhaustion weighed upon her limbs; those teleports had exhausted her magic reserves. The wind decreased its speed. Realization dawned upon her; Adora must have found the device. Her girlfriend saved the day. As she glanced at Randor and Marlena, the couple wore relieved expressions.

"Thank you, Glimmer," Marlena said. "And thank you, everyone, for saving us."

"You're welcome," Glimmer said. "You should also thank Adora. She found Mara's device, a legendary machine used for stopping a blizzard."

"Mara? I've heard tales of the heroine who sacrificed herself."

"Old tales aside, let's get you home."

Randor made eye contact. "Glimmer, you're a hero. And I'm going to have a talk with Adora once Marlena and I get home."

Glimmer smiled. "Adora will be excited to see you."

Once it was evening, Randor, Marlena, and the others arrived at the castle. Adora waited at the entrance, and as Glimmer came forward, she rushed to hug the shorter woman. She had feared losing those she loved, but they were all safe and sound. Releasing Glimmer from the embrace, Adora stroked her cheek.

"You're alive. And you saved my parents," Adora said.

"You stopped the blizzard," Glimmer replied.

"Other than that, I did a terrible job as queen."

"Don't be hard on yourself, starlight. You were awesome, as you've always been."

"So are you."

Adora proceeded to hug her parents and her brother. "I'm so glad you're safe."

"Glimmer told me you stopped the blizzard," Randor said. "Is it true?"

"Yes. And I'm sorry if I hurt your feelings the other night during dinner. I didn't like having my freedom be restricted, but that doesn't excuse my attitude."

"I forgive you."

Without another word, the royal family of Grayskull entered the castle. Glimmer caught up to Adora, then took her hand. If Horde Prime ever escaped his prison, would the girls succeed in saving everyone next time?

Dreams and Freedom

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a nightmare. Later on, Randor gives her the freedom she has always wanted.

After dinner, Adora went to her room, sat on the bed, and began writing in her journal. She drew a picture of snowflakes, a snow-person she had built, and an illustration of the blizzard. Being a temporal queen was tiring, especially when a severe blizzard was blowing through Grayskull. A few servants had compared the blizzard's wind to a hurricane's gale. When she asked what a hurricane was, they told her it was a tropical storm that came once in a blue moon. Those kinds of storms, according to the servants, were more common in tropical regions of the world. The door creaked open, interrupting her thoughts.

"Hey. Celebratory cake, huh? We're sharing a big piece," Glimmer said as she carried a slice of cake to the table.

"No, thank you," Adora replied.

"Aw, come on. Can't we celebrate our victory? I might have said it earlier, but you did great. You saved the day. What are you so upset about?"

"I sent you to face possible death, and I chased after a legend." Adora closed the journal. "In so many ways, today has been difficult."

"Starlight, what are you saying?" Glimmer walked toward the bedside and placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You don't have to be critical of yourself. Everyone makes mistakes. No one's perfect."

"I'm not sure if I'm fit to be queen someday."

"I know today was overwhelming. However, you becoming queen is a long time away. No matter what you decide..." Glimmer grabbed Adora's hand. "I will be right here with you."

Adora pulled Glimmer into an embrace. "Thank you for rescuing my parents."

"So... do you want cake? I could take it back to the kitchen if you don't feel like eating it."

"Actually... I want it." Adora released Glimmer. "What flavor is the cake?"

"Chocolate."

"Sounds delicious."

Glimmer retrieved the slice of cake and approached Adora. "Let's dig in."

Once it was time for bed, both women slipped beneath the covers. Scenes of recent events replayed in Adora's mind as she took in deep breaths. They began blurring together, sleep taking hold as a chill enveloped her body. Gripping the covers, she mumbled as she tossed back and forth. There was no way to shake off the feeling of an invisible presence watching her. Her heart pummeled her ribs, threatening to jump out of her chest...

Storm clouds churned in the sky, thunder booming as Adora raced past countless shops and homes in Gray Haven. A powerful wind tore roofs and signs off the buildings. This was like the blizzard, except there was no snow and ice anywhere. The rain blew sideways, colliding against every surface. She had to do something. For an odd reason, she couldn't remember how she stopped the blizzard. The next thing she knew, she stood in front of the bridge. Large waves fell onto the overpass, flooding every inch. Within a matter of seconds, the flood reached the island. Weren't hurricanes more common in tropical areas? Or was the information inaccurate?

"Adora!" A masculine voice shouted.

Adora glanced to the right, then gasped. Her father was drowning! As she untied her hair, he began floating away. "I'll get you out!"

Before Adora could save her father, his upper body sunk into the water. She was too late. A woman's body floated toward her; Queen Marlena. As her gaze flitted around the area, a wave crashed onto her body. She found herself underwater, somehow able to breathe. Groups of colorful fish swam past her; a familiar mermaid with teal hair and dark skin appeared, strands of hair rising up from the woman's head.

"Salineas succumbed to the ancient curse," Mermista said in a somber tone. "My parents entrusted me with this beautiful kingdom, and I let it fall."

"What ancient curse?" Adora asked as she glanced over her shoulder.

A castle was falling apart. Dozens of merpeople and sea creatures hovered above the rubble. Just then, clusters of black rocks emerged from the seabed, uprooting everything in sight. Squeezing her eyes shut, Adora struggled to remember a certain incantation. Yet no words came to mind. Her eyes fluttered open; she was now standing in the middle of Plumeria Forest. More black rocks had appeared. Every plant withered, a pond turned from blue to murky brown, and fairies mourned the demise of their home.

"My kingdom is doomed," Perfuma said.

"Doomed?" Adora asked.

"Yes." Tears streamed down Perfuma's face as she picked up a dead blossom. "I thought the blizzard was bad enough. But this? Plumeria Forest may never recover!"

The scenery transitioned to the outskirts of Bright Moon. As Adora watched smoke wafting into the air, flames consumed the castle and nearby villages. She detected Glimmer standing by a tree, face buried in palms. Thunder boomed as she rushed to Glimmer's side to comfort her. The shorter woman whirled around; instead of violet irises, the entirety of her eyes were black. Rivers of crimson tears stained Glimmer's face.

"You're too late..." Glimmer said in a distorted voice.

"Glim, what happened to you?" Adora asked.

"You happened. If you didn't touch the black rocks, my kingdom wouldn't be stolen from me!"

Everything faded away, replaced by a white space. Adora had a feeling she was stuck in something, but she wasn't sure what it was. A deep, smooth laughter echoed. Then, it took on a sinister tone. Where was she now?

"Hello, sundrop..."

Adora spun around. "Who are-" Her words halted at the sight of a menacing demonic figure. As terrifying as it was, she couldn't look away from its green eyes.

"Hey, Adora..."

Adora's eyes followed the source of the sound. Catra was unrecognizable; blue hair, matching eyes, and a black outfit. The magicat was paler than she remembered. Catra's evil smile widened from ear to ear. Before Adora could move, the demon's hand enveloped her entire body and tightened its grip.

...

Adora sat up, trembling as the vivid image of the massive hand lingered. All she could see was pitch blackness, and for a moment, she glimpsed a shadow. Sweat poured down her face; all her senses were on high alert, every limb frozen in fear. Something

enveloped her; for a moment, her heart stopped. All she wanted to do was escape the threat, yet she couldn't move. A tired, feminine voice spoke her name, and she could feel herself being drawn toward-

Adora's head met something solid. Or rather, someone's chest. *Glimmer's chest.* A heartbeat thudded in her ear. The calming sensation of fingers running through her hair, accompanied by soft 'shh's, settled her heart. She couldn't deny how safe she felt in Glimmer's embrace.

"Adora, what's wrong?" Glimmer asked.

"Nightmare," Adora answered.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

Adora sniffled. "I don't know. I mean, I thought the nightmare would never end. It started with the storm in Grayskull, and then I was underwater. A bunch of black rocks destroyed Salineas, and I also saw them in Plumeria Forest. Then, the fire destroying Bright Moon. Before the nightmare ended..." Her voice trailed off.

"Did you see anything else in the dream?"

Adora hesitated; she had no desire to mention the demon and the way Catra looked. Talking about them could cause them to reappear in her dream if she fell asleep. Glimmer began rubbing small circles on her back. All she could do was relax in her girlfriend's embrace.

"I'm not sure if I saw anything else," Adora whispered. "The dream is trying to tell me something."

"I think it's just a result of the stress you went through as temporal queen," Glimmer said. "Also, you need to sleep."

Both women reclined on their pillows, figuring out their sleeping positions until they settled on cuddling. Adora didn't mind, as it felt good to be close to Glimmer after a nightmare. A part of her

wondered why Glimmer didn't see the dream as a warning. After all, if the blizzard was bad enough, something much worse could come to them in the future. Her eyelids grew heavy; she resisted the pull of slumber. The hours dragged on as she fought the urge to fall asleep. Early in the morning, she succumbed to slumber.

Sunlight streamed through the window, illuminating every inch of the room. Glimmer and Adora had already awakened; the blonde seemed tired, perhaps from a lack of sleep. Glimmer recalled her girlfriend tossing and turning, minutes before the princess screamed. When she heard her mention Bright Moon while describing the nightmare, a small part of her had wondered if the kingdom would survive under tyranny or not. There was one way to know; just send a letter or two to Castaspella. While Adora remained in bed, Glimmer grabbed a blank piece of paper and began writing a letter.

...

> Dear Aunt Casta,
>
> How are things going in Bright Moon? Is it still bad?
>
> By the way, everyone went through a blizzard yesterday. I rescued Adora's parents from certain death while they were trapped on a mountain during the storm. The others helped, but I teleported the couple to safety. Have you heard of the legend of Horde Prime's curse? It waited for the world to be at its weakest. Maybe it has some kind of connection to the black rocks. Anyways, Adora found Mara's device and halted the blizzard, saving the day.
>
> So, is Hordak up to anything sinister? How much worse do you think the kingdom could get in the meantime?
>
> Love,
>
> your Niece, Glimmer

...

Glimmer drew a rune, then unleashed a spell at the paper. It vanished, and within a few minutes, Castaspella's letter materialized. She unfurled the letter; her eyes scrutinized the words.

...

> Dear Glimmer,
>
> It's still bad in Bright Moon. Catra took over after Hordak's demise.
>
> The blizzard could have been a lot worse if it weren't for intervention. I've heard of Prime's curse, but I don't know if it's connected to the black rocks. However, I did tell you about the Moonstone Opal and the Sundrop. I haven't lived in a kingdom with no freedoms, yet I don't have a good feeling about Catra's reign.
>
> Love,
> your Aunt Casta

...

Glimmer crumpled the paper into a ball. Of course Catra would take over Bright Moon. She thought Hordak was bad; Catra could be worse. And the magicat didn't have any powers. Footsteps shuffled toward the wardrobe. Adora must have gotten out of bed by now. Glimmer rose to her height, then turned around.

"So, you got up," Glimmer said.

Adora yawned. "Yep, I did. Remember discussing my nightmare last night?"

"Yes. Why?"

"I did see something else. Yet I didn't tell you, because I don't want to see something scary after returning to dreamland. There was a large demon with green eyes. Catra's hair and eyes were blue, and she wore a black outfit. Also, she was pale."

A memory of an illustration in the storybook, "Mara," surfaced in Glimmer's mind. What if the dream wasn't a result of stress? What would make Catra's hair and eyes blue? Some sort of dark curse? Adora could be right about the dream trying to warn the blonde.

"The demon could be Horde Prime," Glimmer said. "As for Catra, I'm not sure why she would be pale. Maybe an effect of a curse?"

"Didn't the most powerful sorcerers imprison Prime a long time ago?" Adora asked.

"Yes. If someone releases Horde Prime, or if he finds another way to escape, he will destroy the world."

"He called me 'sundrop' in the dream. What does it mean?"

"He probably knows what the sundrop and Moonstone Opal are."

Adora stroked her chin. "The dream hasn't revealed the Opal's location to me."

Glimmer strode to the door. "We could look for it."

"What do you mean, 'we?' My father won't let me leave Grayskull."

"We'll talk to him first."

Adora and Glimmer made their way to the dining hall and joined the royal family at the table. Scents of fresh fruit, pancakes, eggs, and breakfast pastries wafted into her nose. Of all the options on the table, she chose two cinnamon rolls and a small bowl of fruit. Glimmer chose a stack of pancakes topped with bananas,

blueberries, and whipped cream. Both women began eating their breakfast.

"I had been thinking about your need for freedom. According to many reports, you were capable of taking care of yourself. You were determined to save everyone from the blizzard," Randor said. "Glimmer was right about you. You're the strongest person we've ever known, and someday, you'll be an amazing queen." He wore a soft smile. "Adora, I was wrong to restrict your freedom. I had been afraid of letting you go. Well, you can now go anywhere you want to go. And if you ever lose your way... there's always floating lanterns to follow."

"I... I didn't expect to hear this from you," Adora said. "Thank you for saying that."

Glimmer held Adora's hand. "Starlight, you know what this means?"

"Yes, Glitter-bug?" Adora asked.

"We'll go on an adventure."

"Sounds fun. I've always wanted to travel anyways."

Everyone continued chatting as time passed on. Once they were done, Adora and Glimmer strode into the hallway and navigated the castle. Soon, they stepped into the blonde's room and changed clothes. Adora wore a red sleeveless vest over a white blouse. The vest stopped just above a leather belt, and on the belt was a small pouch. Instead of a skirt, she wore a pair of brown pants.

Glimmer kept on her tunic and leggings, but this time, she included a blue cape attached to a single circular plate. A belt enveloped her waist, and she wore a pair of white fingerless gloves. She had stashed her spellbook into a satchel.

"Ready to go?" Glimmer asked.

"Of course," Adora said.

Unexpected Detour

Chapter Summary

> While on a ship, Adora and Glimmer face a storm. As a result, their traveling group winds up stranded on an island.

Swift Wind and Spirit pulled the caravan along the trail, passing a cluster of black rocks as they trotted into the mountains. Adora gazed out the window, scrutinizing the path. Something about it seemed familiar. Didn't she come here with Glimmer during a trip to see the lanterns? It wasn't as if they were retracing their steps. But then, their next stop could be anywhere. It didn't matter where their destination would be. There was a whole wide world to see; nothing was stopping Adora and Glimmer. It was her first trip beyond the castle walls, a taste of freedom after being cooped up. No one was here to control her decisions, babysit her every minute of the day, and follow her around. She was free to do whatever she wanted. There were no limits, strict rules, and royal protocol to worry about.

As time whizzed by, the caravan arrived at a restaurant. The place Adora and Glimmer once visited. They could stop here to get some food. She led Glimmer into the restaurant; familiar faces glanced at them, then waved. A tall woman with white hair occupied a seat at the bar. Adora swore she had seen her before. Lynda D'Ream? Or, Scorpia? What was the muscular woman doing here? Glimmer stepped past Adora, walking toward the bar.

"Scorpia, Lynda, or whatever you call yourself... did Catra tell you to come here?" Glimmer asked.

"I came on my own. Catra chose to be a bad friend," Scorpia said. "She's always been cold to others, but she has gotten worse these days."

"You were with Catra back in Grayskull Castle. Are you still working for her?"

"No."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "You better not try anything funny."

Scorpia turned her attention to her drink. "I'm not going to cause trouble. I'm looking for Entrapta."

If Adora was just a random bystander observing the scene, she wouldn't expect a short person to intimidate a much taller individual. But she knew what Glimmer could be capable of. And as far as she knew, the muscular woman didn't show any signs of dishonesty. Glimmer shot Scorpia another glare before leading Adora to an empty table. If looks could kill, the shorter woman's scowl could have ended Scorpia on the spot.

"I don't trust her," Glimmer said.

"I can see that," Adora replied.

Glimmer took a map out of her satchel and unfurled it on the table. "We're in the mountains. The black rocks could be leading us somewhere."

"Yeah."

The door swung open, revealing Bow and Perfuma. When they saw Adora and Glimmer, they walked forward and sat down. Bow glanced at the map, then furrowed his brows.

"Are you traveling?" Bow asked.

"We're following the black rocks," Adora said. "The Moonstone Opal created them. If I find the Opal, the rocks may stop growing."

"You mean those scary, dangerous things?"

Adora nodded. "So, Perfuma, how's Plumeria Forest?"

Perfuma twisted a platinum strand around her finger. "Some black rocks showed up. They've uprooted some of the best flowers and bushes. Whatever they are, they're ruining the forest's beauty."

"How about the area surrounding Plumeria Forest?"

"The black rocks could be there, too."

Adora pointed to the map. "They could lead us to the tower, but I doubt the Opal would be in there."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "You were in the tower for eighteen years. Did you see anything out of the ordinary?"

"No. I did see something other than the flower in Shadow Weaver's journal..."

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10 Years Ago

Shadow Weaver hadn't returned home, and all Adora could do was color. Wait, perhaps she could do something more interesting. Her mother's room was off-limits for a mysterious reason. Why would the older woman forbid her from entering? Curiosity flooded her heart as she raced to her mother's bedroom door. To her surprise, it was left open. The older woman must have forgotten to lock it. Tip-toeing into the room, her eyes took in the furniture, shelves filled with bottles, and a desk. Piles of notes cluttered the surface; in the center was a journal.

Adora closed the distance between herself and the journal, then opened it. An illustration of the sun-shaped flower stood out to her. Flipping the pages, she searched for more drawings and pictures. An image of an opal caught her attention. The words above read: "The Moonstone Opal." Her gaze drifted to long, narrow triangles. "Black rocks," the writings called them. According to the writings, the opal was in a "fright zone." She traced her fingertip along the drawings.

A few minutes passed, and footsteps began approaching the door. Before Adora knew it, Shadow Weaver appeared by the desk. The older woman's face contorted into a scowl.

"I told you not to come into my room, flower." Shadow Weaver retrieved the journal. "And what are you doing with my journal? None of this is for you to know!"

"I was looking at the pictures," Adora said.

"You're not allowed in here!" Shadow Weaver rose her voice as she spoke. "You will go to bed without dinner. Go to your room right now!"

Tears blurred Adora's vision. "I'm so sorry!" She raced to her room, sobbing.

Adora heard the distinct sound of her door locking. Now she was restricted to the walls of her room. All she did was enter her mother's room. The minutes transitioned into hours as she waited in bed, staring at the ceiling. Her room had long since darkened, and it was time to sleep. Eventually, she drifted to dreamland, her stomach empty from not eating dinner.

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Present

"The Fright Zone? You mean, the Dark Kingdom?" Glimmer asked as Adora finished the story.

"So, it has another name," Adora said.

"Do you think Shadow Weaver could have been planning to release Horde Prime?"

"I don't know. Maybe."

Glimmer pointed to an area in the map's corner. "It could take a while to reach the Fright Zone. Perhaps a week or so. It depends

on the weather conditions on ocean and land. For a shortcut, we could go past Seaworthy Island."

"Seaworthy Island?" A familiar voice interrupted, prompting the duo to look up.

Mermista and Sea Hawk occupied the last two seats. She said, "Are you going on a trip?"

"Adventure!" Sea Hawk exclaimed.

"Sea Hawk, is it necessary to shout?"

Adora held up a hand. "Give us a chance to talk. Yes, we are traveling. And we plan to go to the Fright Zone to retrieve the Moonstone Opal."

Sea Hawk placed his hands behind his head and leaned back. "People say I'm the best when it comes to braving the treacherous seas on a ship. There's supposed to be a storm sometime this week, so maybe if we could reach Seaworthy Island in time, we'll avoid the storm. After it passes, I'll take you to the Fright Zone."

"A hurricane?" Adora asked.

"No. It's not that time of year yet."

"How often do storms happen on the ocean?"

"Several times a month. One time, I got stranded on an island-"

Mermista rolled her eyes. "Do you have to tell them that story?"

"I saw Mermista looking down at me, stroking my cheek. She was also singing," Sea Hawk continued. "Then, I realized that she rescued me from drowning."

"I did not sing to you. All I did was make sure you're okay."

Adora rolled up the map. "We could start sailing on the ocean after lunch."

"So, anyways," Sea Hawk said. "Who else wants to go on an adventure?"

"I'll come with you guys," Bow said.

Perfuma sighed. "I'm in, but only because I don't want to lose Bow."

Once everyone finished eating lunch, they made their way to a seaside town. The town had a large marina, with multiple ships waiting by the dock. Glimmer, Adora, and the others dismounted the caravan. A group of people unloaded a ship; others carried stacks of crates onto an empty vessel. Seagulls cawed as they glided across the sky. A salty scent wafted in the air as Sea Hawk led the group to a large ship. Glimmer couldn't help but notice Adora's excited grin. The blonde seemed unable to stand still. She couldn't deny how adorable her girlfriend was right now, all smiles and giggles as the princess anticipated a journey across the ocean.

"This is gonna be so fun!" Adora said.

"I hope we don't deal with a storm while on the ocean," Glimmer replied before guiding Swift Wind and Spirit onto the ship.

After ten minutes of getting ready, the group, except for Sea Hawk, descended the steps into a main cabin. In an adjacent room, there were several bunk beds. Glimmer and the others gathered around a table.

"So, any legends surrounding the Fright Zone?" Adora asked.

"Yes. Some people say it's inhabitable due to black rocks," Glimmer said. "No one lives there. However, a royal family used to rule that kingdom."

"I guess the rocks were too stubborn. Regardless of the potential danger, we must get the Moonstone Opal."

"Of course."

Several hours passed as Adora scrutinized the map for possible places to go. One of the islands was called "Beast Isle." How did it get the name? Did some people encounter monsters over there? Snakes? Insects, even? Would there be quicksands, too? She shook her head, reminding herself to overcome the conditioning that had been instilled within her during her life in the tower. There was no reason to let fear hinder her. As she lost herself in her thoughts, the ship began swaying. Thunder boomed in the distance, prompting the horses to rise. Kowl released multiple chirps as he flapped his wings. The door to the adjacent room slammed open.

"Are we going through a storm?" Glimmer asked.

"I don't know," Adora said.

Both women made their way to the main deck. Rain pelted the ship and swelling ocean waves, soaking everything in sight. The storm must have arrived earlier than they expected. If the ship tipped over, they could wind up stranded on an island. A wave collided against the vessel; Adora fell onto her back. Flashes of lightning pierced the darkness as she forced herself up.

"I was not expecting this!" Sea Hawk exclaimed, gripping the helm in a futile attempt to steer the vessel.

"Alright, no one panic," Glimmer said. "All we could do is take down the sails until the weather calms down. I'll get Bow, Mermista, and Perfuma." She glanced at Adora. "You could help with the sails, but try to be careful."

The vessel swayed; this time, the movement was more violent. It was going to be a long night. Adora ascended the ropes, struggling to reach the main sail. It was nothing like climbing her hair. A gale shoved her foot off a rope, and she yelped. It was one thing to climb up or down the tower, and entirely another to scale

the ropes in the middle of a violent storm. Heart hammering her ribs, she focused her eyes on the sail, suppressing a growing urge to peek below. *Don't even look. Stay calm.* Just then, the ship lurched.

"Adora! Are you okay up there?" Glimmer shouted.

Adora glanced down; her heart froze. How would she make her way to the deck if she was trying to maintain her balance? If she made the wrong move, she could fall into the ocean.

"The others can take care of the sails," Glimmer continued. "I'll get you. Hang on!"

Within seconds, Glimmer appeared by Adora's side, grabbed her waist, and teleported both women to the deck. Adora's pulse slowed as she took in her surroundings. Bow and Sea Hawk lowered the sails; Perfuma began steering the vessel. The tides and downpour showed no signs of slowing to a halt.

"At this point, we may have to stay up all night to make sure the weather doesn't kill us," Glimmer said.

"Won't we be tired in the morning?" Adora asked.

"Some of us could keep watch."

Mermista strode to the railing. "If you guys get stranded, I'll go to Seaworthy Island to get help."

Sea Hawk rushed to Mermista's side. "Can I get a new ship?"

"So you can either set it on fire or destroy it in some other way?"

Perfuma ran her hands through her hair. "This is crimping my harmony! I shouldn't have forgotten my morning meditation!"

Bow placed his hands onto Perfuma's shoulders. "We'll be fine. Let's not panic."

A flash, accompanied by a crackle, startled Perfuma and Bow. The archer pointed at an approaching wave. "Uh, guys, I think we should panic. A wave's going to crash down on us!"

Everyone else turned to look. As Bow had predicted, the wave collided onto the ship, knocking it over. The next thing Adora knew, she was underwater, and she couldn't see anything. Fear gripped her heart as she moved her limbs in all directions, reaching for anyone who could be nearby. She would never complete her adventure, and Adam would have to inherit the throne someday. Also, Bright Moon would collapse under tyranny. The black rocks would finish destroying everything in their path. Before she knew it, all the air in her lungs escaped. As her consciousness slipped away, she sensed someone grabbing her wrist.

Glimmer's eyes fluttered open; she became aware of the ground beneath her back. It had a coarse and gritty texture. The rays of dawn brightened the sky as she sat up, scrutinizing the area. Her girlfriend and the others remained unconscious. They must have been sleeping on the sand after the storm. Where was Mermista? Did the mermaid save them? She glimpsed a pile of debris by the water, where Kowl, Swift Wind, and Spirit slept. Images from last night flooded her mind; the huge wave sinking the ship, reaching out for Adora, and a feeling of being pulled in a specific direction. They were stranded, but where were they? On an island?

Glimmer nudged Adora, awakening her. "We survived the storm, but we're probably on an island. Mermista saved all of us."

Adora mumbled under her breath as she sat up. "Which island?"

Bow approached the women. "Beast Isle. I read its sign."

"Beast Isle?"

Glimmer helped Adora up. "Yes. It's named for its reputation as the scariest island to ever visit."

Adora's face blanched. "Oh, crap."

"It's rumored to be teeming with monsters."

"We're not going to survive out here, are we?"

Glimmer shrugged. "If Mermista brings someone here to rescue us, we'll be okay. Yet..." She glanced at the skeletons near the trees. "This place doesn't seem safe."

"So... what do we do?" Adora asked.

"We could make a shelter while there's still light. Just stick by the water, and we'll be fine."

To Leave the Isle of Nightmares

Chapter Summary

> Adora, Glimmer, and their group try to survive Beast Isle. Later, someone helps them get off Beast Isle.

For the rest of the morning, the group built a shelter. So far, they didn't run into trouble. But they might. By noon, when the group gathered firewood for the campfire, Adora was quick to notice that Kowl was missing. She had counted heads multiple times to be sure her eyes weren't playing tricks on her. Glimmer had told her to stick by the water and to avoid the woods, yet Kowl could be in danger. Adora wasn't about to stay behind and wait for her bird to return.

"Kowl's missing," Adora said.

"The bird?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes. We need to look for him."

Glimmer traced a rune in the air. "Last time I used this spell, it was during the blizzard."

The spell revealed Kowl's location. A creature was chasing him. Adora couldn't tell what it was, but she did notice some insect-like characteristics. "It didn't show us a trail, though. We've got to search for him before it gets dark out."

Bow held up a finger. "Are all of us going to search for the bird?"

Adora shook her head. "Sea Hawk and Perfuma can watch the shelter. Bow, you're coming with me and Glimmer."

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow strode into the woods, with the pink-haired woman leading the way. Dark vines enveloped the trees; a stench of rotting vegetation lingered in the air. From time to time, something darted between the trees. Was a creature following

them? Adora's gaze flitted from tall trees to thick bushes. Patches of leaves surrounded large bulbs. The bulbs, for an odd reason, had sharp teeth. What were those things?

"Stay away from them. They look like they could bite," Glimmer said.

The bulbs shot up, hissing as they moved toward the group. Their breaths reeked of dried blood and feces. Despite the possibility of facing danger on Beast Isle, Adora hadn't brought a pan with her. Saliva dripped from the monstrous plants. Glimmer unleashed an air spell, blasting the plants with a burst of wind. The wind sent the bulbs flying into several trees, shattering into pieces.

"We've got to be careful out here," Bow said. "Those plants were scary."

"I agree," Adora replied in a shaky voice. "I should have brought my pan with me."

"You could have gotten hurt either way."

The trio proceeded forward, picking up the pace and keeping their eyes peeled for hostile creatures. Twigs and leaves crunched beneath their feet. Adora swore she felt something skitter over her feet at one point. She thought of some creepy crawlies that had made their way into the tower through the open window. As she followed Glimmer and Bow along the trail, a growl garnered their attention. Then, a hiss. What was lurking in the bushes and treetops? More bulbs? Monstrous insects? Glimmer traced an eye rune in the air, then observed the greenery.

"Did you see anything?" Adora asked. "Where's Kowl?"

"I didn't see him," Glimmer said. "But I saw something big. And terrifying!"

"Okay, so you're not scared of the bulbs, yet you're scared of - oh my gosh, what is that?"

A huge spider with dozens of red eyes descended the closest tree and crawled forward. Bow nocked an arrow and aimed for the monster's face. The arrow plunged into its eye, causing the insect to roar in agony. Glimmer shot a wind spell at the spider; upon impact, the spider flew backward. Adora could see the shorter woman shaking, despite *her* brave face. She fixated her eyes on the spider. It didn't take long for the monster to recover from the impact.

"Hey, bug-brain, leave us alone!" Glimmer shouted as she launched a fire spell at the spider.

The flames consumed the insect and burned it to ashes. Once the group made sure there weren't any more enemies in the vicinity, they moved on. Adora had no idea why Kowl would fly off into peril. This place was unsafe. The last thing she wanted to do was navigate the woods, yet if she didn't retrieve Kowl, something bad could happen to him. Even if everyone stuck by the water, wouldn't one of the creatures find their shelter? She shuddered at the thought.

"Because of our current speed, it'll be sundown before we return to the shelter," Bow said.

"I could teleport you guys. Right now, we're trying to find Adora's bird," Glimmer replied.

"One of those beasts would probably see the shelter and attack Perfuma and Sea Hawk."

"I also know a protection spell."

"Why didn't you use it on the shelter before we came here, then?"

"I thought they would be okay by the water."

"Well, I hope nothing happens to Perfuma and Sea Hawk."

The sun hurried closer and closer to the horizon as the group trekked uphill. Eventually, they stumbled upon a clearing. Adora shouted Kowl's name; the bird appeared, flying toward her. An insect-like creature emerged from the treetops, descending to the ground. Glimmer unleashed another wind spell, then a fireball. After the monster burned to ashes, Adora beckoned Kowl onto her palms. The bird was safe and sound. Now the group needed to return to the shelter before more beasts showed up.

"I'm glad you're okay," Adora told Kowl. "What made you go on your own? It's dangerous out here."

The bird emitted multiple chirps.

"So, you flew off because you felt ignored?" Adora asked.

Kowl nodded.

"I'll try to spend more time with you. You could also befriend the others," Adora said. "I have a girlfriend, and I hang out with our friends, but it doesn't mean I don't love you."

Glimmer approached Adora. "We better go back to our shelter."

"Good idea," Adora agreed.

As the days transitioned into weeks, the group continued waiting for Mermista. In the meantime, Bow and Sea Hawk attempted to fix the ship, only for its parts to break every time. Several monsters had discovered their first shelter and tried to attack. As a result of the ambush, the group built a hut in a different location. It didn't take long for the creatures to bother them again. They built a third hut by the dock; Glimmer made sure the protection spell was effective this time. One morning, during sunrise, Glimmer and Adora stared out at the ocean. The water reflected shades of orange, pink, and yellow; shadows began dissolving.

"We should be in Seaworthy Island or the Fright Zone by now. As long as we're stuck, the black rocks will continue growing," Adora said.

"We're probably getting closer to hurricane season by now," Glimmer said.

"What's taking Mermista so long?"

"Maybe she had to check on Salineas."

"So, she left us here?"

"She doesn't strike me as the type of person to abandon someone."

Adora peeked past Glimmer's shoulder. "Someone's coming."

Glimmer whirled around and saw Sea Hawk carrying a glass bottle. It contained a scroll. How did the bottle get here? Did Mermista send it, or did she have someone else do it?

"I found this on the shore!" Sea Hawk announced. "I believe it's a letter from Mermista." He glanced at the hut. "Bow! Perfuma! Come look!"

Glimmer couldn't see what was so exciting about a simple scroll, other than possible contact from someone who wasn't stuck on Beast Isle. It wasn't a rare underwater treasure that surfaced. Bow and Perfuma left the hut and rushed to Sea Hawk's side. The pirate pulled the scroll out of the bottle, then unfurled it. Sea Hawk began reading the letter...

...

> Dear Sea Hawk and everyone else,
>
> I hope you're doing alright. While searching for a sailor in Seaworthy Island, I met a woman named Huntara. She may seem intimidating, but she's not going to hurt you. Although,

she did mention her somewhat dark past as a thug. Huntara will retrieve you from Beast Isle and bring you to Seaworthy Island. The weather on the ocean can change anytime it wants, so Seaworthy can serve as a temporal destination before going to the Fright Zone. In case you're wondering how long it'll take for Huntara to find you, she's already on the way. As for me, I'll stay in Salineas and see if it recovers from the ancient curse.

Sincerely,
Mermista

...

"Mermista said that Huntara was a thug, yet she trusts her with us?" Adora asked.

"When someone says the other person is intimidating, it's a red flag. The 'intimidating' person could be aggressive," Bow said.

Glimmer held up a hand. "At least she'll get us out of here. It's tiring having to find a new shelter every time those monsters attack us."

Sea Hawk nodded. "Glimmer has a point. As soon as Huntara's ship arrives, we're out of here."

Perfuma clasped her hands together. "I like nature, just not the hostile beasts. This place made me miss Plumeria Forest."

Glimmer smiled. "Don't worry, Perfuma. We'll take you back to Plumeria Forest as soon as the adventure is over."

Once the conversation ended, Sea Hawk proceeded to go fishing. Bow and Perfuma gathered more wood for the fire, and Adora sat on a log. She propped her face against her palms, staring at the sand. Glimmer sat next to her, then drew her into a side hug.

"Is something the matter?" Glimmer asked.

"Mermista thinks it's okay for us to trust a stranger," Adora said. "We don't know Huntara."

"Says the girl who trusted me and Bow to take her to the floating lanterns."

"I had no other choice back then."

Glimmer tucked a strand behind Adora's ear. "And right now, we have no other choice. Would you rather be chased by monsters whenever they find you?"

Adora made eye contact. "No. I don't like worrying at night about the monsters. If I do fall asleep, I'd have nightmares about them."

"Same."

"Despite being afraid, you fought them."

"Because I'm more worried about losing you and the others."

Adora rested her head on Glimmer's shoulder. "I still have nightmares about losing Kowl. If it wasn't for the location spell, we wouldn't have saved him."

Glimmer caressed Adora's back. "Nothing bad will happen as long as we all stick together."

"It feels like we're not safe enough."

"That's the point of an adventure, isn't it? To get you out of your comfort zone."

"Like when I left the tower?"

"Yeah, except our second adventure is crazier. We survived a storm, got stranded on Beast Isle, and are waiting for rescue."

As the women continued chatting, Bow and Perfuma returned with wood and tossed the logs into the makeshift firepit. Sea Hawk joined everyone else, carrying a net filled with fishes.

Glimmer unleashed a fire spell at the wood. She couldn't wait to leave this place, and she was sure the others felt the same way. Even if there was some disagreement regarding Huntara, that person was their way out.

Another week dragged on, and from time to time, the group would take turns checking the dock. One day, Adora made her way to the dock, staring into the distance. A small dot on the horizon caught her attention. Was someone coming? Or were her eyes tricking her? A warm breeze enveloped her body as she remained still. Holding her breath, she watched as the dot came closer. Ten minutes, then fifteen, whizzed by. Footsteps approached; she whirled around.

Glimmer arched her brow. "Did you see something?"

"I think so," Adora said as she peeked over her shoulder.

Sea Hawk raced toward the women and held up a spyglass. "I gotta look!" He peered into the spyglass. "I see a ship. Someone's coming for us. Bow! Perfuma! Huntara is coming!"

"Finally."

Bow and Perfuma joined them. He said, "I hope Huntara doesn't try to hurt us while we're on her ship."

"None of us enjoyed being here, so..." Perfuma said.

Glimmer crossed her arms. "Is there any other choice?"

Bow sighed. "Guess not."

Adora glanced at the approaching ship. "We'll board the ship as soon as it gets here."

After thirty minutes, the ship arrived. A tall, muscular woman with a white ponytail and a pirate uniform stepped onto the dock. Adora estimated the woman's height to be about six feet and four

inches. Scorpia's height and muscle mass were similar to Huntara's, so how was this woman intimidating? Did Huntara have sharp teeth?

"Ready to go? Mermista told me you've been stranded on Beast Isle for a while," Huntara said. "However, she didn't tell me your names. Let me guess... Blondie, Boy, Glitter, Flower Girl, and Pirate."

"Actually, our names are Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, and Sea Hawk." Adora beckoned Kowl and the horses closer. "And the animals' names are Kowl, Spirit, and Swift Wind."

"Ah, whatever. Let's go."

Adora, Glimmer, and their friends boarded the ship. A part of her expected to meet a pirate crew; So far, she hadn't seen anyone else on here. Was Huntara the only one on the vessel? As the ship began gliding away from Beast Isle, she released a sigh of relief. No more worrying about being awakened in the middle of the night by those monsters. Without Glimmer's protection spell, they would be dead by now.

Everyone, except for Huntara, descended the stairs to a room. Adora and Glimmer sat on a sofa, while the others occupied empty seats by a table. She held Glimmer's hand, then made eye contact. The pink-haired woman flashed a smile.

"Thanks for keeping us safe with the protection spell," Adora said.

"I'd do it again," Glimmer replied.

"Of course you would. You're my hero."

"You're my hero, too. One time, you revived me. And I haven't forgotten the day you stopped the blizzard. It was awesome."

Adora chuckled. "We're both brave, aren't we?"

"Yeah, we are," Glimmer said.

Meet the Cat Again

Chapter Summary

> The group visits Seaworthy Island. Adora and Glimmer run into a familiar face.

So far, the voyage had been smooth. The ship was still sailing, its destination not too far off. For several days, the weather was favorable. Not a single storm ambushed the vessel. Huntara was an odd woman; she didn't say much about herself, other than mentioning bits and pieces of her past. It made the group wary of her, as they didn't know whether she was lying or being honest. Bow had commented on her mysterious personality several times. Huntara had developed a habit of picking on the women, making sarcastic comments, and using nicknames. However, for a strange reason, she didn't talk as much to Sea Hawk and Bow. If she preferred women, she sure had a funny way of showing it.

One day, Adora leaned against the railing, inhaling the salty breeze. Tiny waves glistened in the sunlight. The temperature was perfect. Looking up, she detected seagulls hovering in the bright blue sky. There was not a single cloud in sight. Distant shapes came into view. Was the ship approaching Seaworthy Island? Glimmer's voice interrupted her thoughts.

"Enjoying the ocean?" Glimmer asked.

Adora turned to face Glimmer. "Yes. It's beautiful." On the other side of the deck, she spied Huntara and Sea Hawk arm-wrestling. While the beefy woman was gaining the upper hand, the pirate struggled to beat her.

Glimmer tilted her head. "Are you gawking at something?"

"Yes. Sea Hawk and Huntara are arm-wrestling," Adora answered.

"Of course they would." Glimmer snickered as she turned to watch the arm-wrestling match. "She's winning again."

"Huntara and Scorpia should get together and arm-wrestle. They're both strong."

"I agree."

Huntara pumped a fist in the air; Sea Hawk rose to his height and walked away. The muscular woman strode to the helm and grabbed its handles. Should Adora walk up to her and talk, or leave her alone? Mermista had said that Huntara wouldn't hurt the group, yet there had to be a reason behind the tall woman picking on shorter ladies. She made her way toward the helm, then crossed her arms.

"Blondie, are you gonna say something?" Huntara asked.

"Well, yes, if you don't mind," Adora said.

"Go ahead."

"So, what made you want to become a sailor?"

Huntara pursed her lips. "Why do you bother asking? Don't you have better things to do, such as hanging out with Glitter?"

Adora toyed with a strand of blonde hair. "For the record, her name's Glimmer. Why are you avoiding my question?"

"I'm not going to tell you my life story, so stop bothering me."

"You don't have to tell me every detail of your life. Just some things you're comfortable discussing."

Huntara squinted. "You'll regret knowing the truth about me. Also, I must focus on steering the ship, so do whatever you want."

Adora opened her mouth to continue speaking, but Huntara glared at her before she could start. She made her way to a door, stepped into a small hallway, and entered the room with couches and a single table. Glimmer was already in here, scrutinizing a map while chatting with Bow, Perfuma, and Sea Hawk.

"I tried to talk to Huntara and understand why she's acting secretive," Adora said.

Glimmer looked up. "Did she tell you why?"

"No. She shut down my attempts at initiating a conversation."

"If that's the way Huntara is, let her be that way. We'll find out one way or another. See if she's an honest person, or if she's hiding a secret."

Adora sat next to Glimmer. "I wonder why Mermista didn't choose anyone other than Huntara."

Glimmer traced her fingertip along the lines on the map. "Sea Hawk might get a new ship in Seaworthy Island."

"I hope we don't encounter any storms on the way to the Fright Zone."

Once the group arrived at Seaworthy Island, they disembarked the ship. A variety of residents wore pirate outfits. Some children played in the streets, while others frolicked on the sand. Their guardians watched them from a distance, chatting with other adults. In one park, the bystanders gawked at a familiar woman with cat ears as she defeated an opponent three times her size. A pair of females clapped. One of them was slender, with a white and red top and navy blue pants. The other woman was stocky, and she wore a similar outfit.

"You got this, Catra!" The stocky woman said.

"You'd be an awesome leader of a pirate crew!" The slender woman added.

Catra smirked, flicking her tail to one side as she rested a single hand on her hip. "I'm Queen Catra of Bright Moon. I got stranded here after a storm. Queens don't give up."

Glimmer stormed through the crowd, pushing people out of the way. "Catra, you don't deserve such a title! Also, are you following us?"

Catra's brows snapped together. "Ugh, Sparkles! You and the special blonde better not ruin anything!"

"Are you going somewhere, by the way?"

"Why does it matter to you?"

"Adora's going to get the Moonstone Opal."

"The what?" Catra's ears flattened against her head. "She doesn't need its power. I do!"

Glimmer felt her facial muscles tighten. "In case you haven't noticed, more black rocks have been growing, and they won't stop! They're destructive creations of the Opal!"

"Destructive creations? At least I'll use them for something once I gain the Opal's power." Catra inspected her claws. "My ride takes off in an hour or so. When I find the Moonstone Opal, my enemies won't stand a chance against me. Not even the blonde girl!"

Adora appeared by Glimmer's side. "Catra, you're crazy if you think power will make you a stronger queen."

"Shut up, blondie. Shadow Weaver abandoning me is your fault!"

"I know you're hurting, but it's no excuse for scratching me and leaving behind a scar." Adora stepped forward. "Shadow Weaver hurt me, too. She lied to me for eighteen years and never gave me any freedom."

"You and Shadow Weaver made me feel worthless!" Catra's eyes burned with anger. "I waited for her to return for me when I was a toddler. If it weren't for you being born-"

"Listen, Catra-" Adora began.

"Why should I listen to everyone's favorite girl? I bet you were never cast aside for anyone! You don't know how it feels!" Catra spat.

Perfuma and Bow joined Adora and Glimmer. Meanwhile, Sea Hawk and Huntara stood in the middle of the crowd, watching the quarrel. It was obvious; the disagreement was drawing everyone's attention. Was Catra hoping to win an argument?

Catra balled her hands into angry cannons. "Adora, you're privileged. You have it all; caring parents, a group of friends who adore you, and even a partner. The people of Grayskull think you're special. Why else would they do the lantern thing each year on your birthday? No one does anything for mine!"

Bow gasped. "No one celebrated your birthday? That must be so sad!"

Catra hissed. "Hey! I didn't ask you to join the conversation."

Adora held up a hand. "The lantern thing was different, Catra. You weren't the one who was trapped in a tower for eighteen years. I was."

Catra glanced at the two women behind her, then pointed to Bow and Perfuma. "Daisy, Lizzy, get them! I'll fight Adora."

Within seconds, "Daisy" and "Lizzy" restrained Bow and Perfuma. Glimmer glowered at Catra. It was clear; the magicat was trying to instigate a fight. This wouldn't end well for the magicat.

"Two times, you ran away from a fight," Glimmer said. "What makes you so sure you'll lay a finger on her? Your minions are busy restraining Bow and Perfuma, leaving you defenseless!"

"Fortunately, I got a new weapon," Catra replied as she revealed a whip. "Tung Lashor gave it up after I defeated him."

"Remember what I told you about battling powerful mages? Well, I've been practicing. And my magic has gotten stronger. You think

you can stand a chance?"

Perfuma struggled against Lizzy's grip. "Let me go, you ruffian!"

Bow grunted as he attempted to free himself from Daisy's hold. "Glimmer, don't we have a more important mission to take care of?"

Catra swung her whip; the whip wrapped around Glimmer's wrist. Glimmer traced a rune in the air, then unleashed a magical sphere at the brunette. The spell collided against Catra's abdomen, forcing her off her feet. As Catra fell onto her back, she released her weapon.

"Giving up already?" Glimmer asked.

Catra rose to her height. "Daisy, Lizzy, release her friends. Let's go."

"Catra, this is your third time, tucking tail and running. You're not scared of my magic, are you?"

Before Catra could leave, Adora moved in front of her, hindering the magicat. Catra bared her sharp teeth, staring Adora down. The blonde's eyes widened as she took a step back.

"Get out of my way," Catra said.

Adora grabbed Catra's hand. "Listen to me. You don't have to choose bitterness. Shadow Weaver raised me, and she was a terrible parental figure. She manipulated me, punished me for even the smallest things, and used me. I could have been an angry person who hated the world. Instead, I chose kindness."

"Kindness is for weaklings."

"No. It is a sign of strength."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "I'm already strong. If you're hoping the speech would somehow get through to me, it never will."

Adora frowned. "Why would you rather be mean?"

Catra rammed her foot into Adora's abdomen; the blonde descended to her knees, clutching her midsection. The magicat swiped at Adora's back, carving bloody lines into her flesh. Glimmer's nails dug into her palms as she glared at Catra. Her enemy crossed the line! And Catra would pay for this.

"Catra, you are the worst!" Glimmer shouted. "I'll get you!"

Catra gestured at Daisy and Lizzy. Then, they fled before Glimmer could land an attack. Glimmer hurried to Adora's side; what she saw elicited a gasp from her lips. A circle of blood darkened the blonde's vest and blouse. Anger heated her veins. All her girlfriend did was talk to Catra about kindness. And guess what the magicat did? Catra had kicked and scratched the blonde.

"I'll take you to a healer," Glimmer said.

"She... she hurt me..." Adora replied, sobbing.

Glimmer helped Adora up. "I know. Your wound needs to be bandaged. They could take a while to heal."

The two women visited a healer. As a stranger bandaged Adora's wound, she winced in pain. All she could think about was her latest conversation with Catra. The brunette refused to apologize, chose not to listen, and attacked her. Despite the softness of the bandages, the gashes stung. An injury wouldn't stop her from going to the Fright Zone, though. All she could do was make sure the lacerations didn't bleed more. Once the healer left, Glimmer held Adora's hands.

"They said I could go back onto the ship, but I must not move my back too much," Adora said.

"They're right," Glimmer replied. "You don't want the wound to get infected, do you?"

"No. However, I may need to maintain my hair."

"I could help you brush it."

Adora stood. "I'll get my top."

Glimmer held up a finger. "Sit down. I'll get the vest and blouse for you, and then-"

"Can you not overdo it?"

"Overdo what?"

Adora let out an audible exhale. "You know... 'I will get this for you.' Or, 'I will get that.' Glim, I'm not complaining, but still-"

Glimmer snatched the blouse and vest. "I'm pretty sure I told you to let others take care of you sometimes."

"What if I need to let down my hair and fight off a threat?"

"You don't have to worry about that. I have magic, and Bow has his arrows."

"And what does Sea Hawk do?"

"He knows a bit of sword-fighting. Otherwise, he's a sailor who sings shanties."

Glimmer helped Adora put on the vest and blouse, careful not to touch the affected area. By the time she was finished, she drew Adora into an embrace. It was easy to feel safe in the shorter woman's arms. Adora lost herself in the moment, her heart skipping a beat as she inhaled the lavender scent.

"So... ready to sail again?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Adora said.

"Let's go."

The duo left the building. It was located next to the marina. Sea Hawk, Bow, and Perfuma were waiting for them. They wore concerned expressions, probably wondering if Adora was okay. And she was, although the gashes would take time to go away. They would leave behind scars, just like the ones on her cheek. What else would Catra scratch? Her arms and legs? Regardless of what the magicat did, she didn't want to give up on her. In a sense, being raised by the same woman made them sisters. Sadly, though, Shadow Weaver abandoned Catra at an orphanage when Adora was a baby. Catra saw it as a reason to hurt people.

"How's your back?" Bow asked.

"It'll be fine," Adora said.

Perfuma smoothed her dress. "Those ruffians crimped my harmony. I can't wait to go."

Sea Hawk gestured at a ship. "I got a new ship. I named it The Dragon's Daughter Five."

"If something happens to it, the next ship will be number six, right?" Bow said.

"Yeah," Sea Hawk replied.

Adora cleared her throat. "Anyways, we better get going. If Catra takes the Moonstone Opal before we find it, she'll use it for sinister purposes."

Crossing the Line

Chapter Summary

> Catra takes the Moonstone Opal's power for herself. Adora and her friends return to the sea after confronting Catra.

It took almost two weeks to reach the Fright Zone. Or, as some said, the Dark Kingdom. Adora's back was starting to heal, although there were times when the gashes reopened. Upon arriving at their current destination, the group discussed her injury. In the end, the others agreed to let Adora accompany them, despite the dangers lurking in the shadows. They strode through a cave, avoiding its chasms and other perils. Ten minutes passed as they made their way to a cliff. Several ropes held up ancient gondolas; the threads didn't appear steady. What would happen if everyone boarded a single gondola? Would the rope break?

"There's no plant life out here!" Perfuma exclaimed.

"I agree. It's like the whole kingdom is dead," Bow said.

Glimmer stared at the gondolas. "I have a feeling the black rocks forced every citizen to escape. My aunt said that the rocks would destroy everything in their path." She pointed to a cluster of rocks. "*This* is what happened to the kingdom."

Sea Hawk peered into his spyglass. "It could take a while to reach a gondola."

"Not if I teleport."

Adora arched her brows. "So what you're saying is, you'll teleport all of us across the abyss? Or are you going to bring the gondola to us?"

"I'll bring it to you," Glimmer said. "Just a second." She vanished into thin air and reappeared on a gondola's roof.

For the next five minutes, Adora fixated her eyes on the gondola. At first, it moved toward the other side. Then, it glided closer to the group. She was surprised the rope hadn't snapped in half at this point. The vessel seemed heavy. Someone tapped her shoulder; she whirled around, expecting to see Bow or her other friends. Instead, she saw Catra and a pair of female ruffians.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said.

"Why are you here?" Adora retorted.

"To make sure you don't take the Moonstone Opal."

"And how are you going to stop me?"

"Well, where is Sparkles? I assumed she would be here to protect you. Guess not." Catra began circling Adora. "Ooh, someone is scared."

Bow aimed his arrow at Catra. "Leave her alone."

Catra stepped toward Bow. "Defending your friend? How can you do it if you can't escape Daisy's grasp?" She glanced at Daisy. "Restrain Arrow Boy. Lizzy, get the blonde in the pink dress."

Sea Hawk pointed his sword at Catra. "En garde!"

Adora peeked over her shoulder and detected Glimmer emerging from the gondola. The pink-haired woman glowered at Catra. Someone wasn't happy to see the magicat. And Glimmer had every reason to be furious; Catra was causing trouble. The magicat had a habit of running off whenever Glimmer used aggressive magic. Would Catra flee for the fourth time? Or would she ride another vessel to the Opal's location?

"Fuck off, Catra!" Glimmer shouted as she stormed closer.

Catra's eyes widened. "Daisy and Lizzy, follow me to another vehicle." She hurried to the other side of the cliff. "And don't take those two people with you."

"Tucking tail already?"

Daisy and Lizzy followed Catra to another rope. Glimmer led the group to the gondola; the moment Adora and her friends stepped inside, the vessel began moving. She approached a window and stared at the chasm. Perfuma wasn't exaggerating when she said there was no plant life out here. Glimmer stood next to Adora, also gazing at the abyss.

"Catra is never gonna give us a break, is she?" Adora said.

"She probably wouldn't stop anytime," Glimmer said.

"It's tiring, trying to be kind to her. All she does is treat me like crap." Adora folded her arms. "Am I being a pushover?"

"When it comes to Catra? A little. Other people? Not as much." Glimmer sighed. "You didn't mind standing up to Shadow Weaver and Hordak. What is it about Catra that makes you want to be super nice to her?"

"Shadow Weaver raised me and Catra. It makes us sisters."

"You already have a sibling. Adam. And he's nothing like Catra."

Adora nodded. "I know. But I care about her."

"Why do you care so much?" Glimmer asked.

"Because Shadow Weaver hurt both of us. For a moment, try seeing things from Catra's perspective. How would you feel if your mother abandoned you for someone else? Wouldn't it make you feel a little angry?"

"I would have felt a little upset over the abandonment. But even then, I wouldn't attack my 'sibling' and their friends. I swear, if Catra tries something again-"

"Glim, I get it." Adora made eye contact. "You're mad at her."

"Because she hurt you," Glimmer replied.

Once Catra's gondola reached the other side of the chasm, she led her companions to a pair of large doors. Peeking over her shoulder, she watched as Adora's vessel approached. If she gained the Moonstone's power, she would be more willing to fight Glimmer. For now, it was best to stay out of her sight. The pink-haired girl's magic could easily crush an opponent. It would be unpleasant to be on the receiving end. She pulled the door handle, listening to the creak as she allowed Daisy and Lizzy to enter the building first. Stepping inside, she shut the door behind her and followed the women.

"This place is creepy," Daisy said.

"All we could do is find the Moonstone and get out of here," Catra said. "Don't let the ancient building intimidate you."

"A ghost could jump out at us," Lizzy replied.

"Let me guess. You read one too many ghost stories."

"Actually, we listened to tales of ghosts when growing up. We don't read books."

The trio entered a passageway, walking past multiple archways and doors. Was there a map, or did they have to figure it out themselves? Catra paced ahead, muttering to herself. If the blonde found a shortcut, she would miss the chance to gain the power she had craved. She stormed into an adjacent corridor, her heartbeat speeding up with each step. There was no way Adora should win. No way the blonde would take the Opal away. After all, she wanted - no, needed - the power. According to Horde Prime, it was her destiny to gain its magic.

"Are you in a hurry?" Lizzy asked, panting as she attempted to catch up to Catra.

"What do you think?" Catra spat.

"Lizzy, don't question her decisions!" Daisy shouted.

"Can you not make a big deal over my response?" Catra asked.

"Whoops. We won't say anything else."

"Good."

After fifteen minutes of navigating the building, Adora and her friends stumbled into a room, where the Moonstone was. The only thing standing in the way was a chasm. Her hair floated upward, glowing in the darkness. Dozens of black rocks pointed to a glowing blue stone. A sphere enveloped the Opal. Something about the color reminded her of the way Catra looked in one of her dreams; a change in hair and eye color. The black rocks gleamed, illuminating the area as she approached the abyss.

"I could teleport you," Glimmer said. "That way, we'd get out of here before Catra gets the Moonstone Opal."

"Or I could walk," Adora replied as she stepped forward.

A path formed as Adora strode toward the Opal. Once she reached the platform, she turned to face Glimmer. Bow, Perfuma, and Sea Hawk waited by the door, watching the couple. She held Glimmer's hands.

"We made it, Glim," Adora said.

"Yeah. The last few months had been crazy," Glimmer replied. "Now go get the Moonstone Opal."

"I will." Adora leaned in and kissed Glimmer's lips, then pulled away. "Thanks for everything."

Adora moved closer to the Opal and reached out for the gem. Before she could grab it, she became aware of the commotion behind her; shouting voices, a few harsh words exchanged, and a dull thud. Or two. A hand with sharp claws snatched the

Moonstone Opal, prompting her to look at whoever took it. Catra stepped in front of her, making eye contact. A magical aura enveloped the brunette's hand.

"Catra! What did you do?" Glimmer spat as she stepped closer.

"Made sure Blondie didn't get the power," Catra replied.

Adora shook her head. "I'm not seeking power. You are."

"Well, I'm fulfilling my destiny."

A bright light enveloped the magicat, altering her appearance; her eyes and hair were now blue, and she wore a black outfit. Catra snickered, glaring at Adora and Glimmer. She lifted her hand; glowing black rocks surrounded the pink-haired woman. Glimmer teleported before more rocks could impale her. She reappeared in front of the door.

"Give me the Moonstone Opal. You don't know what you're dealing with," Adora said.

"Why should I take orders from you?" Catra retorted.

"If the Sundrop and Moonstone don't reunite, the black rocks will destroy everything! The whole world is at-"

"Shut. The. Fuck. Up!"

More black rocks emerged, forming a barrier between the two women. The force of the rocks blasted Adora toward the door; her spine met the floor. She grunted in pain as she sat up. Glimmer sat next to her, then shot Catra a death glare.

"Catra, she told you to give her the Opal. She was right to warn you about the black rocks," Glimmer said.

"Adora is right." Catra laughed mirthlessly. "She gets everything she wants! But not this time. I will win, no matter what it takes! The power is in my hands."

"It's not yours to take!" Glimmer charged at Catra, unleashing powerful spells. "Hand. It. Over!"

"I'm not taking orders from you, either!" Catra conjured more rocks to shield herself. "You can't stop me now, Sparkles. I got stronger."

Bow shot an arrow at Catra; the rocks deflected the projectile. Sea Hawk swung his blade at the rocks; his sword shattered. As Catra stormed out of the room, Adora followed her into a hallway. Closing the distance between herself and Catra, she grabbed the magicat's wrist. Despite the white-hot pain in her wound, she suppressed the urge to whimper.

"Look into my eyes," Adora said.

Catra scowled. "Ugh. Why should I?"

"You'll regret making this choice. Reconsider your decision, and-"

"Listen, Blondie!" Catra yanked her wrist out of Adora's grip. "Don't you get it? I am never regretting what I did!"

"What will you do if there's no life left, and the black rocks end up killing you? Will you regret it, then?"

"I don't care."

"You're crossing the line."

"Of course there's a line... a line between the winners and the losers; between the chosen and the rest. You and Glimmer, and anyone else with decent guardians, are lucky. Meanwhile, I was left to deal with the pain of Shadow Weaver abandoning me! No one cares how I feel! Not even Shakra, the old woman who ran the orphanage!"

"I care about you."

"You're saying this because I mentioned my childhood." Catra whirled around, her back facing Adora. "I intend to cross the line. I never had the chance... and now, I have the opportunity to do so. And I will! You don't know how much I've been denied, even as commander of the royal guard in Bright Moon."

"I'm not just saying that I care. I genuinely do," Adora said.

"You're trying to convince me to let go of the Moonstone Opal. I'd rather see the whole world end -" Catra summoned a barrier of black rocks "- than let you win!"

Adora jumped back. "Wait!"

"I refuse to wait!" Catra raced to the other end of the hallway. "I'm taking what's mine!"

Glimmer and her friends boarded the ship. As she bandaged Adora's wound, she couldn't help but notice the blonde's overly cheery demeanor. Why was her girlfriend acting as if nothing happened? Catra hurt her. And no matter what Adora told the magicat, none of the words had gotten through to Catra. Glimmer rested her chin on Adora's shoulder, then wrapped her arms around her girlfriend's waist, careful of the gashes underneath the blouse and vest.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asked.

"Okay? I'm more than okay. I'm feeling peachy," Adora said.

"Are you sure?"

"Of course!"

"How do you feel about Catra's actions?"

"She took the Moonstone Opal, which isn't good. But the more important thing is going home."

Glimmer released Adora, left the sleeping quarters, and strode to a desk. She occupied an empty chair and began writing a letter.

...

Dear Aunt Casta,

Catra stole the Moonstone Opal and gained its dark power. If it weren't for her actions, the Sundrop would have reunited with the Opal. Adora tried to get through to her, but Catra was too stubborn to give up the Opal. Catra thinks her sad childhood is the perfect excuse for taking it. I'll give you a quick summary of her childhood; Shadow Weaver abandoned her at an orphanage, leaving her for Adora. Back then, Adora was a baby. Anyways, as long as the destructive magic remains in Catra's clutches, she will be capable of great harm. Adora and I must find her and retrieve the Moonstone Opal.

Love,

your Niece, Glimmer

...

Glimmer traced a rune in the air and unleashed a spell. Within minutes, a scroll appeared. Unfurling the letter, she began reading.

...

Dear Glimmer,

I agree with what you said about the destructive magic. I'll tell you this; legends say that Horde Prime will escape if the Sundrop and the Opal clash. If he flees his prison, it will be a matter of time before he destroys the world. Adora may have to find another way to get the Opal without triggering his release. The world is in more danger than ever, and will fare much worse under Horde Prime's control. However, I have a feeling you and Adora won't let evil win.

Speaking of Adora, I've never met her, but I would like to see her in person. Well, maybe after you saved the world. Or before, depending on the circumstances.

Love,

your Aunt Casta

...

Glimmer wasn't sure how to respond. And she had a bad feeling about the coming future. When it came to introducing Adora to Castaspella, such a meeting might have to wait. Would it even be possible to get the Opal without Catra fighting her and Adora? Or was a clash inevitable?

Home Again

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer and Adora check on Bright Moon and Grayskull. Catra gets used to her power. And later on, Glimmer and Adora have a disagreement.

Spring transitioned to summer as Adora and her friends sailed across the ocean. They didn't encounter any storms, despite the occasional discussion regarding hurricanes. On the way to Grayskull, Glimmer insisted on visiting Bright Moon and seeing how things were going. At first, Adora said no, because she wanted to know if her family was okay. After a long conversation, they decided they would go to Bright Moon first. Due to Glimmer's reputation in Bright Moon, the group donned their disguises upon entering the kingdom. In Glimmer's absence, the land changed for the worse; guards scaring villagers into submission, failed uprisings that resulted in bloodshed, and black rocks forcing people out of their homes. Several people either lived on the streets or got arrested.

Glimmer led Adora and the others to a house not too far from Mystacor Academy. Not too far off in the distance, a cluster of guards gave them suspicious looks before moving on. Knocking on the door, she waited for Castaspella to answer. Several minutes dragged on as she tapped her foot. She rested her hands on her hips. What was taking her aunt so long? Nothing happened to Castaspella, right? Or did the guards arrest the older woman?

"Usually, Castaspella doesn't take forever to answer," Glimmer said.

"Maybe she thinks we're here for bad reasons?" Adora replied.

"Didn't she know a spell-"

The door creaked open, revealing Castaspella. "Are you loyal to Queen Catra?"

Glimmer shook her head. "Use the truth spell on us. We're wearing disguises."

"Disguises?" Castaspella beckoned the group into a living room.

Thick curtains concealed every window, hiding the room from the outside world. Summoning a rune, Castaspella unleashed the spell at the group; recognition dawned on her features.

"Glimmer, I didn't think you would come back until after the adventure ends," Castaspella said. "What brings you here?"

Glimmer snapped her fingers; the disguises vanished. "I wanted to see you. And we were checking on the kingdom." She pointed to Adora. "This is Adora, Princess of Grayskull. I'm pretty sure I've already told you about her."

Castaspella shook Adora's hand. "It's a pleasure to meet you, Princess Adora."

"Just call me Adora," Adora said. "Nice to meet you, too."

"Anyways..." Castaspella turned her attention to Perfuma and Sea Hawk. "Who are you?"

"Perfuma. Princess of Plumeria Forest," Perfuma said. "This pirate is Sea Hawk."

"Did you travel with Glimmer and Adora?"

"Yes, we did."

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Quests aside, I'm still thinking of a way for us to take the Moonstone Opal from Catra. She has the power to summon black rocks, and those things are indestructible. It's like a different kind of magic. Is there a spell that affects indestructible stuff?"

Castaspella stroked her chin. "There was, although it summons yellow shards."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Wouldn't yellow shards impale people? I don't want to hurt Catra."

Glimmer tilted her head. "Despite everything Catra did to you?"

"We've gone over this multiple times."

"I know. But I don't trust her with you. Not one bit. I've seen what she did. Doesn't her cruelty make you angry?" Glimmer crossed her arms. "What would you do if Catra takes over Grayskull?"

Catra made her way to Hordak's old room, then shut the door behind her. Every surface and vial had been collecting dust. Because she had been on a trip to find the Moonstone Opal. And she succeeded. *Take that, Hordak and anyone else who cast me aside for someone 'better,'* she wanted to say. A spirit, who appeared to be an inch or two taller than Hordak, materialized. She recognized the green eyes.

"My power worked when I took the Opal," Catra said. "Why isn't it doing anything right now?"

"Remember confronting Adora in that room? What emotion did you feel?" Horde Prime replied.

Catra recalled yelling at Adora and lashing out at the blonde's friends. Only an angry, hateful person would do that. Then, it hit her. She felt rage. White-hot rage toward people who were unfair to her and saw her as an inferior person. Shadow Weaver leaving her for Adora. Hordak replacing her with a new commander. A vague memory of Shakra telling her to be like that "good" kid surfaced. Grunting, she conjured a single black rock.

"Excellent, little sister. Adora deserves the punishment for trying to hinder you," Prime said. "She has already taken a piece of your

power when she touched those black rocks. It's the reason her hair is indestructible. None of the power is meant for her to possess."

"Of course she would steal what should be mine!" Catra replied. "That's what Adora does. I wanted Shadow Weaver to love me, but she never did. She doesn't even care what happens to me."

"I know how it feels to be cast aside." Horde Prime rested a palm on Catra's cheek. "Little sister, I care about you. Shadow Weaver, Hordak, and Adora have no love in their hearts for you."

"Shakra has no love in her heart, also. She plays favorites when it comes to the orphans' behavior."

"Let's focus on something more important; destroying Adora."

What will you do if there's no life left, and the black rocks end up killing you? Will you regret it, then?

Catra's ears twitched. Despite what Adora told her, she would never regret her choice. "Yes, Horde Prime. If I find Adora, I'll end her. And her friends can suffer, too. I will crush them all."

"Adora wields the power of the Sundrop. If you have both the Sundrop and Moonstone, you'll be stronger than ever," Horde Prime said.

Catra smirked. "That would be nice. I'm going to keep testing out my powers."

"Remember, the Moonstone reacts to your rage."

"I'll remember that."

Catra strode out of the dungeon, navigated the hallways, and made her way to Glimmer's room. Everything was left untouched. As her gaze flitted around the room, a portrait caught her attention. Queen Angella held a much younger Glimmer in her arms; Micah stood next to his wife, holding a magical staff.

Hissing under her breath, Catra approached the portrait. Even though it didn't display the current Glimmer, the depiction reminded her of the royal mage who was quick to protect Adora. She swung her hand at the portrait, claws digging into the paper. Large gashes formed across the painting.

Catra didn't stop there; she conjured dozens of black rocks, impaling the furniture and windows. The castle was long overdue for a makeover. She proceeded to the castle gallery and allowed more rocks to grow. Once she shattered every painting, she walked to a flight of stairs. Glimmer would be pissed at the destruction of the castle, but did it matter? The Opal gave Catra unbreakable armor, and she could use the rocks as her primary weapon.

After spending several days in Bright Moon, Adora and the others went to Grayskull Castle. She wasn't sure how she felt about being home. There were still things to fix; black rocks showing up everywhere, Catra carrying the Moonstone Opal, and the possibility of Horde Prime fleeing his prison. Unlike Mara, she didn't save the world. All she did was fail everyone by being too slow to grab the Moonstone Opal. Unless she and Glimmer did something, the entire world would fall into devastation and darkness.

Standing on the balcony, Adora let her hair sway in the wind as she leaned against the tall stone fence. She gazed at the clouds, then folded her arms. Someday, the black rocks would consume everything in their path. Her nightmare about Catra and the demon could come true. Lost in her thoughts, she was unaware of someone approaching. A hand rested on her shoulder, drawing her to reality. Turning around, she saw Glimmer looking at her.

"Adora, you haven't spoken much since we came here," Glimmer said. "Are you okay?"

"Do you think I'm letting Mara's sacrifice be in vain?" Adora asked.

"No. All we did was leave the Fright Zone."

"Without the Moonstone Opal." Adora averted her gaze. "I had the chance to reunite it with the Sundrop, yet I let Catra steal it. Since then, things have gotten worse. And with the possibility of Horde Prime escaping his prison, every kingdom will fall. There will be no one left. Catra will destroy herself due to being evil. All of this is my fault."

Glimmer caressed Adora's arms. "Look at me, starlight. We'll figure this out, no matter how bleak it seems."

"You think so?"

"I know so." Glimmer embraced Adora, resting her head against the blonde's chest. "I have your back. So do our friends."

Adora's heart fluttered. "Speaking of our friends, where are they now?"

"Sea Hawk left Grayskull. Bow and Perfuma are in the strategy room. We could join them and discuss our plans."

"Okay."

Both women strode to the strategy room, where Bow and Perfuma sat. Adora and Glimmer occupied a pair of empty seats. As she scrutinized the map, the figurines stood out to her, especially the ones symbolizing black rocks. Her parents weren't kidding when they said that more rocks appeared in her absence.

"Is waiting it out an option?" Perfuma asked. "I have a feeling Catra wouldn't give us the Opal anytime soon. Maybe the universe will reset itself and heal. It's just a little rough patch."

"A little rough?" Glimmer repeated. "The black rocks won't stop ruining everything! According to Aunt Casta, if the Sundrop and Moonstone clash, Horde Prime will flee his prison."

Adora nodded. "Glimmer's right. If we don't take action, there will be no life left."

Perfuma frowned. "What can we do? Catra has the Moonstone, and-"

"We're not going to fight her." Adora set her palms down flat on the table. "I'm going to talk some sense into her. If she's receptive, there won't be a clash."

Glimmer leaned back in her chair. "I doubt she'll be receptive. You've seen her response to what you told her in Seaworthy Island."

"The clash would aid in Horde Prime's escape."

"Catra's not going to listen. She'll hurt you."

Adora expelled an audible sigh. "Maybe she's like this because you fought her."

Glimmer shot up to her height. "Listen up, Adora! All I want to do is keep you safe. I don't want you to risk your life trying to change her mind! She scratched you two times, and the last time we saw her, she tried to kill you!"

Adora rose, too. "I'm not fragile! She might have scratched me, but guess what? I'm still alive."

"Next time, you may not be as lucky. I get that you want to calm her down, but the plan to avoid fighting won't work. I don't trust her to avoid attacking you!"

"I have no desire to let a clash happen between the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal. We know what the consequences would be. Horde Prime will destroy everything in his path!"

Bow held up his hands. "Hey! Easy! There's no reason to argue!"

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "Adora, I won't let you endanger yourself in an effort to make Catra listen!"

Adora stormed toward the door. "I'm going to my room. Don't follow me. I need alone time."

Glimmer made her way into the courtyard. She couldn't believe what she did; arguing with Adora not long after she comforted her girlfriend. Pacing back and forth, she silently scolded herself for making the blonde feel upset. She wanted to protect Adora at all costs, yet the blonde insisted on not fighting Catra. The magicat had attacked them during their confrontation over the Moonstone Opal. As far as she knew, there wasn't any kindness in Catra's heart. What did Adora see in her?

"Glimmer, is this your first argument?"

Glimmer turned around and saw Bow sitting on a bench. "I guess you could say that. Do you and Perfuma ever argue?"

"Sometimes we disagree. The first one is the hardest, though," Bow said.

"What do I do? I rose my voice at Adora, something Shadow Weaver once did in the past."

"Give Adora some space. Eventually, you'll have to talk it out in a peaceful manner. When Perfuma and I disagreed for the first time, we spent a bit of time apart. Later, we had a calm discussion."

"I hope Adora and I don't end our relationship after this."

"I don't think it will happen. The two of you are meant for each other."

The bedroom door creaked open. "Adora, can I come in?"

Adora looked up from her journal. She could see Perfuma peeking into the room. "Well, sure. Is there something you want to talk about?"

"Yeah." Perfuma stepped into the room and plopped onto a chair by the nightstand. "How did the fight make you feel?"

Adora took in a deep, calming breath. She hadn't expected Glimmer to yell at her. The shorter woman had reserved the loud voice and harsh words for when she wanted to shout at an enemy. But to hear Glimmer raise her voice earlier? Glimmer wasn't the first person to do so. Shadow Weaver had done it many times in the past.

"I didn't think she would yell at me," Adora said. "She's not like Shadow Weaver, but her voice still startled me. How do you and Bow handle disagreements?"

"We talk it out," Perfuma replied. "And if either one of us said something in the heat of the moment, we usually apologize."

"Easier said than done. When you're stuck in a tower for eighteen years, you're going to want freedom and to not be babysat all the time. I don't mind when Glimmer protects me, yet there were times when she seems to go overboard."

"Glimmer cares about you. And considering what Catra could have done to you-"

"I know. And I don't want my freedom to be restricted. Shadow Weaver raised me and Catra, which makes us sisters. It's the reason I have no desire to fight her."

Perfuma sighed. "I've never had a sibling, whether adoptive or biological, so I don't know what to tell you. Perhaps the universe will give you a perfect solution."

Adora shut her journal. "You're speaking of the universe as though it was a living thing. What has it done when Shadow Weaver held me captive for eighteen years?"

"The day before your birthday, fate sent Glimmer to the tower. And the two of you met. You never returned to the tower after that."

"True. But Shadow Weaver attacked us on the night of my birthday."

"And you healed Glimmer."

Adora recalled the night Glimmer slipped into unconsciousness in her arms. "She could have been gone forever."

Perfuma strode to the edge of the bed. "I know, but she's still here. Maybe someday, once all this is over, you and Glimmer will rule together as queens. The two of you are stronger together."

"Glimmer told me that, too."

"I believe your relationship will survive the disagreement."

The Cat Abducts the Prince

Chapter Summary

> Catra interrupts a ball and kidnaps Prince Adam. After that, Adora and her friends try to figure out a way to rescue her brother without letting the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal clash.

Two days passed as Adora and Glimmer avoided each other. Unspoken words lingered on their tongues each time they were in the same room, anticipating release. Yet neither woman had the heart to initiate a conversation. If they made eye contact, they would exchange apologetic looks. One morning, Adora found Glimmer in the courtyard, lingering on a bench. She didn't want any of this to go any longer. The lack of communication between them weighed on her heart.

"So, Glimmer..." Adora began, unsure what to say next. "Did you wake up earlier than I did?"

Glimmer made eye contact, then glanced at the rosebush. "I couldn't sleep." Her fingertips brushed the rose petals. "That's all I can say."

"I couldn't sleep, either."

"The sunrise is pretty, though."

"Yeah, it is." Adora gazed at the streaks of pink and orange in the sky. "You'd have to wake up earlier to watch sunrises, though."

Glimmer wore a soft smile. "I'll stick with sunsets and moonrises."

"You know, on some nights, the moon is invisible. And if it's cloudy, you can't see the stars."

Glimmer's smile faded. "I'm sorry for yelling at you."

"I'm sorry, too." Adora sat next to Glimmer. "The other day, I was feeling frustrated. Black rocks, Catra, the possibility of Horde Prime's release..." She wrapped her arms around herself. "I... I'm worried. If the Sundrop and Opal don't reunite, if they clash, and if Horde Prime..." A memory of a nightmare surfaced as she spoke. "If we fail to protect everyone from Prime and the black rocks, the entire world will be doomed."

"Adora..." Glimmer placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. "I'd be lying if I say that I'm not feeling the same way. I don't want to see Bright Moon fall. And I don't want to see Grayskull suffer, either."

"When I discovered my true identity after eighteen years, I didn't expect the burden of the world's fate to rest on my shoulders. It's not like I'm going to turn into another Mara. Am I? What are we going to do?"

"We have some options, but they'll have consequences."

"I could face Catra alone."

Due to their proximity, Adora felt Glimmer's body going tense. The pink-haired woman swore under her breath.

"I don't want you to get hurt," Glimmer said. "I don't like the idea of you and Catra being alone together, with no one present to intervene."

"Well, you could stay close by in case things go south," Adora replied.

Glimmer held Adora's hands. "I like that idea."

Adora couldn't help but grin. It was a start, and despite fearing the end of their relationship, there was no break-up. As the sun rose higher into the sky, shadows vanished. A warm breeze tickled her face.

"Glim, did you ever think about the day we met in the tower?" Adora asked, gazing into Glimmer's violet eyes.

"Yes," Glimmer replied, her thumbs rubbing small circles on Adora's hands.

"Perfuma said it was fate."

"She said that?"

Adora nodded.

"Perfuma believes that everyone has a destiny."

"Well, we all have a dream," Adora said.

Glimmer chuckled. "I remember that morning in the restaurant. Sea Hawk and everyone else sang about their dreams."

"Back then, I didn't like talking in front of crowds."

"Yet you still spoke. Since then, you overcame your fear of large crowds. Someday, you'll be queen, right? Public speaking is a part of being queen. I've seen my mother speak to the audience in the throne room. And sometimes outside the castle."

"Still, you would do a better job as a queen." Adora stood. "We're going to have breakfast soon."

"Queen Catra, someone has requested an audience with you in the throne room," Juliet said.

Catra's ears twitched. It better not be yet another person who complained about her reign. She didn't have the patience for such rebels. She followed the commander to the throne room and occupied the throne. A raven-haired woman with fair skin scowled at her. The woman wore a floor-length gown, and her hair was pulled back into a bun. Catra crossed her legs, glowering at the

visitor. Claws digging into the armrests, she watched the woman performing a mock curtsy.

"The title isn't yours to carry," the woman said, making eye contact.

"What's your name? And why do you disrespect me?" Catra spat.

"I'm Castaspella, Micah's sister. You don't deserve any respect."

"So, you have a connection to Glimmer. Where is she? And do you know anything about the Princess of Grayskull?"

"I'm not going to tell you."

"Adora has the power of the Sundrop."

"How do you know?"

Catra hissed. "Word travels around. You would be wise to avoid defying me."

Castaspella gave a dismissive wave of her hand. "Whatever. If you don't abdicate the throne-"

"I'll never do it."

"I can't believe we're stuck with you. I might be a little rusty on magic, but I do know some spells."

Catra shot up, straightening her spine. "Are you threatening me? I can easily destroy you with black rocks." She conjured a cluster of black rocks near Castaspella's side. "Unless you want to die, forget it."

Castaspella's eyes widened. "N-No. Don't kill me."

Catra threw her head back, laughing. "You backed down as soon as you saw them. You're a coward. Threats only work on someone who has something to lose. As for me, I've lost everything. Your threat is meaningless. All talk, no fight."

"Glimmer will stop you."

"Oh, come on. Sparkles hasn't paid me a visit. Besides, she chose to run away on the night of her mother's death."

Castaspella hurried toward the exit. "You will not prevail!"

Catra's tail swished from side to side. "My power will protect me from you and everyone else who defies me."

Once Castaspella left the throne room, Catra strode out of the castle and glared at the crowd. Crossing her arms, she said, "If there's still someone who doesn't like my reign, turn them in. It doesn't matter who they are; friends, enemies, relatives, strangers, and children. I will deal with them."

A week later, the King of Grayskull hosted a royal ball and invited many people. Adora and Glimmer had changed into their formal gowns prior to entering the ballroom. They made their way to a table, where Bow, Perfuma, Adam, and Teela were sitting. Perfuma wore an elegant pink gown with floral accents instead of her usual dress. A single flower rested on Bow's vest. Adora looked to the right; King Randor and Queen Marlena occupied one of the tables, holding hands. Several guests gathered by the buffet, chatting as they sipped their wines. A few voices interrupted Adora's thoughts; she turned her attention to Bow.

"Perfuma and I have some exciting news to share," Bow said as he grabbed Perfuma's hand.

"We're getting married," Perfuma said.

Glimmer gasped. "Congratulations! Have you decided on a date?"

"Not yet."

Bow frowned. "We could wait until after the black rocks go away."

Adora wrapped her fingers around a wine glass. "That aside, I'm happy for you."

Adam smiled. "Can I be the person of honor at your wedding?"

Teela set her glass on the table. "Can we discuss something other than weddings? Bow and Perfuma just got engaged."

"We'll talk about something else, then."

"You could start by asking about their adventure beyond Grayskull."

Adam cleared his throat. "Alright. Bow, how was the adventure?"

Bow leaned back in his chair. "It had been chaotic at times."

Adora held up a finger. "Still, it was fun."

Adora proceeded to narrate the story to Adam and Teela, starting with a visit to the restaurant. She continued the tale; the time she and her friends got stranded on Beast Isle, Huntara taking them to Seaworthy Island, and exploring the Fright Zone. When she brought up the confrontation over the Moonstone Opal, Adam asked several questions regarding Catra's motive. She explained that Catra saw her traumatic childhood as a reason to steal the Opal.

"Another question; why do you consider her a sibling?" Adam asked.

"Shadow Weaver raised both of us," Adora said.

"You said she hurt you, though."

The musical rhythm slowed; a few couples began dancing. Adora took Glimmer's hand and strode toward the dance floor. Both women gazed into each other's eyes. She wrapped her arms around Glimmer's waist, while the shorter woman wrapped hers around Adora's neck. Their foreheads met, and their breaths

mingled. She closed her eyes. Just as her lips brushed Glimmer's, a gust of wind blew into the ballroom.

Adora pulled away, eyes fluttering open as she glanced at the large doors. It was dark in here, as the wind had extinguished every chandelier. A silhouette lingered in the doorway; she recognized the ears and tail. What was Catra doing here?

"I'm surprised no one has invited me," Catra said. "I'm the Queen of Bright Moon, not a random person who doesn't deserve an invitation."

"Catra, why are you here?" Glimmer shouted, stepping in front of Adora.

"To pay the most *beloved* princess a visit." Catra walked closer. "Adora, some people say you wield the power of the Sundrop. Guess they're right." She extended a hand toward Adora's cheek.

A memory of Catra scratching Adora's face arose. Adora stepped back, her eyes fixating on the claws. Glimmer traced a rune in the air, then unleashed a wind spell at the magicat.

"Stay away from Adora!" Glimmer spat.

Catra snickered, shaking her head. "I was expecting this from you anyways, Sparkles. You're so quick to be Adora's knight in shining armor, yet you abandoned Bright Moon and your mother."

Glimmer launched a fireball at Catra; the magicat conjured black rocks to defend herself from the raging flames. Despite the rocks being indestructible, Glimmer continued blasting the barrier with her magic. Everyone watched the scene; none of them moved a single inch. Dozens of guards charged at Catra, aiming their weapons at her. Black rocks surrounded the guards, hindering their movements. Teela unsheathed a concealed sword; belting out a battle cry, she lunged at the magicat.

"Everyone, stop fighting Catra!" Adora shouted, garnering the crowd's attention. "You're making her angrier at the world. She's

bitter because Shadow Weaver left her at an orphanage." She approached Catra. "Attacking people won't make you feel better. You don't have to be cruel to those who don't deserve it. Not everyone is out to cast you aside for someone who they think is better."

"Stop acting like you care about me. I know you're scared of me - I can see it in your eyes and body language," Catra said. "I'll take something from you, see how you feel. Would you fight me, then? Or are you going to put on a sad face and say: *'Oh, no! I don't want to fight you! Wah, wah, wah!'* Another thing - because you're so weak, you're more likely to choose the second option."

"What will it take for you to change your heart?"

"What will it take for *you* to fight back?" Catra made her way to Adam's table. "Look at you, all alone without someone to defend you." She yanked out a potion and tossed it at the prince.

"Catra, don't-" Bow began.

A black rock shot up from the ground, blasting Bow into the nearest wall. Perfuma screamed as she rushed to Bow's side.

"Of course your first response is to scream and act helpless," Catra said. "I remember you calling Lizzy a ruffian."

"Guards, get her!" Randor ordered.

As if on cue, the guards advanced. Once again, Catra was swift to hinder them. The magicat chucked another potion at the floor; the shattered vial emitted a smoky fog, making everyone cough. By the time the fog faded away, Adam and Catra were gone. Did the magicat kidnap the prince?

"What happened to Adam?" Marlena asked.

"Catra happened!" Glimmer shouted.

Adora frowned. "We'll go find Adam."

Glimmer crossed her arms. "We can't risk losing you. I'm going alone."

"No, you're not. We'll do this together."

"You're unwilling to fight Catra."

"What do you want me to do to her instead?"

Randor cleared his throat. "Guests, you may leave the ballroom. Soldiers, find the woman who kidnapped Prince Adam."

Glimmer and her friends gathered in Adora's bedroom to discuss their rescue mission. Adora sat in the chair, head lowered to her chest as her posture slumped. Perfuma wrapped both arms around Bow's left arm. If the group tried to save Adam, either a clash would occur between the Sundrop and Moonstone, or they could lose someone. Catra was a danger to everyone, especially Adora.

"We may have to destroy Catra and get the Moonstone," Glimmer suggested.

"No, we're not," Adora replied.

"Don't you want to save your brother?"

"Of course I do!" Adora twisted a blonde strand around her finger. "It's just that I have no desire to kill Catra."

"Is there any other way?"

"Uh, maybe a sleeping spell?"

Glimmer shrugged. "I guess. Or I could make a potion."

Perfuma furrowed her brows. "Do you think you guys would have a chance when battling Catra?"

"My trick arrows won't work on black rocks," Bow said.

Glimmer stroked her chin. "Our plan could go like this; we storm wherever Catra is holding Adam, and I distract her with many spells and teleports. Then, one of you tosses a sleeping potion at Catra. Adora takes the Moonstone Opal. No clash between the Opal and Sundrop takes place as a result. We'll free Adam and arrest Catra."

"She'll deflect the potion."

"I could make sure she doesn't see anyone throwing the vial at her."

Adora shook her head. "Catra would catch on. If we were to pour all our focus into distracting her, she'll figure that we're trying to take the Moonstone Opal."

Glimmer massaged her temples. "Did anybody else see holes in my plans that I *apparently* overlooked?"

"You haven't taken something much more dangerous into consideration; Horde Prime's release."

"I'm not the one with the Sundrop. Does anyone have better ideas? Any other objections to my plan?"

"Well, the rocks are dangerous," Bow said.

"I know, which is why the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal must reunite," Adora said.

Glimmer strode to the door. "I'm going to make a sleeping potion, and then we'll find Catra."

Free at Last

Chapter Summary

> The group tries to rescue Adam from Catra, but the magicat doesn't let him go. The Sundrop and the Moonstone clash, resulting in Horde Prime's escape.

According to Glimmer's location spell, Catra hid in the tower. Though, someone must have renovated the building at one point. Adora and her friends embarked on a journey to the forest, searching for the tower. She never expected to return to the very place she had left. As the group arrived in a familiar meadow, she froze at the sight of the tower. Stone fragments and cracked murals cluttered the ground. Was Catra sending a message? Her gaze flitted to a broken piece of her painting, something she made at twelve years old. Tears blurring her vision, she picked up the fragment. It was one of her favorite portraits, and Catra ruined it.

"It's much taller than the old one. And where's the entrance?" Glimmer said.

Bow shot an arrow at a ledge; the projectile transformed into a long rope. It flew past the closest ledge, barely touching the black rock. "Darn it. Is there another way to get in?"

"I could teleport."

Adora tossed her hair upward; it fell to the ground. "This tower is nothing like my childhood home."

"You don't have any good memories of this place, do you?" Glimmer asked. "I saw you pick up a painting."

"I had a few; I painted gorgeous pictures and read my favorite books. Once, I took Kowl in, and we became best friends ever since."

"How did you meet the bird?"

"He came into the tower one night when I was twelve..."

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6 Years Ago

Adora didn't like it when she was told to play quietly; she was having so much fun, pretending to be the main character from her favorite book. All she did was smack the railing with her frying pan once. The sound had summoned an angry Shadow Weaver. Sighing, she strode to the bookshelf and grabbed the book. Its cover read: "She-Ra." She sat by the window, humming as she pored over the pages. One of the pages depicted the main character hugging the pink-haired girl. It had been the inspiration behind today's painting. A hiss, accompanied by lightning, interrupted her thoughts as she looked up.

On the windowsill, a snake circled a bird. Adora rushed to the kitchen, snatched a frying pan, and crept closer. If she made a sound, the snake could attack. *She-Ra wouldn't be afraid to fight an enemy,* she told herself. She swung the pan at the snake and connected, blasting it off the windowsill.

"Are you okay?" Adora asked the bird.

The bird let out a weak chirp. Adora wrapped her hair around his body and began singing.

Flower, gleam and glow

Let your power shine

Make the clock reverse

Bring back what once was mine

What once was mine

Within seconds, the song healed the bird. Adora said, "I'm gonna call you Kowl, like the bird in my favorite story."

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Present

"That is a sweet story," Glimmer said. "Anyways, I'm about to check if there's a way in." She vanished, then reappeared on a ledge. "Guys, there's an entrance, but I'll have to teleport you."

"We're going to teleport all the way up there?" Adora asked.

"The ledge doesn't seem stable," Bow said.

Glimmer teleported to Adora's side, grabbed her and Bow, and reappeared on the ledge. The large black rock retreated into the tower, carrying them into a large room. They approached Catra. On one side of the room, Adam was trapped in a cage. Adora made eye contact before glancing at the magicat. The stronghold was spacious; all she could see was blue. She glimpsed a broken mural on the cold floor.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said. "I figured you would come for Adam. I'm not giving him up without a fight. Then again, you're too unwilling to fight me."

"Let's talk," Adora replied.

"Oh, sure. Let's have another chat about how Shadow Weaver chose you over me."

"Shadow Weaver took me and held me against my will. I didn't choose to be kidnapped by a madwoman."

"Well, did you choose to shove her out a window?"

"You weren't there. Weaver tripped and fell out the window."

Catra snickered. "It doesn't matter either way. You stole my chance of seeing her again and asking her why she left me."

Adora arched a single brow. "If she had remained alive, she would have continued using me for my hair. All she cares about is staying young and beautiful."

"Whatever. Get out of here."

"I'm not leaving until you give me the Moonstone Opal!"

"Then I guess you're not leaving." Catra rose her arms upward; black rocks blocked every window. "I have complete control over the rocks. You know what this tower is made of?"

"I already know." Adora narrowed her eyes. "I'm not going to fight you. If the Sundrop and Moonstone clash, Horde Prime will escape his prison."

"The battle will be easy."

Glimmer widened her stance. "What are you going to do to my girlfriend?"

Catra smirked. "You'll see. First, Arrow Boy needs to get out of the way." With a snap of her fingers, she summoned a prison of black rocks, restricting Bow's limbs.

Adora straightened her spine. "Release him."

Glimmer tossed the potion to Adora. "I'll fight Catra. Our plan better work."

Catra rested a hand on her hip. "What plan?"

Glimmer proceeded to fight Catra, while Adora tried her best to stay out of sight so she could chuck the potion. Fifteen minutes dragged on as Glimmer unleashed a variety of spells. Catra deflected her magic each time. The magicat had lightning-quick reflexes, summoning barriers whenever she defended herself. Once Catra's back was facing Adora, the blonde flung the vial. Catra turned around just in time to catch the potion.

"What makes you think you can outsmart me?" Catra said. "The potion's in my hands now."

"Hand over the potion and the Moonstone Opal," Adora replied.

"I'll never take orders from you! Also..." Catra tossed the potion at Glimmer's feet. "Someone sure put up a fight."

The shattered vial emitted a cloud of smoke; the cloud enveloped Glimmer. Within seconds, she passed out on the floor, unconscious. Catra glowered at Adora, holding up a hand. Should Adora resort to violence? Or should she keep trying to make Catra listen? The brunette began singing an incantation, interrupting her thoughts.

Crescent high above

Evolving as you go

Raise what lies beneath

The floor beneath Adora ascended, forming a platform as it shot up toward the ceiling. Before the platform could collide with the ceiling, her hair formed a shield around her body. The next thing she knew, the floor descended.

"There are some things your hair can't block," Catra said.

"This has got to stop!" Adora replied.

The rock beneath Adora collapsed; she began falling, but was swift to loop her hair around a ledge. Climbing back into the room, she anticipated another attack. She evaded the black rocks and rushed toward Catra. Despite not wanting to battle the magicat, she wondered if she should stop holding back. Catra had restrained Bow and Adam, thrown the sleeping potion at Glimmer, and refused to give her the Moonstone Opal.

"Why don't you just give up?" Catra spat.

"Because I don't want to," Adora replied.

Catra conjured dozens of black rocks; some of them pinned Adora to the wall. "I can't wait to see the looks on your friends' faces when they find out you failed to save them."

"I *will* save them! And none of this will stop me from trying to get through to you."

"Look at you, naively believing in the power of love and friendship." Catra lowered her brows. "You and your friends are so emotional. It's the reason you won't win."

"Would you rather see people hurting each other?"

"Why do you ask?"

Adora sighed. "Can you at least answer my question?"

"Whatever. It looks like you'll be stuck up there for a while," Catra said, conjuring a rock cage to trap a sleeping Glimmer. "Your knight's not going to save you this time. Adora, unless you come up with something, I'll destroy you. But I'd do it either way."

Glimmer had no idea where she was; all she could see around her were constellations and floating debris. She had to find a way back to the tower, where Adora was. Someone must have taken her to this area. One of the trees glided toward her. A ghost materialized; he was tall and wore a formal outfit. A sinister smile widened across his face. She dug her mind for any memories of the spells she had learned, only to find nothing.

"Hello, little sister," the spirit said.

"Uh, we're not related. And I don't know who you are," Glimmer said.

"My identity isn't important. There's a way to stop Catra. The Sundrop must use it against the Moonstone's power."

"Wouldn't it trigger a clash, releasing Horde Prime?"

At the mention of Horde Prime, the spirit's expression became neutral. "Desperate times call for desperate measures."

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asked, not wanting to know the answer.

The ground disappeared beneath Glimmer's feet; before she could blink, she fell into the starry abyss. A disembodied voice whispered an incantation into her ear.

...

Glimmer's eyes fluttered open; she found herself in a cage. Kowl flew toward her; the chant flashed into her mind. It wasn't just a dream, right? She couldn't forget the spirit's facial expression when she brought up Horde Prime. Did he know something? Would the spell work without causing the Sundrop and Moonstone to clash? Peeking through the holes in the cage, she detected black rocks pinning her girlfriend to a wall.

"Kowl, I heard an incantation in my dream," Glimmer said.

The bird chirped; Glimmer whispered the chant to him. Once she was done, Kowl flew to Adora's side. Catra crossed her arms, then rolled her eyes. Was the magicat underestimating Adora? The blonde began singing.

Power of the sun, gift me with your light,

Shine into the dark, restore our fading sight,

Rise into the dawn, blazing star so bright...

The black rocks shattered as Adora continued the song. She levitated in the air, her hair shining like the sun. The light exploded; a gust of wind pierced the room. Each time Catra summoned the rocks, Adora would demolish them with her power. Flashes of yellow and blue lit up the room. Out of the corner of

Glimmer's eyes, she detected a silhouette. The figure's shape resembled the spirit from her dream. They ascended into a portal and disappeared inside. Each prison cracked, freeing Glimmer, Adam, and Bow. Within minutes, Catra fell out of the tower.

Adora reclined on the floor; the amount of magic she used to battle Catra seemed to exhaust her. She rose to her height, panting. Glimmer rushed to her side. So did Adam and Bow.

"Catra made her choice," Adora said. "She should live with it."

"Does it mean you're done chasing after Catra?" Glimmer asked. "By the way, what you did was awesome."

"It was hard, yet I was left with no choice. Wait a minute. The Sundrop and Moonstone Opal clashed, didn't they?"

"They did. I saw a spirit entering a portal."

Adora furrowed her brows. "Are you saying that Horde Prime escaped?"

Glimmer nodded. "He did. We may have to come up with a plan to stop him and Catra."

Catra made her way to the main room in her tower. Piles of rubble cluttered the floor. She couldn't believe she lost to Adora. A sphere of green light nearly blinded her; as she opened her eyes, she gasped. Horde Prime was no longer a spirit. He wore a white outfit, and his eyes were bright green. She had seen a lot of shocking things in her life, but none of them topped a ghost gaining a physical form.

"Finally... the clash of sun and moon released me. It's good to be back," Horde Prime said.

"Released you from what?" Catra asked.

"My prison. It was unjust of my enemies to lock me away."

"Unjust?"

"That's right."

"So, what are you going to do?"

Horde Prime steepled his fingers. "For now, I will guide you. The blonde one is determined. Not too different from Mara."

Catra tilted her head. "The legendary heroine?"

"Correct. Anyways..." Horde Prime rested a hand on Catra's cheek. "Don't let your defeat discourage you."

Catra wasn't sure what to feel about the icy touch. A vague memory of her toddler years surfaced; Shadow Weaver caressing her cheek whenever she told her to do something. The gesture was manipulative, a subtle way of saying, "I love you when you obey me." Aware of her tail bristling, she smoothed the hairs. Horde Prime observed her, as though gazing into her soul.

"I am not going to harm you, little sister," Horde Prime said.

"Good. We'll work together to crush Adora and her friends," Catra said.

Later that night, Adora and Glimmer reclined beneath the covers of their bed, cuddling. Today, they didn't have one dull moment; the rescue mission and the fight with Catra. They had gotten Adam back, yet they didn't retrieve the Moonstone Opal. Also, if Catra wanted to remain evil, fine. There was still a tiny inkling of hope in Adora's heart that Catra would change, though. Taking in deep breaths, she looked into Glimmer's eyes. The shorter woman stroked her hair.

"Sorry my plan didn't work out," Glimmer said.

"It's okay. At least Adam's home, safe and sound," Adora replied. "The world? Everyone's in danger, now that Horde Prime is free."

Through it All

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Horde Prime have taken over Grayskull. It's up to Adora and Glimmer to save the day.

Chapter Notes

> This is a much longer chapter than normal, but I wanted to get the climax out of the way and get to the "happily ever after" sort of epilogue.

Glimmer jolted awake, panting; scenes from the nightmare surfaced. The most prominent one? She had been telling a demon with green eyes to stop hurting Adora. Ever since both women discussed Horde Prime's release, she felt a strong need to protect Adora. Inhaling deeply, she focused on the sunlight streaming into the room. Adora stirred awake, then sat up. Sure, the blonde was safe, but for how much longer? Until Horde Prime and Catra attacked innocent people? Until the black rocks consumed everything in their path? She pulled Adora into an embrace, as if defending her from invisible enemies. If Horde Prime and Catra lay a single finger on her girlfriend, she would retaliate.

"A good-morning hug?" Adora asked.

"Yeah. Sort of." Glimmer released Adora. "I had a nightmare about Horde Prime hurting you. I couldn't save you, and-"

"I'm still alive, right? If he attacks Grayskull, the soldiers will fight back. So will both of us. Not to mention Teela and Bow."

"So, how are you going to fight Horde Prime if he's in his demon form?"

"I could use my hair and the frying pan."

"I'm not letting you face him alone. Remember Mara's tale? She lost her life while battling Prime."

Adora scooted off the bed, then stood. "I won't let her sacrifice be in vain."

"What will you do?" Glimmer swung her legs over the edge of the bed. "Don't you want to be happy? To live in a peaceful world?"

"I may have to sacrifice myself."

An image of Horde Prime's demon form surfaced. For a moment, the scene in the dream replayed; Adora struggling against his hold, and Glimmer frozen to the spot as she begged him to stop.

Don't hurt her. Please! You can't hurt her!

"No. I will not let you. There's a way to stop Prime and the black rocks without anyone dying," Glimmer said.

"Are you saying this because of the dream?" Adora asked.

"Yes. The dream felt so real." Glimmer slipped into her tunic and leggings. She completed her outfit with a suit of armor. "We'll discuss battle plans with Bow, Teela, and the other soldiers."

"The battle hasn't started, you know."

"We've got to be prepared, just in case."

Catra and Horde Prime made their way into Gray Haven. Bystanders stared at them with wide eyes, whispering to one another. Small children pointed, while adults pulled them away. A few guards drew their weapons and advanced. Glowering at them, she conjured block rocks to keep them at bay. Those people's reactions were priceless; they were scared of a magicat and a tall man. She was here for a reason; to destroy Adora and her friends, once and for all. As long as she wielded the power of the

Moonstone, no one would stand in her way. A small child stopped in front of them. She hissed at the child.

It didn't take long for the child to cry for their parents. Catra threw her head back, laughing. More guards emerged from the alleyways; she summoned more black rocks. They surrounded the guards, hindering their movements. Dozens of locals began evacuating the town as the rocks pierced multiple buildings. Once everyone else left, she turned to face Horde Prime.

"None of them saw this coming," Catra said, snickering.

Horde Prime wore a sinister smirk. "True. When you confront Adora and those who mean a lot to her, do not hold back."

"I won't. They have something to lose."

You'll regret making this choice.

"You seem unsure about your decision," Horde Prime said.

"What makes you say that?" Catra replied.

"I can see it in your face; wrinkled forehead, squinting eyes, and rubbing the back of your neck. You're not allowing Adora's words to get to you, right? Don't make the mistake of backing down. Remember what she took from you."

I didn't choose to be kidnapped by a madwoman.

You've been cast aside your entire life.

Catra grunted, hugging herself as she shoved the voices out of her head. She couldn't afford to befriend the enemy. Not when victory was in sight. There was one person who cared about her, but she viewed it as being annoying. That one person was Scorpia, and she pushed her away. *No, Catra! You must focus on the goal!* She told herself.

"Thinking of conceding?" Horde Prime asked.

"What? No!" Catra replied, clutching her wild curls.

"Like everyone else in this miserable world, you are emotional. It will be a shame to let your feelings get in the way."

"Trust me. I'm not weak. Adora's the weak one, ruled by her emotions. Alright, let's proceed with our plan. Two of us against everyone else."

Horde Prime patted Catra's head. "We'll see about that, little sister."

Ugh! Not that condescending nickname again!

"Why do you refer to people as little siblings?" Catra asked.

"Because I'm ancient," Horde Prime replied.

"Does it mean you view everyone else as insignificant?"

"Every asset has a place. If they cease to be useful, it's over for them."

When an asset fails to serve its purpose, it becomes worthless to me.

The more they spoke, the less Catra trusted Horde Prime. What would he do if he somehow found any fault in her? Cast her aside? When it came to "assets," Horde Prime and Hordak held similar opinions. Was it a mistake to talk to him in the mirror in the first place? They strode toward the castle; more guards approached them.

"You shall not invade the castle!" A tall guard shouted.

Catra conjured a wall of black rocks, deflecting every attack. "You people are no match for me! Where is Princess Adora of Grayskull? I'm here to see her!"

"Evacuate the castle!" A feminine voice shouted.

Catra balled her hands into angry fists. "You cowards can run away! The castle is mine now."

Evening came. Adora and her friends, including her family, decided to stay at a restaurant by the lake. Everyone kept their weapons and armor nearby in case they needed something to defend themselves with. Glimmer had suggested using a spell to weaken an ancient demon, while Adora asked if they could seek answers from the spirit world; specifically, Mara. Both women were unwilling to give up, no matter how bleak things seemed.

"There has to be something," Adora said as she followed Glimmer to the lake.

It was a starless night, with no moon in sight. A distant hoot drew Adora's attention to the trees. At the moment, her mind dwelled on the fate of the world. One wrong move, and every kingdom would succumb to destruction. Of all the dangers she had faced in the past, she had never fought a demon. She hoped she would have the courage to face Horde Prime when she saw his demon form in person.

"There are more black rocks than ever. Catra is still on the side of evil. And Horde Prime, he..." Adora's voice trailed off. "Mara and her friends wouldn't allow things to get this bad."

"Adora, you haven't allowed anything to intimidate you," Glimmer said. "You revived me, stopped a blizzard, went on a dangerous adventure, and rescued your brother. Horde Prime and Catra haven't stopped us. They want us to let them win, but the victory will not be theirs. We will win in the end. However, there has to be a way to defeat Prime and Catra without losing anyone."

"Can you summon Mara's spirit? She might have some insight."

"Sure. But I may still use a spell to weaken Horde Prime."

Glimmer traced a rune on the ground, chanting an incantation. As she rose to her height, a spirit materialized. So, this was Mara; a

youthful appearance, long brown hair, tan skin, and a suit of armor. There was a look of weariness in Mara's eyes, mixed with sadness.

"I am Mara, the chosen heroine of the world, and I am gone," Mara said.

"I'm Adora, and I want some insight on how to defeat Horde Prime," Adora replied. "I also want to stop more black rocks from growing."

"Has he escaped his prison?"

"Yes."

"Did the Sundrop and the Moonstone Opal remain separate?"

"Yes."

Mara gazed at the sky. "I thought the magic of the sorcerers was powerful enough to keep Horde Prime imprisoned forever. He has always sought power, due to dark magic corrupting his mind. He had a vast army of monsters and evil spirits. Anyone who tried to stop him would perish. When he heard rumors of the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal, he began his search for them."

Adora cleared her throat. "We've heard of the tale of you saving the world from Horde Prime... and your sacrifice. I wield the power of the Sundrop. Catra has the Moonstone."

"Adora, I have heard of a prophecy of two women, holding the powers of the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal. The prediction has yet to be fulfilled. According to a sorcerer who could see into the future, they would reunite the two stones and defeat Horde Prime."

"Catra will be too stubborn to work with me. Besides, Glimmer can slow Prime down with a spell or two."

"Catra may surprise you. The sorcerer has also said that the woman holding the Moonstone Opal will realize what she has done, and will make amends with the one who possesses the Sundrop."

Adora sighed. "Whoever the sorcerer is, they're wrong about the prediction."

Mara shrugged. "You'll have to wait and see. Adora, you can save everyone. But you have a whole life ahead of you, dreams and wishes yet to be fulfilled. Don't throw your life away, as I once did."

"So, if I shouldn't sacrifice myself, then what should I do?" As Adora spoke, she watched as Mara's spirit faded away. "Wait. Answer my question!"

Within seconds, Mara vanished, along with the rune.

By sunrise, everyone awakened. No one came up with a plan yet, due to a lack of hope. Adora could see it in everyone's expressions. However, Glimmer's was a look of determination. Bow and Perfuma seemed conflicted, while Mermista and Sea Hawk were busy discussing shanties. Teela and a group of guards sat at a bar, sipping their drinks and mentioning the loss of their home. Adam, Randor, and Marlena occupied a table by the fireplace.

"I will not sugarcoat this," Adora said as she stepped onto the stage. "This is the biggest challenge all of us will ever face."

Glimmer joined Adora. "I'm here today because I will help Adora take back Grayskull. There's something we still need to do. Besides, Horde Prime has taken over. So has Catra." She grabbed Adora's hand. "We won't let them win. Together, all of us will take back our home, once and for all."

Everyone cheered as Adora and Glimmer pumped their fists in the air.

"Now is the time to fight," Adora said. "Let's turn our losing streak around. Rise and unite!"

"If we're to win, we can't turn back or sneak around," Glimmer said.

"Once we begin, the only way is through," both women said in unison.

The rest of the crowd joined in. At one point, Sea Hawk played the piano and sang. Mermista reminded him to play music her way - by performing a remix. As the rhythm picked up, everyone began dancing as they sang.

"It's not gonna be easy, but it's our only option," Adora said. "Who's with me?"

"Now's the time to stand!" Glimmer shouted.

Randor held up a sword. "Let's save our home!"

Teela straightened her spine. "At your command!"

Sea Hawk smiled. "I'm in!" He took out his sword. "Adventure!"

Mermista crossed her arms. "Can you not be dramatic?"

Bow frowned. "Who knows if we'll make it back?"

Adora made her way to the door. "We can't hold back in this time of need!"

"We will rise, and we will march tall!" Glimmer said.

After everyone finished the song, they picked up their weapons. Some of them donned suits of armor. Adora and Glimmer stepped outside, holding hands and gazing into each other's eyes. They were ready to take on the biggest challenge together.

"We're going to fight an ancient demon, right?" Glimmer asked. "I hope Horde Prime won't recover too quickly from a spell that's

supposed to weaken him."

"Glim, we're in this together," Adora said.

Glimmer nodded. "We are, for sure."

By noon, everyone stormed the castle. Dozens of black rocks dotted every wall, floor, and window. Cracks ran along the floors and walls; after the battle, the castle would undergo repair. Adora turned around and glanced at Glimmer. Once again, the shorter woman was wearing armor. A staff rested in her girlfriend's right hand. For a minute, she thought of the knights from her favorite stories.

"I'll look for Catra," Adora said.

"Be careful, Starlight," Glimmer replied.

"You be careful, too."

Adora proceeded into an adjacent hallway, scanning every door and archway for any sign of Catra's presence. She hadn't seen the magicat yet. Wouldn't the brunette be lurking in the shadows, waiting to strike? Or did Horde Prime tell her to hide? Sighing, Adora strode toward the end of the corridor.

"Looking for someone?" A deep, smooth voice asked.

Adora whirled around, then narrowed her eyes. A tall man with green eyes stepped forward.

"Much like Mara, you're determined," the man continued. "There is one thing you can't do. You can't save Catra. She works for me."

"Horde Prime, I'll make sure you won't win," Adora said.

"The eclipse is upon us. What are you going to do about it? I'm surprised you haven't given up."

"Well, considering that the fate of the world is at stake, I'm going to keep fighting."

Horde Prime rushed to the door. "You and Catra have some catching up to do. I'll leave you to it. Let me know when you have given up."

Once Horde Prime left, Catra entered the hallway.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said.

"How do your choices make you feel?" Adora asked.

"We've gone over this many times, blondie. I'm not changing my mind! Only I get to decide what I will do and what I won't do. You can't control my life."

"Your head is clouded with anger and hate. Hand over the Moonstone. You're playing right into Horde Prime's plan. He'll destroy everything and everyone. Even you!"

"Forget Horde Prime. Give me the Sundrop!"

Adora unbraided her hair. "I will do whatever it takes to protect everyone. And since you won't listen to me, and are sticking with your choices, I will not hold back!"

Adora and Catra began exchanging blows, caring little for the destruction of vases and the palace structure. Time dragged on as both women tried to gain the upper hand. After a half hour, Catra grabbed Adora's hair.

"You forgot one thing," Catra said. "Turn your enemy's strength into a weakness."

Within seconds, black rocks emerged from Catra's hands and the ground, running along Adora's hair and restricting her movements. Grunting, Adora struggled to break free. The prison wouldn't budge; instead, it ascended toward her room, carrying

her to the balcony. Catra stepped off a platform made of black rocks and hopped onto the balcony.

"The fight is over, Princess," Catra said.

"Why are we here?" Adora retorted.

"I want you to give me the Sundrop."

"Then what, Catra? If you win, what will you do? And if Horde Prime turns against you, will you finally wake up? Have you ever considered such a possibility?"

Catra grimaced. "Why can't you shut up?"

Summoning her power, Adora broke free of the makeshift prison and landed on the balcony. She chased Catra into the room, hoping to catch up to her. Catra summoned a barrier of black rocks.

"For the final time, Catra, I demand you give me the Moonstone Opal!" Adora shouted.

"Like that's gonna happen," Catra retorted.

Adora wrapped her hair around Catra. "It's over."

"I was thinking the same thing." Catra broke free, then launched multiple black rocks at Adora. "Your friends will soon discover how much of a failure you are. The Sundrop is now mine."

The doors slammed open, revealing Horde Prime. He levitated the Moonstone Opal and the Sundrop into the air, snickering as they floated toward him. "They are now mine." He glowered at Catra. "Since I have the power, you are no longer useful. As for you..." He pointed at Adora. "I will finish what I've always wanted to do. Mara and her friends may have hindered me in the past, but unlike them, you don't stand a chance!"

The Sundrop and Moonstone Opal slid onto Horde Prime's forearms; he transformed into a huge demon, cackling as he approached Adora. He grabbed her, restricting her limbs. As he brought her closer to his face, he wore a sadistic grin.

"You will watch in horror as I destroy the world," Prime said.

"Let. Me. Go!" Adora replied, grunting.

Horde Prime tossed Adora toward the door. "I will end everyone you care about."

Glimmer swore she heard Adora screaming at one point as she mounted Swift Wind. Was Horde Prime hurting her girlfriend? Anger boiled her veins as she gripped her staff. As she and the others waited in the courtyard, a crack formed in the tower. No, multiple. At first, a large hand stuck out. Then, a demon slipped out and descended the structure. Horde Prime didn't do anything to Adora, did he?

"Looks like he underwent an unfortunate growth spurt," Glimmer said. "Okay, everyone. You stay away. I'll slow him down with my spells!"

"Can't we help?" Bow asked.

"We're dealing with a demon, not a regular foe." Glimmer traced a rune in the air. "Horde Prime, listen. I will do whatever it takes to keep my Adora safe! So don't even think about hurting her!"

Horde Prime conjured dozens of yellow shards, trapping multiple soldiers. Glimmer rode Swift Wind closer to the demon, then launched the rune. The demon deflected the rune, cackling. She unleashed the same spell, hoping it would succeed. Instead, it didn't sink into him. How was he outsmarting her? How many sorcerers did it once take to stop him? She teleported out of this reality and zipped through another dimension. Before another second passed, she reappeared above Horde Prime, pointing the staff at his face as she attempted a downward strike.

Horde Prime grabbed Glimmer's body, preventing her from completing the blow. "Of course you would try to be the hero! You and your friends will lose. My reign will begin!"

"The entire world will never be yours!" Glimmer retorted.

Horde Prime flung Glimmer toward a mural. "You're wrong!"

Glimmer landed onto her back, groaning in pain as she sat up.

"Wither and decay, end this destiny..." Horde Prime began.

"No..." Glimmer whispered.

"I've got to stop Horde Prime," Adora said, pacing back and forth.

"I don't think you can," Catra replied.

"What do you mean?"

"It's too late. All of this is my fault. I've been so focused on getting people to respect me and quit casting me aside, that I hurt everyone. And now we'll lose everything. You were right. Everyone's right."

Adora wasn't sure what to think. Was Catra truly coming to her senses, or was the magicat saying all this because of the current situation? As she watched tears stream down Catra's face, a small part of her wanted to forgive her. At the same time, this could be a facade.

"Adora, I am so sorry for everything!" Catra finished.

Adora pulled Catra into a hug. "Catra... I forgive you."

"I don't deserve forgiveness."

Adora detected small blue sparks in Catra's chest. "What's that?"

Catra pointed to the sparks. "This?" She took out a tiny shard of the Moonstone Opal.

"So, conversations aside, we better put an end to all this." Adora placed her finger onto the shard; a golden glow illuminated the room. "Are you joining me?"

"You can use the power to defeat Horde Prime. And you must get a move on."

Adora raced out of the castle, not wasting any time. A gasp escaped her lips as she scrutinized the area. The sky was red, and everyone was comatose. "Horde Prime! What have you done to those I love? To the world?"

Horde Prime whirled around. "I'm surprised you haven't given up."

Adora swung her hair at Horde Prime, slamming his face. As he rubbed his cheek, she tossed her hair at his horn; the blonde strands looped around it. She leaped into the air and crossed the ground to the other side of the courtyard. As she landed near Glimmer, her heart froze. She descended to her knees and caressed the shorter woman's cheek.

"Glitter-bug?" Adora whispered.

Glimmer's eyes fluttered open. "Starlight... you're okay..."

"I'll take care of this." Adora gathered all her hair into her arms as she looked up. "Horde Prime, you won't get away with your wicked plan."

Horde Prime scowled. "Do you think you can stand up to my power?"

Ten minutes whizzed by as Adora evaded the incoming blows. Each time she thought she had an opening, Horde Prime would prove her wrong. A yellow shard appeared in front of her; turning around, she balled her hands into fists.

"And now the sun sets - ow!" Horde Prime fell forward, unconscious.

Catra stood on Horde Prime's head, admiring a frying pan. "Frying pans... who knew?" She rushed to Horde Prime's left hand. "Quick, blondie! Get the other hand! We're merging the stones together!"

Adora began pushing Horde Prime's other hand. "Take my hand, Cat." She reached out for Catra's hand.

As the two women shoved both wrists closer, Horde Prime's eyes opened. He rose to his height, roaring. Adora tossed her hair at one of his wrists; Catra grabbed the rest of the blonde strands and looped it around the other wrist. Both women hurried in opposite directions, forcing him to fall onto his back.

"Ready?" Catra said as she kicked a yellow shard in Adora's direction.

"Yes!" Adora replied, catching the shard. She pressed it into her hair, slicing every strand.

Horde Prime's wrists collided; a light exploded from the two gems, consuming him and every black rock in the vicinity. A bright flash penetrated the air, chasing away the red sky. Adora let out a sigh of relief as she watched the Sundrop and Moonstone Opal merge. There was no Horde Prime in sight, and no black rock to see. She did it; she saved everyone.

"Glimmer? Catra?" Adora called out, glancing around. Despite what she did, everyone remained comatose. Did she do something wrong?

An idea formed in Adora's mind. The healing incantation. She could use it again. Snatching the merged stones, she took a deep breath and began singing.

Flower, gleam and glow

Let your power shine

Make the clock reverse

Bring back what once was mine

What once was mine

After Adora was done, she launched the Sundrop and Moonstone into the sky. Both stones would be in space, hopefully for eternity. She collapsed onto her back, exhausted from the excess release of such power. Footsteps approached; Glimmer's face appeared in her vision.

"You did it, Starlight," Glimmer said.

"Catra and I both did," Adora replied.

"Catra?"

"You heard me correctly. She has a change of heart."

Glimmer helped Adora up, then drew her into an embrace. "How did I end up with the most awesome girlfriend in the world?"

"Fate. Destiny. Call it what we will," Adora said.

And they kissed.

Happily Ever After

Chapter Summary

Adora and Glimmer get a happy ending.

For the rest of the year, every kingdom rebuilt broken structures and villages shattered by black rocks. Catra helped Grayskull and Bright Moon rebuild, as a way to make it up to those she hurt. Eventually, she bid farewell to Adora and Glimmer, then went on an adventure. Bow and Perfuma tied the knot in an outdoor ceremony in Plumeria. Later on, Adam and Teela got married; everyone in the kingdom attended the ceremony. King Randor and Queen Marlena mentioned the possibility of retiring soon and letting either Adam or Adora take the throne.

One evening, after Glimmer's coronation, she took Adora out on a date. They sat near the entrance to the woods, gazing at the starlit sky. A moment later, they made eye contact. Tonight, Adora wore a white tunic with gold accents. Her leggings were the color of the bright blue sky. As of recent, Adora had started wearing a "braided headband" hairstyle to make up for the lack of length. Glimmer considered it an adorable style.

Tonight, Glimmer wore a lavender gown, and she had brushed all her hair to one side of her face. A tiara, which once belonged to her mother, rested on her head. She thought of the conversation with Adora earlier today. The blonde had told her that Queen Angella would be so proud. Adora's words had warmed her heart.

"I have a surprise for you," Glimmer said.

"A surprise?" Adora asked.

"Well, it's more of a question. Considering everything we've gone through, I waited until the world was not in danger." Glimmer took a cupcake out of the basket and handed it to her girlfriend. "Take the cherry off."

"What am I supposed to find?" Adora grabbed the cupcake, then took off the cherry, revealing a ring. "Oh... what's this?"

"Adora, ever since I laid my eyes on you, I've fallen in love. You're the best thing that has ever happened to me, and I love you so much."

"Are you proposing?"

"Of course. Starlight... will you marry me?"

Adora smiled. "I considered asking you the same question. And yes, I'll marry you."

Glimmer grabbed the ring, then pressed it onto Adora's finger. "I can't wait to spend the rest of my life with you."

The following year, on their wedding, all their friends attended. Adora and Glimmer exchanged their vows. As the afternoon approached, they proceeded to dance in the ballroom. Everyone watched as they swayed to the music.

"You know, a lot has happened since the day I left the tower," Adora said. "Fate brought us together. A year ago, I was a naive girl in the tower."

"And now you're here with me," Glimmer replied.

"I mean, if it wasn't for you finding me in the tower, I would never have met my real family and explored the world. To be honest, I enjoyed our adventures together."

"Same. Sometimes, I still think about what could have happened to you during that battle. Those thoughts even showed up in my dreams. But I would remind myself that you're still alive, and the world is safe. Most importantly, you're safe and sound."

"I've had similar nightmares about that day." Adora released a soft sigh. "I could have lost you. But, you're here, and..."

"It was awesome when you defeated Horde Prime for good. You're so brave."

"You're brave, too." Adora leaned in, her breath mingling with Glimmer's.

Glimmer's lips brushed Adora's, and they shared a passionate kiss.

And they lived happily ever after.

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